

arnica butler  
*Liquid  
Kitty*



Thirteenth Line Publications



**LIQUID KITTY**  
**A Wife-Sharing Romance**  
By Arnica Butler

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## ***Thank You***

*It would be impossible to write quality books in a niche genre like hotwife, at the pace I do, without the help of beta readers, who do the thankless work of editors for even less than peanuts. Thank all of you, so much, for your help, keen eyes, and suggestions.*

*And as always, thanks to my readers and fans. Enjoy!*

# CHAPTER 1

I didn't like the idea at first. Not at all.

About six months ago, it had looked like I was going to be out of a job: corporate was restructuring, new rules were coming down from them and from outside pressures, plus some changes to state law were going to eat my department alive.

It couldn't have happened at a worse time. Lynn was finishing up school, she had about \$100K worth of debt and a monster student loan payment coming up. We had just bought an expensive condo, a new car, and we were going to be royally screwed.

Lynn couldn't find any work in her field, which was not a real wonder because she studied linguistics. Everything she found in academia was temporary, far away, or barely related to her actual studies.

Her stepbrother – a real shady piece of work named Jessie - had a “stake” in a strip club called Liquid Kitty (some kind of vaguely legal connection to his vaguely *illegal* goings-on), and he suggested she wait tables there.

Liquid Kitty was the classiest strip club in town, with the cleverest name, though to tell the truth, I was never sure if half the numbskulls in that place even got it. The girls were gorgeous: long-limbed, young, pretty faces, and expensive-looking upkeep. Pretty nails, perfect hair, glowing skin. A nice variety of blondes, redheads, and raven-maned vixens, along with some adorable Asians, really hot and terrifying light-skinned black girls, and a Latina named Alicia who could do her entire performance upside-down if asked. It was clean, upscale, and popular, but at the end of the day, it was still a *strip club*.

So imagine my utter surprise when Lynn – pretty, clean-cut, academic Lynn – actually gave it some serious thought.

She convinced me that she'd worked out a deal whereby she didn't have to strip, and in fact a lot of the girls were happy about that because they didn't want the competition.

All she was going to do was wait tables in a sexy suit.

“Just tell me,” I remember saying, “what made you want to wait tables at a strip joint all of a sudden?”

“They make like \$300-\$500 a night in tips there,” she told me.

“The waitresses?” I remarked cynically.

I didn’t believe it for a minute. You know how everyone inflates every single thing they talk about with money, to the point it’s not even possible to know what’s going on? People owe \$50K in taxes! They paid \$7,000 for this watch! They got a \$10,000 raise! They made \$12,000 a minute when they were waiting tables at Chez Bianca!

“Honey,” I remember saying. “There’s no way you can make that much money bringing people *drinks*.”

Lynn’s whole face changed. Her eyelids slowly covered her eyes, and then floated up, and her mouth – ordinarily a plump, split tomato, bee-stung and ripe, hardened into a thinning line. She folded her arms over her chest. “Oh I can’t? Is that a fact?”

It’s important to mention here that Lynn has a hair-trigger for certain things, like being challenged. I really *wasn’t* saying *she* couldn’t make \$300 a night bringing people drinks, I was just saying that *one* couldn’t do that.

As in, any one person.

But Lynn, of course, took it as a challenge.

Which is never, *ever*, a good thing with Lynn. Oddly enough, she would deny being competitive, which is one of the most charming things about her.

I tried to clarify: “I’m not saying *you*, personally, can’t make that much, just that no one makes that much...”

I trailed off. I didn’t want to say, “without sucking cock.”

But... come on.

Lynn was already leaving the room, one hand up in the air with her palm facing me.

“Lynn,” I had pleaded, but I didn’t work too hard at it, because once Lynn gives you the hand, your chances of winning the argument or influencing what she does are over.

“I just don’t think a strip club is the best place to work,” I said, following her down the hall, trying a new tactic anyway.

She flipped her hair around as she entered the kitchen. It was a shimmery curtain of Asian-straight golden-brown, and fell sexily across her

face. With her flared nostrils, her wild eyes, and the creep of pink making its way across her high cheekbones, she was *hot*.

“Look,” she said, suddenly serious. “I know it isn’t. But if I can grab some quick cash and pay the bills while you look for a new job, then I can quit when you find one, and go back to job-hunting, without us having to go into debt or have... all that *stress*.”

This sort of deflated my... er, mood. Nobody likes being told their wife is going to work at a strip club because they can’t bring home the bacon.

“Why don’t you just defer your student loans,” I said. “And then pick them -”

“Because I’m not a loser,” Lynn snapped. “*And* I don’t want to. Listen. Let me just see how it goes. It’s not like I’m stripping, or I’m going to run off and start doing coke and making out with guys. It’s strictly for the money and Jessie knows that. I go in, I wait tables, I collect my money – for *waiting tables* – and I’m out.”

I frowned. There was a certain appeal to her working at a strip club, one I couldn’t quite put my finger on.

I also didn’t like it much.

I felt obligated, furthermore, to really *insist* on her not doing it. That seemed like the right thing to do.

“Why don’t you just do that at a respectable restaurant?” I asked.

She glowered at me. “Because you don’t make \$500 a night at a respectable restaurant.”

I rolled my eyes. “My point exactly.”

Lynn’s nose, which was ordinarily a very petite, oddly beautiful box-edged little thing, was changing shape with her angry nose-breathing. Her fingers clawed into her biceps.

“You’re not going to make \$500 a night just waiting tables, even if it’s at a strip club,” I continued.

By saying that, I pretty much guaranteed that she was going to work at Liquid Kitty.

Liquid Kitty. Once a club-club with dancers in cages, now a strip club, the place was famous around town. Not that I thought a lot of people we knew would be going there, but it still gave me a queasy feeling to think about my wife waiting tables in a club with that sort of... *reputation*.

I decided, after Lynn flipped her hair around in a wild turn, whipping it across my chest, and then slammed the door to the bedroom when she got there, that maybe it wouldn't be so bad. Places get reputations, and they're almost always exaggerated. Like the earnings from waiting tables at Liquid Kitty, Liquid Kitty's reputation for girls lined up on their knees to give blow jobs was almost *certainly* overblown.

It didn't matter what I thought about it, though, because Lynn was going to do it.

The first night she worked, she made \$120.

I refrained from saying "I told you so."

In the bathroom, she pushed her hair from her face in the mirror and stared herself down, with a look that I know so well: Lynn's determined expression. Like I mentioned, she has a really competitive streak in her, and so if someone told her she could make \$300 a night, she was going to make \$300 a night.

The next night she worked, she made \$200.

But the third night she worked, she came home with a glow on her face.

She had changed back into her regular clothes the previous two nights, so I had still not seen the Liquid Kitty uniform. That night, she had wrapped herself up in a longer coat that came to her knees, but she stripped it off as soon as she walked in the door.

She was clad in the standard Liquid Kitty work uniform: an ultra-short black skirt, barely reaching her upper thigh, swooping low on her waist, clinging in slight dip to reveal her hip bones. Her midriff was bare until just below her breasts, where criss-crossing strips of the same black fabric (some kind of faux leather) encased her medium-sized, very spherical breasts. She had a very well-rounded bottom, out of which protruded the standard Liquid Kitty tail, silver and un-cat like, matching the silver kitty ears protruding from the headband in her long, silky brown hair. I took in the fishnet stockings, the tight, strappy dress in a trashy plastic material, the bare midriff, the patch of thigh between the hem of her skirt and the stockings. My cock swelled. "Nice outfit," I said.

Lynn's glow did not flicker. She smiled, and walked toward me sexily. "Guess, how much, money, I made," she said, and I stared at her mouth, at her bright red lips. Her hair was down, wavy from sweat and



moisture, giving her a tousled, romp-in-the-bed look. But her red lips gave her a frosting of trashiness that I had never seen on her before. It was oddly alluring, and very disconcerting.

She pulled the money from her bra, like a real pro, and waved it in the air.

Then she laughed, seeing that I was confused, and not very impressed. "It's not super impressive like this," she said, "because I changed all the fives and ones in for hundreds."

I raised my eyebrows.

"Four hundred and forty-five dollars!" she yelled.

I stared at her.

"Waiting tables," I said incredulously, as a hot wave of possessive jealousy traveled over my skin. My cock was rock-hard, my heart was racing. I was incredibly angry, incredibly ready to fuck.

"No," she said sarcastically. "I sucked all the cocks in the place."

I could feel my face getting red. I wasn't entirely sure what emotion was overtaking me.

"Of course just waiting tables," she said, dropping the money on the counter.

I tried to get control of myself, and fingered the filthy strip-club cash. "So what'd you do different?"

"What?" she asked, batting her eyes coyly.

"How'd you make so much money tonight? Compared to yesterday? And the day before?"

Lynn walked over to me, and put her hands on my knees. She had a grin on her face: she was enjoying fucking with me. I don't know if she knew that my cock was hard, that I was having a side fantasy about throwing her over the counter and fucking her blind, giving her a smack on the ass for good measure. She ran her tongue on her upper lip. "How'd I do it?" she asked throatily.

Her hand moved up my thigh, and her mouth teased me as her lips remained poised to tell me her secret. All the while, I wasn't sure who the hell she was.

Her fingers made it to my mid-thigh, and she grinned again. "The oldest trick in the book," she said, almost in a whisper.

My cock pulsed again.

She leaned in close.

“It’s Friday.”

So basically, at Liquid Kitty, it *was* entirely possible to legitimately wait tables (albeit in a hooker costume) and make \$300-\$500 a night on a weekend night.

I stood corrected.

But Lynn’s little act that night had started something brewing inside of me.

It wasn’t exactly jealousy, and it wasn’t exactly pure arousal. It was just a bug, a bug I couldn’t shake. I started thinking about Lynn with other men *all the time*.

At first, the fantasy was confined to thinking about Lynn flirting with other men. Because legitimate waitressing or not, she *had* to be flirting a little if she was making tips at that place.

I started to wonder if she maybe let guys touch her. A quick hand under her skirt, a brush across her knee. Maybe they would walk their hand along the inside of her thigh as she stood there taking drink orders, and brush their fingertips over her panties.

We started having some pretty hot sex, and I wasn’t sure if it had changed in my mind alone, or also in hers. But it was definitely caused by her new job, because there was a definite difference between sex before and after Liquid Kitty.

I would swear that Lynn was more into it than she had been in a long time.

“So,” I would say, when she came home from work (and I started waiting up on Friday nights, thinking about what she was doing all night, imagining her getting closer and closer to crossing the line). “How much did you make tonight?”

Lynn was having fun with it. She started leaving her uniform on, peeling away a coat with a sexy stripper-move. Doing a little dance. “I made *so* much money tonight,” she’d say.

One night she climbed onto my lap, her thighs tight against mine, straddling me. Her mound brushed over my hard cock, and she smiled. She put her fingers in my hair, and rolled her breasts toward my face, her butt firm against my palm. “The rules are, I get to touch you, but you can’t touch me,” she said.

I dropped my hands and gripped the rungs of the chair, as she rolled her tits closer to my face, her butt following in an s-curve, her thighs gloriously toned and tight near my lap, partially wrapped in fishnets. She did some magical move, in which the mound at the center of her hiked-up skirt brushed harder with each undulation against my throbbing cock.

“Ah ha,” I said raggedly, watching her fishnet thighs and the dark center of her panties as they rolled rhythmically over my lap. “So *this* is how you make such good tips.”

Lynn ran her fingers through my hair like she had never done before, raking her fingernails on my scalp and sending the thrill straight to my dick. Her pert breasts were just below my mouth, my breath was hot on them, and it was all I could do not to bite her nipple through the plastic of her dress.

She tossed her long mane of hair over her shoulder and squeezed my legs as she let go of my shoulder and head to run her hands along her own torso, leaning back, all her muscles controlled, her mound grinding against my cock. “And what if it is?” she warbled. Her mound ground harder against me and her eyes dropped to my bulging cock under my pants. “You don’t seem to mind.”

Her voice had an accent suddenly. A very good one, Eastern European sounding. She smiled at me. “This girl at work taught me that. Men love a good Russian accent.”

She drew her hand across her lips, and bit into her finger. “My name is Lidiya,” she said, gargling the consonants in the back of her throat.

My hands flew to her waist, and she feigned shock. “No, no,” she said, shaking her head, her accent getting stronger. “You’re not allowed to touch. These are the rules, and you must following them.”

I dropped my hands, willing to play along as long as this was going somewhere. Lynn smiled, and rolled her body a few more times to tease me. Then she stepped off of me, and walked over to the cabinet where we kept the booze. “What do you want to drink?” she asked me.

I appraised her bottom in the tight costume, the length of her legs as she reached up for some glasses from the top shelf – a deliberate act to show me her thigh, because there were identical glasses on the lower shelves. She had a whiskey bottle in her hands, and she didn’t wait for my reply. My ears were ringing, I was so heated up, and I wasn’t sure if that was the end of her performance or not.

She set the glasses on the table and walked around it again, crawling back up onto my lap.

I had never seen her behave like this, so I just let her do whatever she wanted. She squeezed my thighs between hers, rose up, leaned forward, and shoved her breasts in my face as she poured the drinks behind me.

Then she sat down on my lap again, handed me a glass, and clinked hers against mine. “And *that’s*,” she declared, her voice normal again, “how you make \$500 a night waiting tables.”

I slammed my whiskey, set the glass down, and grabbed her by the hips. “You don’t actually do that,” I said.

She shrugged, still holding the whiskey. “What if I do?”

I stood up, lifting her by the hips, and she squealed delightfully. She dropped her feet to the floor, and the whiskey glass fell out of her hand shortly afterward, breaking into a million pieces. I walked her out of the kitchen and into the living room (my feet were bare, I’m not crazy) and pushed her up against a wall.

“You seem very, very good at that sort of act,” I said, pushing the bottom of her skirt up, feeling for her panties. When I found them they were wet to the touch. I hooked a finger under the fabric and explored her sloppy-wet folds. She was wildly turned on; I could smell her tangy scent from there.

I had a sudden, terrible and arousing thought, that my fingers were deep in her pussy juices but that she had already come earlier that night, after some lucky patron had talked her into letting him lick her to a frenzy in the bathroom.

Or was there more?

Lynn closed her eyes as my fingers dipped inside of her, and my thumb pushed on her clit, making her shudder.

“You like that? Grinding on strange, dirty men at a strip club?” I breathed into her ear.

I couldn’t help adding: “Like a little whore?”

I had three fingers inside her wet cunt, and her muscles closed around me in a spasm. Her mouth was open, her dark-shadowed eyes half-closed. There in the darkness, pushed up against the wall, she didn’t look anything like my wife.

She didn’t answer, but she didn’t need to. Her hands came down between her legs, pushing my sweatpants with them and freeing my cock.

She took me with both hands and squeezed, grinning when she felt that I was dripping pre-cum, hard as a rock. She pulled me toward her, sliding my cock along my wrist, fingers deep inside of her.

I pulled my hand out and sheathed my cock in her soaked pussy. Her eyes closed, her mouth opened, and she mewled like a dirty whore.

And a new game was born.

## CHAPTER 2

This went on for a while, with Lynn coming home to tell me about how she had made so much money that night, and then acting out her pursuits. It was a fiction, of course – she told me, after we rutted like animals on the couch, the bed, in the shower, in the kitchen, wherever – that she had waited tables, nothing more, and her only weapon was her Russian accent and her fake name.

The game was fun, but it began to turn reality on its head. I started to ask her for details about these guys she danced for, forgetting momentarily that she wasn't dancing for them.

And Lynn, to my frightened and delighted surprise, had no end of ideas, no end of "lies" to pour from her lips.

"Tonight I got a hundred dollar tip from this man," she said one night, "who was all muscles and still sweaty from his job, dirt caked on his neck and his elbows.... but I could tell..." and here she emphasized her point by pushing her pussy against my own hard cock, "that he had a huge, thick cock, and he knew how to use it."

"You're just teasing me about all this, right?" I asked her, playing with her hair as she lay on my chest after a particularly robust session of lovemaking, during which she'd let me fuck her from behind while she claimed to think about how big some other guy's cock was. This had been my request, but she had thrown herself into the act so believably that I was now feeling a little nervous.

Lynn propped herself up on one elbow, leaning on my chest, and laughed. "Are you serious?" she said. "Of course I'm just teasing."

She lay back down, giving a derisive huff, as if I'd asked the stupidest question in the world.

Which made something flare inside of me.

"It's just... you're awfully good at just coming up with details, out of nowhere."

Lynn tapped her fingers on my chest. "I'm smart," she said. Her hand slid down my chest, over my hips, right to my cock, bringing me back to life even though I really preferred to have this discussion first.

"And I don't hear you complaining..." she said breathlessly.

I tried to keep my concentration off her hand on my shaft, and *on* my... whatever I had meant to talk about.

Lynn – who seemed to be more like Lidiya at that moment – kept her eyes on mine as she brushed her lips down my torso and over my pelvis. Her silky chin rubbed my cock from base to tip as her head moved further down. When the crown of my dick popped out from under her chin, she grinned at me before catching it in her mouth, bringing her hand to the base of my cock only after her lips had closed around the head.

All the while, Lynn had her eyes on me, giving me the eye contact I had always craved when she gave me head. It was this sort of thing that I loved, but found disturbing: Lynn slurping on my cock, her throat purring with moans of pleasure that vibrated all the way to the root of my shaft. Don't get me wrong, it was great, which is why I bent into half a sit-up and grasped her hair and panted as she sucked me off, instead of asking questions, even while my abdomen roiled with a disturbed sensation, something dark and cold.

There was something unnerving that I didn't want to touch on about how Lynn's Russian accent lasted longer and longer into the night, past the foreplay, into our lovemaking. And with the Russian accent, her alter-persona stayed as well: she was more Lidiya than Lynn; less my wife, and more like a Russian slut who worked at a strip club as a waitress while... what? Turning tricks on the side?

How much of what she said was a joke? And what was with the change in her, the new hunger for sucking on my cock?

That particular night, Lynn met my eyes as her tongue swirled around my shaft and then she sucked like a vacuum cleaner all the way to the tip of my dick before swallowing me in her wet hot mouth all the way to the base. She did this again and again while I agonized, trying not to come too soon, finally giving up and throwing my head back just as my cock exploded in her mouth. I reached futilely for her hair, because I knew she wasn't usually up for swallowing my cum, and when I couldn't grasp it, I looked back at her.

Her smokey eyes were hovering just an inch from my pubic bone, hairs at her nostrils. Her eyes were watering as the spurts of cum left my dick, all the way at the back of her throat. With each spurt, her eyes blinked quickly as she struggled to swallow every last drop.

I stared at my wife, not recognizing her, as she sucked hard all the way along the length of my dick and released my cock with a pop. A dribble of white cum and saliva rolled off her lower lip, and she used a finger to wipe it back into her mouth, sucking at her own fingertip like she had just sucked on my cock.

She swung a leg over me to straddle me at mid-thigh, and rose up on her knees, smiling. Her fingers traveled down my chest and she said, in a thick Russian accent: “You like that?”

Her free hand was directing my cock toward the lips of her pussy, it throbbed in her hand. I was too sore to have her ride me, and I looked down with alarm. But her intention was only to rub the crown of my dick between her soaked lips, over the swollen nub of her clit, with her pussy sloshing loudly, until she threw her own head back and shuddered with an orgasm, moaning softly from the back of her cum-coated throat.

She had a firm grip on my cock, which was coming back to life – to no one’s greater surprise than mine. I stared at her hand, at her magnificent breasts thrust forward, the sheen of sweat coating her body, and then at her mouth as she tilted slowly back toward me and stared at me with an unrecognizable expression on her face.

“That was hot,” I said.

She slapped me playfully. “But...?”

She had heard the “but” in my voice. She rolled off me and lay on her back, stretching her arms above her head.

I rolled on my side. But what, indeed? What the hell was I complaining about? My wife was hot as hell in the sack now, and the only thing I had to come to terms with was that she was working at a strip club as a waitress.

I stroked her along the vague line of muscle in the center of her firm abdomen. “It’s just that... you seem like a different person sometimes.”

Her eyes went wide, as did her mouth, as she turned to me disbelievingly. “Oh, God. You aren’t *serious*, are you?”

Serious about what? What was I even saying?

I shrugged. “I don’t know. It’s just... with the stories, and the late nights, and the... the accent...” I floundered. What *was* I saying?

“Rick,” she said, almost laughing at me. She put a hand on my chest. “This is all just a game, you know that, right?”



“Yeah, of course, sure,” I said. I tried to play it off like I really believed I was being as stupid as she evidently thought I was.

This was a hard act to maintain, because it was complicated by the pangs of desire inside of me to find out she *wasn't* just playing. I didn't really understand that at the time. Which is why, when she said the following:

“Look. If you're really that worried about it, just come to the club one night. And then you'll see how it is. You can even hold my tips for me and see how they pile up, how I get them for just *waiting tables*.”

She turned to me. “I can't believe you think I'd *do* anything else like that!”

I shook my head and rubbed my face. “I'm sorry,” I said. “I just... you sound so authentic.”

“Thees is ghow I get big tip,” she said, laying her accent on so thick it sounded comical.

I laughed for her.

But unease still writhed deep in my gut.

\*

I had been to strip clubs before, but each and every time it had been because I was dragged there by some guy friends in a big group.

This is not to say that I had no interest in strip clubs – it was a good enough time, and I enjoy a nice view of naked women as much as the next guy. But I had eyes for Lynn, and no real interest in paying a ton of money for lap dances from girls who always seemed a little over-powdered, over-made-upped, and trashy beyond appeal.

The idea of going by myself was a little daunting. I'd seen all those creepy-looking guys, single and sullen, eating pretzels and letting them fall into their unkempt beards while they stared at the ladies on stage.

When I told Lynn I didn't want to look like that, she rolled her eyes.

“So bring someone with you, then,” she said, turning her kitty costume inside out to iron it, which I couldn't see the point of given that it seemed to be made of plastic and stretch to fit.

I laughed. “Like who?”

I had some friends I could immediately think of – old buddies from college, back East, who'd moved out here as well. They were my

adolescent friends, who I didn't really want to spend that much time with, because, frankly, they were kind of dicks.

She looked up at me. "I don't know. A friend. Ethan. He likes strip clubs."

Lynn didn't care much for Ethan, who was just such an old friend from back East. She had certainly hit the nail on the head with him: he *did* like strip clubs.

The only problem was...

"You don't mind if Ethan, I don't know... sees you there?"

Lynn looked at me and shrugged. "Why?" Then a grin curled up her lips. "It's not like Ethan's some class act I'm trying to impress. He'd probably get off on it."

I felt a peculiar pang swell in my crotch.

"Yeah, just... I mean, if you don't mind..."

Lynn shook her dress back right side-out. "Why would I care about this? I'm just waiting tables. The money is great. It's not like I work at Hooters or something."

I made a face to indicate that I had no idea what she meant by that.

She laughed. "I don't know. Something about making \$500 a night makes it not so cheap shaking my ass, you know? So invite whoever. God, especially if it's Ethan, I hate that guy already anyway." She smiled. "Just don't invite, like... my mom or something."

I wasn't sure how I felt about this. Or which of my friends I wanted to invite, which ones I was cool with knowing that Lynn was an ultra-hot waitress at Liquid Kitty. It was a confusing situation: I both wanted everyone to know, to see how hot she looked, to maybe even be overwhelmed by her – and I also *didn't* want anyone to know.

Or get any ideas.

"You know I think I may have seen Ethan there anyway," Lynn said, in an offhand way.

She looked at me. "I didn't say *hi* or anything," she said, smirking.

I finally settled on asking Ethan to go, and then for some reason I didn't tell *him* that Lynn was working there.

Ethan was not the kind of guy to think very hard about why a friend of his wanted to go to a strip club all the sudden, so he didn't bat an eye or ask any questions. You'd think he'd have wondered why I was setting it up in advance, ask me if it was my birthday, anything.

But all he said was: “Sure thing, buddy.”

## CHAPTER 3

Ethan ended up inviting his friend Burke, who I kind of knew, and Burke's girlfriend Jen, who was a pretty, white-blond girl who looked a little too young for him and like *she* maybe worked at Liquid Kitty. Then our friend Chris got wind of our excursion, and in a way typical of Chris, he decided to make it an excursion and invite a bunch of people.

Fortunately, only five of them could make it (Burke, Ethan, Chris, some friend of Chris's named Steve, and Jen) but it was still too big of a group for my liking, considering that my wife was going to be strutting around in that slinky outfit and possibly serving them drinks.

"Guys," I said, over my steak at Jerry's Smokehouse, "how would you feel about changing the venue? Liquid Kitty's kinda pricey for me."

"To what?" Ethan said dubiously. "Nah, man, if we're going out to see some ladies, I want them to be classy."

Then, to my horror, he said:

"I don't even like the ladies so much, as those little waitresses in the kitty costumes."

My heart stopped beating and I stared at him. He made a face at me, and then continued eating his steak. I wondered if he knew that Lynn worked there, and if he was just fucking with me.

Or worse yet, was Lynn fucking with me?

And so, with anxiety dragging my heart down through my feet, we finished our steaks and headed over to Liquid Kitty, in a minivan cab (classy). I had tried to drown my dread in beer, and then, deciding it wasn't enough to kick my anxiety, in shots of vodka.

Everybody was boisterous in the cab, drunk and amped up about the strip club. I was sullen, sorely regretting my decision, and wishing I was headed there alone after all. I *was* looking forward to watching my wife wait tables, seeing for myself that she simply fetched drinks with a sultry outfit and a Russian accent. To see that nothing more was going on.

But strangely, when I thought about seeing that for myself, I also felt a little pang of disappointment. Almost like I was looking forward to seeing her do something else, something *bad*, something more like the stories she told me.

And now I was stuck with these knuckleheads, who were acting like frat boys, and they were going to give me no end of shit when they found out Lynn was working there.

And yet... there was also a strange appeal to all these guys seeing my wife there.

We piled out of the car, and the guys went to stand in line. Lynn had given me VIP passes, but only for three people, so I walked over to talk to the bouncer about what could be done. He was a fearsomely large black man who looked at me blankly and then crossed his arms (as best as he could) over his enormous heft. "You know who?"

"Lynn. Vistke. She's a waitress."

He was already shaking his head.

A hot panic started to crawl across my face when I remembered. "She goes by Lidiya," I almost shouted.

"Oh *Lidiya*," the guy said, his whole demeanor changing suddenly. He hefted himself up to unhook the velvet rope. "Yeah, she told me you'd be coming."

"I have five people with me."

"That's cool, that's cool," the bouncer said.

I felt like a real big-shot, at least, getting waived into the club when there was an expansive line out the back.

Ethan was impressed, which rarely happened. "Wow. *VIP*. What happened, you fall off a chair and get a settlement or something?" But he punched me in the shoulder like he approved, and we strolled into Liquid Kitty on a Friday like big-shots.

Ethan is a strip club pro, so he had stopped a waitress already and was working his magic on her. Ethan's from Maryland, a country-South kind of guy, and he has an inexplicable charm with the ladies.

Well, *some* ladies. I should clarify that "some" means strippers, cheerleaders, girls with low self-esteem, and recently divorced women, who all seem to really respond to whatever he does.

Whatever he did, it scored us a table up close to the stage. The place was crowded with a lot of young, well-dressed men, and quite a few women, most of whom seemed to be there because it hadn't been worth arguing about.

The waitress Ethan had flirted with was a petite blonde, whose name, I was privy to know, was Annie, but who went by Bridgette. She was a tiny

thing, and I could already see that Ethan had designs on picking her up (literally) and carrying her around the place by the end of the evening.

It was against the rules and no one else could get away with it, but this was the sort of thing Ethan did well.

He plopped into a high-backed chair and lured the waitress toward him while the rest of us got settled. Burke was frowning, but he always did that.

His girlfriend Jen seemed only mildly uncomfortable. She was staring at the stage, where a pair of very limber Asian girls, who looked like twins but probably weren't, were doing a routine with fuzzy handcuffs on and not much but the pole between their gyrating lean bodies. When they came together at the crest of a wave of their torsos, their dark, tiny nipples brushed against each other.

Steve was watching with a big grin on his face.

But I was looking around for my wife. The music was so loud I felt like it was affecting my vision. All three stages were alive with pretty girls doing their best routines, the floor was hot with a lot of male energy filling the air, and hoots and catcalls could be heard over the steady bass beat.

I couldn't see her anywhere. There were three waitresses weaving through the tables, and one standing by the bar. But none of them with long brown hair.

I got my phone out, wondering if maybe she'd gone home sick. There were no messages so I sent her one to tell her I was there, though it didn't seem possible for her to put a phone in that getup. There was barely enough room for her money in the little pouch, edged with silver and in the shape of a cat, which dangled on her side so the view of her ass and tits wouldn't be interrupted.

"I ordered us shots!" Ethan screamed at me, leaning forward. His eyes were quickly swept away by the Asians on stage.

"That waitress is hot!" Steve yelled in my ear.

I nodded absently, assuming he was talking about the little pixie Ethan had been hitting on. I was still scanning the room, looking for Lynn, not finding her.

A few things went through my mind as I watched the crowd. One was that it was much larger, and younger, than I had envisioned. There were a lot of good-looking guys in expensive suits flirting with the waitresses and the strippers who had come out to do lap dances and mingle.

I watched how they interacted with the waitresses, and while I didn't specifically see anyone touching each other, it wasn't exactly impossible to imagine. The tables were crowded close together, the girls weren't wearing much more clothing than the strippers, the bouncers couldn't possibly police everything, and the waitresses were hot and pliant. By pliant I mean: they were all leaning close, putting hands on shoulders and chests, smiling and flirting almost as shamelessly as the lap-dancing strippers.

The Asian duo left the stage and a new set of girls came on – three blondes on each of the stages. I tried to relax, but I couldn't help checking my phone compulsively and scanning the room for Lynn. The guys settled into watching the stage, talking to Jen, and generally being typical attendees of a strip club: lascivious, wide-eyed, and frat-boy silly.

In the corner of my eye, I saw the small frame of the pixie waitress, her lean arms setting down drinks, her lithe body bobbing up and down a little to get to the tables without overturning her tray.

And then I heard it:

“Hey boys.”

Something warm caressed my shoulder, and I jerked my head up to see a collage of red, bee-stung lips, dark bedroom eyelids over sea-green eyes, and plastic-wrapped breasts bulging from a rock-solid abdomen. A flash of shoulder-length platinum hair confused me: everything was Lynn except the hair.

She smiled at me, and I stared back at her. Then she winked, nudging a fishnet-clad leg against my torso. She leaned over, and the platinum hair fell across my face, plastic and inhuman.

A wig.

“What is this?” she said, in her Lidiya-voice. “You don't even say hello to wife?”

Her breath was warm on my earlobe, and she raked her fingers lightly down the back of my neck before standing up again, leaning slightly on my shoulder.

Steve was holding a shot glass in his hand, in midair, his mouth slightly open in surprise.

Steve knew Lynn (as my wife), but he'd only met her a few times and briefly.

I could tell his look of surprise was not because my wife worked at a strip club, but because he couldn't understand why a woman that hot had

singled me out to talk dirty in my ear.

He shook his head and downed the shot.

Lynn leaned across the table and picked the glass up. By now she had caught Ethan's attention, and even though I wasn't looking at him, I could see that his eyes were traveling up and down my wife's body. She was leaning in a provocative pose, her breasts displayed to Steve through the webbing of her dress. "You want other shot, cowboy?" she asked.

Steve grinned almost sheepishly; I still couldn't tell if he had recognized her or not. I tugged on her arm and she leaned down toward me, as though I were a regular customer. "What's with the hair?" I shouted.

She gave it a shake. "You like it? One of the girls suggested I try it out, she swears she gets more tips as a blonde."

"Lidiya," I heard Ethan purr.

Lynn turned to him and smiled, putting a hand on her hip. Then she turned without saying a word and sauntered away, while Ethan's eyes closed halfway, like a satisfied cat, watching her retreat.

Realization was slowly overcoming my shock, like slow-moving lava from my toes and from my head, meeting in the center. I looked at Ethan, knowing, in a sense, what he was about to say. I was putting all the pieces together, all of Ethan's comments, the look on his face...

He snapped his gaze back at me when Lynn faded into the crowd.

"That's the one," he shouted. He pointed in the direction Lynn had left, shaking his finger for emphasis. "That's the fucking girl I'm gonna marry."

Could he really, seriously, not know that it was Lynn?

I was dumbstruck, my cock pulsing almost painfully in delight, my head spinning, as jealousy stepped on my chest like an elephant. My mouth was open to say something, but I had no idea which angle to attack from.

Somewhere in the back of my mind, I was wondering how many times Ethan had seen "Lidiya," and how intimate their relationship had gotten. Clearly, Lynn had told a lie of one degree or another, when she had said that she had only "seen" Ethan at the club. He knew her name, so they had clearly interacted more than that.

I said nothing. Steve shook his head at Ethan. "That chick," he said, "wouldn't touch your dick with one of these skanks' pussies."

Ethan grinned and leaned on the table. "And that'd also be fine. But how do you know that, Steve?"



Steve laughed. “You’re an ugly fucker and you don’t even have a cool job.”

It was true: he was sort of bug-eyed and he was an arborist, which isn’t exactly renown for being a chick magnet, as far as occupations go, but women seemed to like Ethan anyway.

Ethan shrugged, still smiling, undaunted. “Maybe she needs a green card.”

My mouth, which was already looking pretty stupid at that point, I’m sure, fell open a little more.

He *really* didn’t know.

Steve snorted.

I was about to lean over and ask Ethan how many times he’d seen this Lidiya, and how far he’d gotten with her, when she returned.

I had my back to the bar, but I knew she was coming by the way Steve and Ethan’s expressions changed, from adult to adolescent, intelligent to ridiculous.

I gave my wife a glance and she rested her gaze on me for a moment, her lips in an expression that, honestly, did look Russian: a blend of sexy condescension, unbreakable cynicism, and allure.

She set the drinks around the table, and I thought she was going to ignore Ethan again, which would have been fun to see, because the ladies rarely ignored Ethan. Instead, she gave me a sideways glance as she leaned over the table, stood up, and took a few steps before sinking into Ethan’s lap.

She stretched an arm over his shoulders and smiled. “Have we met, darling? You have to tell me your name, I am forgetting it...”

“Ethan, sweetheart,” Ethan said, using his usual charm. He had a big, broad grin on his face.

“*Eestan*,” she said, as though it were difficult for her to get the word out.

She ran her fingers through his hair, at the back of his head, just the same way she would do to me. I felt them as though she had her fingers on my scalp, and one hand on my cock, which was rock-hard by then.

Steve’s eyebrows shot up and he took a sip of his drink.

Lidiya leaned close to his ear, fingers still playing with his hair, and I could no longer hear what she was saying. Her red lips moved just fractions

of an inch from his earlobe, slowly enunciating something that Ethan, if I were to judge by his expression, liked a lot.

And then: Ethan fished some money out of his pocket, rolled it up, and worked it into the straps on Lynn's top, which seemed well-designed for exactly that purpose.

Lynn stood up, leaving the money in the straps of her outfit, which made her look cheap and slutty and made my cock pulse to record-breaking hardness. She blew Ethan a kiss, nudged my knee as she walked by, and disappeared.

Ethan pursed his lips to let out a whistle I couldn't hear over the music. Then he raised his glass in a toast, which I returned without clinking his glass, because I had no idea what else to do at that particular moment.

"Smokin'!" Ethan yelled.

I looked at Steve, who concurred by nodding his head and then let his attention wander to the stage.

Did these two imbeciles actually have no idea that "Lidiya" was my wife?

I thought about it as I stared emptily onto the stage. I guess her accent was fairly convincing (she had studied Russian once upon a time, and did have a friend in college who came from Moscow).

The blonde hair changed her appearance wildly enough that even *I* hadn't recognized her at first. Lynn, in real life, never wore much make-up or dressed like that.

And she didn't hang out with these guys much. Neither did I.

I supposed it was possible.

In which case... it was very fun.

But the question still burned inside of me: how many times had Ethan run into "Lidiya" before this?

He was absorbed in the dancers onstage now, so I didn't bring it up until after Lynn passed by to take more drink orders, leaning in front of Ethan provocatively, putting a hand on his shoulder, whispering more sweet nothings in his ear.

She barely gave me a glance before leaving again.

I leaned on the table. "Ethan. Ethan!" I yelled.

He turned to me, his eyes dragging along more slowly than his head. He was still watching Lynn's ass. "How many times you had that waitress?" I yelled.

Steve, who had a tendency to get this way when he went to strip clubs, waved his hand in the air dismissively. “Dude, that’s all just an act for tips.”

Ethan laughed. “Like I don’t fucking know that. This chick gets fifty, sixty bucks outta me every time I come here, and she doesn’t even take her clothes off.”

Steve snorted again and his eyes went back to the stage.

Ethan shrugged and leaned back in his chair. “She has a nice little ass,” he said, as if there were no further explanation needed.

I abandoned my question, left with my mouth hanging open yet again. My stomach felt like someone had funneled live bait into it.

The evening went on, Jen remained seated on Burke’s lap, and from the looks of it, was grinding against his cock. She seemed utterly disinterested in any of us.

About the fourth time Lynn came back to the table, though, the cat got out of the bag. She put a hand on my shoulder and juttied a knee next to my arm, a patch of her thigh visible between the dress and her thigh-highs. She leaned down to speak in my ear. “You havink a fun?”

I flashed my eyes at her. “How long have you been hitting on Ethan?” I asked.

She grinned. “He’s a regular during the week. He still doesn’t know it’s me.”

She wiped the table in front of me with a waitressty professionalism, probably not even conscious that she was doing it. “You want another drink? Yours are on the house.” Then her mouth flickered. “Well, they’re on Ethan, technically.”

I leaned to her ear and shouted: “You told me you *thought* you’d seen him.”

Lynn blinked at me. Then she leaned in close. “That’s what I *thought*. Now that I see him again I guess I’ve seen him a lot.”

She looked at me, her eyes searching my face.

Then she rolled her eyes and leaned even closer to me. “Oh, come on. I wait on a hundred guys on a Friday. I wouldn’t know this mutt was Ethan if he wasn’t here with you.” Then she smiled conspiratorially. “He *lofs* accent. I get lots dollars from him.”

My heart was pounding. *I bet*, I thought.

Lynn put a fresh cocktail napkin in front of me. Then she kissed one for Ethan, and set it in front of *him*.

Burke had been fairly silent all night, probably because he had a pretty hot chick right on his lap and all he had to do was buy her drinks. He was hidden behind Jen, who had never met Lynn and was drinking a shot, giving the stage a glazed look.

Burke's head slowly peeked out from behind Jen to look at me. "That waitress looks exactly like Lynn," he said plainly.

I shook my head, which was neither a yes or a no, but a message to shut up.

Burke looked at Lynn, leaning to the side to get a good look at her face.

She smiled at him. "You want somethink drink?" she asked.

Burke's face was still scrunched up in curiosity. I tapped Lynn and yelled, "Get him another one."

Lynn smiled at me, wrote the orders down lazily on a piece of paper she had, like the napkins, produced from nowhere, and then she made a very big deal of standing up slowly, almost like she was stretching, before slinking away.

I looked nervously at Burke.

I wasn't sure what my deal was: coming into Liquid Kitty, I had fully expected to answer questions about my wife working there, and take a little heat for it. But now, now that I knew Lynn had been stringing Ethan along with her fake accent and her blonde hair, I wasn't sure if I wanted the game to end.

I think I wanted to see how far Lynn would go, teasing Ethan, who wasn't the kind of guy to just stop at flirting with a strip club waitress. I sort of wanted to sit back and watch it unfold.

How far would Lynn take it?

As soon as I had that thought, jealousy reared up inside of me again. I stood abruptly, feeling hot under the collar. "Gotta use the john," I said, loudly enough that someone might hear, but no one did. Steve and Burke were talking, but it seemed like Burke had given up on his theory of Lidiya being Lynn. Ethan was looking at the stage.

I squeezed my way among the tables, plotting a course for the bar. By the time I reached it, Lidiya's blonde hair was floating over a sea of men,

back out the way I had come in. Annoyed, I made my way to the edge of the bar by the wait station, and ordered a drink.

When she came back, she gave me a quick look, almost like I was a stranger, and started barking things off to the bartender while typing away on a computer screen.

I stared at her. She looked nothing like my wife.

What was happening?

At last, she leaned on the top of the computer station and smiled at me. "Ethan still buying it?" she asked wryly, her voice back to its normal accent.

I jerked my head in the direction of the hallway to the bathrooms, and she looked over in that direction and crinkled her nose. "No way," she said, shaking her head. "Nothing back there on Fridays but coke and whores."

I leaned close to her. "How far are you going to take this with Ethan?" I yelled, close to her ear.

"Greg, I need one more Stella for twenty-three!" she yelled abruptly behind the bar. She was using her accent.

Her eyes were scanning the tray of drinks in front of her, her mind miles away from what I was saying.

"I gotta go," she said to me. Greg the bartender yelled something at her.

"No, it's two. I need three."

She looked at me while she waited. Her eyelashes were thick and black, and I realized they must be fake.

"How far are you taking this thing with Ethan?" I said sullenly. The music had dropped down to where we could talk to each other.

She smiled. "What think with Ethan? - Thank you -" she interrupted herself to speak to Greg. She was picking up the tray.

"Lynn," I said, my voice protesting, though I wasn't sure what I thought I was going to say next.

"Rick," she cooed. Then she leaned toward me, the tray balanced precariously on one hand, and kissed my cheek. "How do you think I make tips?" she asked me. "Bringing beer on time? Now please, I ghave table."

She was grinning, really enjoying herself. I watched her wade back into the crowded floor, a wave of smiles and upturned faces rolling in front of her, and then backs of heads behind her, as all the men at the edges of the

tables stopped watching naked women on the stage to look at my wife as she brought them drinks.

And that's how Lidiya came into my life.

At the end of the night, Ethan and Burke never figured it out. And I was left alone at home, waiting for the return of my wife, the first drops of an uneasy feeling creeping into the fun that we'd been having.

## CHAPTER 4

This went on for a long time. And it *was* fun, even with that little layer of unease in it.

We were having hot sex, I enjoyed fantasizing about Lynn teasing men, I got brave enough to occasionally go in on a Wednesday or a Thursday and watch the patrons ogle her as she sizzled from table to table.

She really developed that Lidiya personality, and brought it home with her.

Lidiya was a great time, at the beginning. She was a lot more enthusiastic in bed, a hell of a lot more creative, and... well, I'm a man.

I wasn't about to complain.

But the unease never went away. I don't know what it was: I didn't care that my wife was play-acting at work. I didn't care about her faking an accent or wearing a wig.

But the *way* she did it. The expertise with which she transformed?

*That* scared me.

And like all good things with a hint of danger in them, I knew it was going to take a turn for the dark.

And that's just what happened.

It was a Saturday morning like any other when Lynn came home late for the first time.

Usually she got home around 4:30 at the latest, and that rarely happened. She was all about getting her work done, her area cleaned, and out of the club almost as fast as the patrons. In the wee hours of the morning, it was a quick drive home, and I think she sensed that I wasn't too keen on her getting home any later, or going out with some of the girls from work to a place down the street that started serving beer and steaks at 5am for the late-shift workers. I could only imagine what went on at that place, full of strippers and guys getting out of their customer-service jobs in the strip malls along Brighton Avenue.

It was 6:30 am when she came home, and I was grateful that I'd fallen into a deep sleep and hadn't worried all night about her, like I usually did, even when she came home on time.

I heard the ring of her keys on the kitchen counter, and the clomp of her shoes before she kicked them off.

I gave the clock a frown and hauled myself out of bed. Lynn's job was making me tired: I'd been woken up at 5:00 by Lynn crawling into bed almost every day she worked at Liquid Kitty. By that time, I was half-awake anyway, and she was always ready and wet, happy to let me roll over and slip into her pussy. After a few minutes, I was properly awake, and she climbed on top of me or licked my cock while whispering sweet Russian-accented dirty talk into my ear.

I was tired. But I wasn't complaining. Six-thirty was a little late, though. I had an ice-cold feeling in my gut, suspicion climbing up and down my spine with cold fingers.

I plodded into the kitchen, where Lynn was standing in the light of the open fridge, gulping water straight from the glass container she used to keep it chilled. She lowered the bottle and smiled at me. "Oh hey," she said. "Sorry. I didn't want to wake you up."

This annoyed me. After all, hadn't she been waking me up even *earlier* almost every night that she worked until now? The nails of suspicion drove further into my back.

"What are you doing home so late?" I asked. I tried to sound like a normal husband who trusted his wife and did not have an image of her in a red velvet private room sliding up and down some stranger's cock with her back to him, watching her own tits bouncing in a wall-to-ceiling mirror.

Not that I was aware of any such room existing at Liquid Kitty.

"God," she said, putting the water back in the fridge. "We had a meeting. At four-thirty in the morning, can you believe that? New owner. Wanted to come and meet us, blah, blah, blah." She closed the fridge. "At least we got free drinks."

I frowned in spite of myself. Her excuse – well, reason, really – for being late sounded completely legitimate, but I found myself judging each syllable of her speech, every motion of her eyes, as though I were trying to interrogate her for a murder. "And you drove?" I asked her, my tone almost father-like.

Lynn rolled her eyes, which she had been doing a lot of lately. I found it charming, sexual, and irritating as hell. "I only had one, silly."

She was looking at me with a mischievous grin on her face.



The unsettled feeling that had slowly been fading into a dull roar started to come back at me in waves. I must have *looked* unsettled, because Lynn made a face that I took for an imitation of my expression. She walked toward me. She was still in her waitress garb, and her hair was a wavy mess, staticky up top. Her lipstick was rubbed off, and her eye make-up was slightly smeared beneath her eyelid.

My cock sprang to life, at the same time as my imagination, which went into overdrive. I knew she had probably just lost the lipstick over the course of the evening and not bothered to replenish it for a staff meeting, and that the static and tangle of her hair was from removing her blonde wig. That the smeared makeup was just from rubbing her eyes on the way home because she was tired.

But it was equally easy to imagine that her lipstick was out there somewhere, forming a nice red circle at the base of some guy's cock. That her eyes had watered while she swallowed it whole and then smeared her mascara. That her hair had gotten clingy as another man wove his fingers into it and pulled.

"What was it about?" I said lamely, looking at every detail on her face. "The meeting?"

Lynn rolled her eyes again. "I just said," she complained, reaching out for my shoulders. She smelled like sour drinks, smoke, and the strange powdery scent of the strip club.

Trashy.

It was strangely arousing.

"I just *told* you," she said. "New owner. Wanted to meet all the girls. It happens every year or so, I guess."

I raised my eyebrows. I was unable to control the violent attraction I was feeling toward her, only enhanced by the dirty thoughts I was having about her sucking some other guy's cock.

"I bet he wanted to meet the girls," I croaked.

It was meant to be a joke, but it came out sounding a little jealous.

Lynn grinned, and I could see her prickling with delight, sensing my jealousy. "I think he likes me," she said.

This set me on fire. I had a hand up against her cheek and was pushing her back toward the counter, where I envisioned turning her around and pushing her dress up, getting inside of her and fucking her right then and there.

“Oh yeah?” I said. “Did you use your Russian act on him?”

Lynn smiled secretively, and let that sink in while I walked her back toward the counter. She derailed my plan to turn her around by putting both hands on the edge of the counter and hoisting herself up nimbly to a seated position. She gave a shake of her head, sending her brown hair cascading in waves.

Her mouth quivered into a new smile I’d been noticing since she’d started working at Liquid Kitty. It was a flirtatious, mysterious smile, like the flash of a lure to a fish. I loved it and hated it.

“I think he might be Russian,” she whispered, her fingers playing with her throat in a flutter.

I cocked my head. My eyes were on her throat, her lips, her spreading legs and the slow revealing of the black triangle of her panties. My *mind* was on this new boss, the unease that was ricocheting through my chest as I thought of all the unsettling things my wife was doing: smiling this way, stroking her throat, sitting on the counter like a slut with her legs spread.

She leaned back on the counter, driving her legs open a little more. She swung them playfully, her huge heels switching past my legs. “What?” she asked, meaning ‘what was up’ with my stone-faced response.

I shrugged. “I don’t know. It’s a lot of turnover of ownership. You sure this place is legit?”

The smile again quivered on her lips, with a tinge of derisiveness. “What do you mean by that?”

I had my hands on her thighs. The fishnet was rough until it ended with her ultra-smooth legs, mid-thigh. Her skin was hot to the touch. I moved my fingers upward, savoring the feel of her skin, the trashiness of her smell, searching for a rough patch of cum or a sticky patch of her excitement. I wasn’t sure if that search was being done with excited anticipation or dread.

“I mean,” I said, as my fingers brushed over the decidedly wet center of her panties and I shivered, “that it seems a little sketchy.”

Lynn’s eyes moved up and down my body. She leaned her head back as my fingers passed over her hard clit, protruding slightly from between the lips of her cunt as a hard bump beneath the wet satin of her panties. She was awfully riled up for someone just coming from a work meeting.

Her legs spread further apart and she lifted her head to meet my eyes. As her legs spread, her panties slipped into the folds of her pussy and the

gooey, hot center of her spilled out from behind them. My fingers were wet, and I dove into her folds.

“What would you think,” she said, putting a hand on the back of my neck and pulling herself toward me, leaving nowhere for my exploring fingers to go but deeper into her soaked pussy, where it was deliciously hot and wet. “About me starting to dance there?”

The question was completely unexpected. Not only that, I was feeling around inside of her cunt, trying to find something about it that would incriminate her, give her away as a secretive slut. Maybe she would be looser, maybe she would still have the slippery cum of another man inside of her.

I didn’t really process the question right away as a result. Lynn slipped her free hand between us and into my sweats to get at my cock. As soon as what she had said made its way through my brain, my eyes went wide and my cock jumped in her hand, making her smile.

“Wha... I thought you had decided not to do that...?” I babbled. A flood of images filled my head: Lynn spinning around a pole, her tits bouncing in front of burly, filthy men, saliva practically falling all over her lap.

“It’s just a thought,” Lynn said, and she squeezed my cock as she said it. “It seems like you are sort of into the idea.”

I *was* sort of into the idea, and there was no real denying that as my aching cock grew stiffer in her fingers and pulsed wildly beneath her palm.

The hand on the back of my neck moved down, her fingernails scraping my spine as she did. When she reached my sweats, she tugged them down, moving her hand from side to side to get them free of my cock in three jerks.

The hand on my cock was making languid strokes from base to tip, her thumb swirling over the sensitive crown, smearing the precum practically gushing out of it. “It’s not a done deal,” she said. “But I could be making closer to a *thousand* dollars on a Friday night.”

My cock pulsed again. It wasn’t the money, though the thought of that kind of money was a little erotic. But the idea of my wife dancing practically naked on strangers’ laps, while her new Russian overlord watched with Slavic stoicism and a hard cock from some dark office with one-way glass (as far as I knew, Liquid Kitty had no such thing) made my cock actually throb.

“Hmm,” Lynn said, as she felt the pulse in her hand. “I think you like that idea.”

I had three fingers inside her wet cunt, and her own body was just as revealing as mine. Her pussy rippled against my fingers. I pushed them in deeper, clawing toward the root of her clit, and her lips parted in ecstasy. She pushed herself toward me, driving my hand deeper inside of her, spreading her opening wider with the thickness of my hand.

I grabbed her hair in my fist and pulled her face toward mine. We kissed with an animal passion, wetly and filthily, and a strand of spit hung between us when our lips parted. “Turn around,” I directed her, and the little smile fluttered around on her lips briefly before she began to comply. She rolled over and dragged her leg over my arm, her knee bent and her sexy heel near my face, so that I didn’t have to pull my hand from her pussy as she did.

She kept her knee bent, so I pushed on her ankle, bringing her right ankle up to her ass. Her other leg dangled off the table, and I heard the heel scrape lightly on the floor. I pushed my hand further inside of her, envisioning her naked except for her panties, in a similar pose, dancing for strange men.

She lifted her ass up, giving me a better view of her bottom. The panties were a thong, nestled between the smooth, round humps of her ass, the material askew from being pushed aside so I could practically fist-fuck her. The heel on the shoe of her right foot was black, shiny, and also trashy, making my erection even more intense.

I pulled my hand out from inside her, with the plan to yank the panties down, hooking them on the crease of her left buttock. I then had a perverse and delightful idea: I grabbed the right side of the underwear and pulled it tight to stretch it up to the heel of her right foot. The material embedded itself in her pussy lips, stretched out to a thin line against her asshole, and she gasped.

I massaged her ass for a moment while I stared at the tableaux I had created: the panties hooked on her heel, holding her bent knee in place; the satin taut against her pussy, cutting into her soaked flesh.

I pulled her foot toward me, like a lever, and the panties slid against her skin, loosening slightly, then tightened again when I pushed her heel back toward her ass. Her dangling left leg trembled.

This was fun, but I couldn't wait any longer. I clawed at the panties and tore them away from her body. I caught her right foot as it started to drop, and pushed it back into place as I guided my cock toward the dripping wet entrance to her cunt.

I thrust into her, and fucked her against the counter, her words licking at my ears, replaying in my mind over and over again:

*What if I dance there? What if I dance there?*

*I think you like that idea.*

...until Lynn clawed at the countertop and screamed, her pussy milking the cum from inside of me so hard that I had to hold onto the edge of the counter and grit my teeth.

\*

"So..." I said, after we'd gotten up very late, made coffee, and Lynn was seated in the bright kitchen sipping it. "Are you really going to do this?"

Lynn had on a silky bathrobe. We had fucked again when we woke up, and I had the pleased-with-myself glow of a man who'd had a lot of sex in a short period of time. She had washed her face, but not taken a shower, and I relished the idea of her pussy still being slick, wet, and scented with cum and her own arousal.

She looked up at me. "Do what?"

She had a strange look on her face, almost like I had caught her doing something naughty.

I wondered if she had forgotten telling me about dancing.

"Dance," I said plainly.

Lynn's look of shock melted away, and she almost looked relieved.

She gave a shake of her head and smiled. Not the mysterious smile; a plain old smile. "Oh God," she said. "*That*. I was just saying that because I thought it turned you on."

I felt a pang of disappointment, and then a wave of relief. And then another pang of disappointment. And then, I got my hackles up, because I had to wonder: why had she looked so shocked by the question?

"So, you're not actually thinking of doing that?" I pressed.

She set her coffee down. "No," she said firmly.

But then she wavered for a moment. “I mean, why would I do it? I’m already making good money with less effort.”

She paused. “Wait... do you think I should?”

There was a blizzard of thoughts in my head. It actually felt like a blizzard, with thousands of ideas swirling around like snowflakes on crack. What *did* I think she should do?

I sat down at the table. “Do the girls there actually make that kind of money?”

Lynn looked at me with an expression of surprise, her mouth open in a smile of disbelief. “I mean... I guess they do. No... they do, I’ve seen it. But... you aren’t actually serious, are you?”

I looked at my coffee mug, concentrating on it because it seemed sufficiently non-sexual. “No, of course not. Unless you are.”

I looked back up at her. Lynn blinked slowly at me. She brought her mug to her lips. “Wow,” she said, and then took a sip of coffee.

She sounded offended. I moved myself closer to her under the table and put my hand on her knee. “Hey, I only say that because I thought maybe *you* were serious. I just... wanted to support you. If you were.”

That sounded good. I applauded myself inside my own mind.

“Hmm,” Lynn said, setting the mug down. She looked at her coffee. “I guess I might be thinking about it,” she ventured.

This hit me like a load of bricks, right in the gut.

“Oh, you are, are you?” I asked.

I wasn’t exactly sure what I meant by my statement. I wanted, desperately, for her to laugh and start drinking her coffee, but a darker force inside of me was tugging just as fiercely at the hope that she might give a toss of her hair, shrug, and say, “why not?”

We stared each other for one simmering moment.

“It’s good money,” she said. “And this Tim guy... I don’t know. He seemed pretty interested in.. you know, why I wasn’t doing it.”

Of all the things to say, I asked: “Tim?”

“The new owner.”

“The Russian?”

I had been imagining some guy named, I don’t know, Igor or Vlad or something. Tim?

“His name is Timor or Timur or something. He goes by Tim.”

“Huh.”

The secretive smile reappeared on her lips, pursing them slightly, and she shifted sexually in her chair. “Yes, Tim,” she said. She watched my reaction. “He’s still very Russian. Very macho. Very... I don’t know, *mafioso*.”

“Huh,” I repeated. “And so Tim-bo wants you to dance for him?”

Just saying this sentence was giving me an erection. I pictured some mongoloid of a Russian, jowls fat and hanging, leering at my wife, his cock fat and stubby and erect, thinking of her swinging on the poles at Liquid Kitty with nothing more than a black thong on her body.

Lynn watched me, and then smiled again, and brought her mug to her lips. “I probably won’t do it,” she said. “It’s so much... waxing, and working out, and... you know.”

“I don’t know,” I prodded.

She smiled again. “Just... a little *dirty*, don’t you think?”

My cock pulsed. I *did* think it was dirty. Very dirty, very slutty, and very perversely appealing. I had a coil of cold snakes writhing in my gut. The air had become tinny in my ears, and my arteries were tight with pulsing blood. What the fuck was wrong with me? I could feel myself urging her to say she was going to do it. The word “waxing” was repeating over and over in my mind.

*Such a bad idea*, my conscience was screaming. But the dull roar of my boiling blood was drowning it out.

Lynn was waiting for me to answer. She tapped her mug with one fingernail, as though cueing me to answer.

When I didn’t, she yawned, and lifted her arms to stretch. The robe she wearing slipped open, revealing her chest and the creamy mounds of her breasts, right up the edges of her aureole. “Man,” she said. “I have to eat something and take a nap before work. This day is completely shot.”

The yawn was contagious. I couldn’t believe she was thinking about food, changing the subject. I wanted to discuss it more, in detail, but I pushed the idea down hard. I didn’t even really know what I wanted, for christssakes.

Lynn slid her hand across the table to mine. “Let’s think about it,” she said. “In the meantime, you want to take me out for breakfast? I want bacon. And a mimosa.”

## CHAPTER 5

The idea got shelved, at least as far as I knew. Lynn went to work, and she came home at four-thirty. I was awake, staring at the ceiling, my mind a cesspool of dirty thoughts. She yawned when I rolled over and stroked the length of her body. “Oh babe,” she said, her eyelids heavy. “I’m so, so tired, I have to sleep.” She practically fell asleep saying that, so I made another trip up and down her body, but abandoned all hope of intercourse when a low, feminine snore came from her throat. She rolled over, and was sound asleep.

I surveyed her body. She had taken a shower, like she usually did when she came home from work. The normalcy of that action didn’t clear the suspicious thoughts from my mind: had she showered to hide something from me, the scent of another man, or to wash away glitter, or sticky cum from the inside of her thighs?

I grew restless around six and got up. Lynn didn’t stir. I made myself some breakfast, paced, tried to read the news online, got annoyed by everything I saw, and decided to get myself to work looking for a new job.

It wasn’t easy going. The internet pages swam in front of my eyes, the words never penetrating my thoughts, which were all imaginative and filthy. She got up around one pm, and we had an ordinary Sunday – the kind of ordinary that had settled in since she started working at Liquid Kitty, in which we went out to eat, and I got sleepy around ten, and Lynn was still bright-eyed and awake.

She had become a night-owl. She tried going to bed with me, and we had a nice, married-sex interlude, but just as I was dozing off, I felt her rise, heard the rustle of her robe as she put it on, and opened one eye to see her slipping into the hallway.

I wondered what it was she did at night, all alone. I’d been wondering long before then, but now the thought was starting to burn inside my head, keeping me awake.

I lay like that for a long time, and then when curiosity got the better of me, I rose and crept down the hall to see what she was doing.



My heart was pounding when I peered into the crack of the office door. The blueish light of the computer was pouring from inside. Steady, not flashing like a video would be, but I found myself hoping right up to the last minute that I would catch her at something. Watching porn, maybe, or videos of pole dancers. Something burned inside of me, like a gallon of gasoline trapped in my chest, and I was torn between wanting to find her doing something illicit, and to rid myself of the unfounded jealousy by discovering that she was not.

When I saw the screen she was looking at – a steady white glow, with words and nothing more on it – I was just as disappointed as relieved. Lynn was, in her long lonely nighttime hours, looking for a job.

Just like we had originally planned.

My heart was buoyed. For the most part. I returned to bed, and finally fell asleep, just before my alarm blared and woke me up.

Nothing was going on with my wife except that she was a waitress at a strip club, looking to pay the bills while she found a job in her field. Of course that's all that was going on there.

And that was what I wanted, I told myself.

Because really, what kind of pig wanted something *else* to be true?

Weeks went by and there was no more mention of dancing. We started to really fall into the new schedule, our opposite hours. I often didn't wake up when Lynn got home. She spent her nights off looking for jobs related to her field of study, or watching very non-racy series on Netflix.

The suspicions started to wane, the pulse of my jealousy stopped flickering.

And then...

She came home one morning, and everything changed.

I felt her body sink into the bed, but I had gotten used to just barely reaching a level of consciousness when she came home, recognizing that she was there, and then dropping back off to sleep.

Her hand was on my thigh soon after, and I felt the covers sliding away, down my body. I struggled to open my eyes. "Rick," I heard her say.

I had a big day the next day, a presentation and a lot of other branches coming in to hear it. But I'm a guy, so my dick started thinking, tapping at

my chest, warming me up. I rolled toward the heat of her body and fumbled for her soft breasts.

Her mouth was close to my ear when she whispered: “I did it.”

I went from half-asleep to violently awake in less than a second. My eyes flew open to see her looking at me, a smile on her lips but a little bit of fear lurking in her wide eyes.

I scanned the scene: she was reclined on her side, at the very edge of the bed, as though she didn’t mean to stay there long. I could smell alcohol on her breath, and her lips were bright red, still lipsticked. I reached up and fingered the blonde wig, still on her head, the shoulder-length false tresses swinging slightly over her shoulder.

She had a black, silky hoodie on, an article of clothing I’d never seen. It was only partly zippered, and beneath it was another piece of clothing I’d never seen before. A light from the hall illuminated the room dimly, and her skin had a shimmery quality to it beneath the transparent gauze she seemed to be wrapped in.

I put my fingertips on her chest. The material was a little scratchy. “Did what?” I said, still thinking in a fog, even if my body was wide-awake.

She was gone in a second, standing up next to the bed. “Don’t be mad,” she whispered. “It just sort of happened.”

I could feel my dick get hard as a rock almost instantaneously, Three pulses, and it inflated and started to hurt. She *did it*? I immediately thought of her fucking another man. Sucking someone’s cock. Did what?

I sat up, unable to speak.

Lynn was already drawing the zipper of the hoodie down the middle of her body. It was a long hoodie, more like a hoodie-dress, made of a trashy-looking satin fabric with a gold zipper. As it opened, more and more of the less-black, transparent material appeared, and then the hoodie slipped from her shoulders and onto the floor.

I was too stunned to speak.

My wife – if that’s indeed who was standing in front of me – was clad in a short jumpsuit made of see-through black material. The cut of the outfit was not particularly slutty – the shorts were short, and there was a deep plunge between her breasts, but had it been made of an opaque substance, it would have been okay on a public beach.

But *this* jumpsuit was made of almost nothing, and Lynn’s pebbled nipples were very much visible, along with every delicious contour of her

body, through the fabric. The oval of her belly-button, the indentation of her waist, the flat expanse of her belly. The dark pink pools of her aureole, the shadowed lines of her spherical breasts where they met her ribcage.

The only place where any decent, non-transparent material covered her was between her legs, where I could see the undulating edges of a pair of *red* panties through the gossamer layer of costume.

Her legs dangled from the sexy getup, and a pair of red stockings began just above her knees, disappearing a few inches below that into a pair of shiny, plastic, thigh high boots that looked a lot like the pair Julia Roberts wore in the opening scenes of *Pretty Woman*.

It was, in summary, a hot but insanely trashy outfit.

She put a hand on one hip and posed for me. "I did it," she repeated. I was still speechless.

"You aren't going to say anything?" she asked me, shifting to a bored-looking stance with one hand on her hip still.

"Did... what?" I managed to ask.

She threw her arms open to display her outfit. "What do you think, crazy? *Danced*."

Upon making this declaration, excitement overtook her. I swung my feet over the edge of the bed. She moved right in, taking advantage of my stupor, and climbed onto my lap. I dropped my eyes, looking at the plastic boots, the long spiky heels jutting out on either side of me. Now that she was close, the strip-club smell was invading my senses: the fake mist; the cigarette smoke that somehow lingered where you couldn't smoke; soured and fresh alcohol; plastic; glittery, powdery makeup.

I put my hands on her thighs. "You did what?" I croaked.

"I did it," she said, and there was thrilled look in her eyes. "I danced. It was crazy. I made three hundred dollars off just that dance. I was really good."

My eyes were staring into her breasts, tantalizingly half-obscured by the jumpsuit.

I had no idea what to say.

"Timor says I can start dancing on the center stage on Wednesdays and Thursdays, if I want to," she said. "Those girls make like \$300 a dance sometimes, at night."

I looked at my wife, who seemed like she had come from another planet. The blonde wig changed her features, and her excitement about

dancing distorted them even further.

“I... have... I don’t know what to...”

She leaned in and kissed me, and her hand cupped my balls. I knew she felt my cock bouncing in my boxers, hard against the center of her legs.

“Don’t be mad,” she said. “I just tried it out. But I *was* really good at it.”

I stared at her.

“Wanna see?”

She didn’t wait for my answer, probably because she had some idea of what she was doing to me, and because my hard cock was telling her the real truth, anyway. She pushed me down onto my back, and rose up on her knees. “I don’t have any music,” she said. “So you’ll have to use your imagination.”

There was no need to use my imagination as Lynn demonstrated her “dance routine” for me. She swooped down over my body, dangling her deliciously gauzy-wrapped breasts over my face, her back arched, her red thong and white bottom visible behind her, stuck up in the air. I watched her lips as they formed a vacant, stripper expression – sultry, not smiling and not frowning, slightly parted, open in a way that indicated they could get much wider for the right enticement.

She backed up, sending her bottom into the air, drawing her hands along my chest, then swooped back down again. My cock was being rubbed by her body as she made her way down my torso the second time, and she smiled.

She stood and did a slow turn, undulating her body in contorted, sexy ways that I had seen other strippers do, in movies, but never thought were physically possible for a *normal* woman. She jutted out her bottom, twerking, but with grace. She dropped to a crouch and then stood back up, drawing her finger along her sensuous outfit and then sucking on it, before she gave another turn and bent over so I could see her from behind as she stretched down to her toes, long lean lines of flesh and muscle swarming before my eyes.

The red of the panties was barely visible between her butt cheeks, almost so that she looked naked except for a ruby gash. She stood up abruptly, twisted to look at me, and gave me a simmering look so I could take it all in before she started to sway and turn around.

By the time she was facing me, the top two buttons of her jumpsuit were open. Her fingers moved from her mouth down the center of her chest,

teasing me into believing she was going to open the next button, and that the black gauze was going to slide open further, revealing the color of her nipples, which I anticipated with as much excitement as if I had never seen them before.

I had raised myself up to my elbows, and I was vaguely aware of a completely ridiculous expression on my face, a mixture of thrill, surprise, confusion, and maybe even fear.

I watched her hand pass over the next buttons down her torso, following the trail of little black buttons to the center of her legs. I noticed that the knobs ran all the way down, right to the middle of the costume. Of course, I thought, just before she gave another turn and took the view away from me.

She was back, in short order, and did the same thing again, only this time she used one hand to pop the final button, at the center of her legs. Her fingers moved upward, almost as though she had practiced it a million times, unsnapping the flimsy jumpsuit from the center of her legs *up*, until nothing but a single button just below her breasts held it in place.

The red of her barely-there panties – edged with lace, and utterly trashy – was brighter now that it was freed from behind the filmy black curtain. Her inner thighs opened as she did a twisting crouch to the floor in those wild boots, spreading her legs and then popping back up. Her breasts somehow managed to remain hidden through this whole routine, promising to peek out from behind the jumpsuit, but somehow never falling out.

Standing again, she played with the remaining button, sashaying from side to side, her eyes on mine, her mouth smiling. She knew how badly I wanted to see behind the mesh, even if I was her husband, even if I had seen it a thousand times before. I clenched a fist and waited, thinking of the men who had ached to see that final button pop open, to find out what those hard nipples looked like when they were free.

She drew it out, really getting into it, doing a few more dips and squats and turns, before finally popping the last button. But she didn't just let me see: she pulled the sides of the gauze tight together, squishing her breasts together, making them look larger and softer than they were. She turned, pulling the jumpsuit off in a physics-defying move that left it in her two hands, like a scarf, in front of her breasts when she turned around.

"Oh, God, Lynn," I said.

She grinned, moving the remains of her outfit in front of her breasts while she danced a little more.

Finally, she drew the jumpsuit along, through one hand, and tossed it aside, and gave her naked breasts a little jiggle. They bounced, firm and pert, and the effect was dirtily beautiful.

She was then dancing in nothing but the thong, and the black boots, with the red stockings peeking out from inside. She edged closer to me, and turned, bending over so that her bottom was in my face.

I put my hands on her thighs and attempted to pull her toward me. I wanted to get my face right between her asscheeks and pull the thong away to bury my tongue in her pussy, which I could smell now.

She spun away, laughing, playfully slapping my hand away. “No touching,” she insisted. “Or you’re going to get bounced.”

She danced a little more, and then started laughing. “Well, that’s about it. I really need the pole for the finale.” Her chest was rising and falling a little quickly from the exertion.

And her face was positively beaming. “What do you think?”

I *thought* that I could not believe what I was seeing. I thought that I wanted to see the finale. I thought that my wife looked like a hot, raging little slut.

She didn’t give me time to finish. She climbed on top of the bed, and surprised me by swinging her leg over me to face away from me, reverse-cowgirl style. She rose up on her knees, hooked her thumb under her panties, and pulled them away to the side. Her other hand pushed my boxers away from my cock, and she sat down on it almost immediately, sinking me into her pussy.

It was her show from that moment on: she rode me wildly, her head thrown back, but she wasn’t even in the same room as me. It was all about her. I watched her, amazed and terrified, as she made herself come on my cock, and then leaned forward, exhausted and spent, her pussy throbbing around me.

I grabbed her hips, and thrust inside of her, until I also came. Lynn flopped on top of me like a rag doll, mewling, until I climaxed.

Lynn rolled onto her back, panting, and drew her hand lazily up to her chest. “Wow,” she said. “That was a workout.” Her feet were by my head, so I sat up and crawled round to lie next to her.

I had stars at the edges of my vision, so I flopped down and waited for them to clear.

I turned my head to her. She was looking at the ceiling, her eyelids growing heavy.

“How’d that happen, anyway?” I asked her.

The question had been percolating in the back of my mind since she came home, but I had been... well, distracted by other things. Now it was blaring at me: how was it that my wife had ended up dancing tonight? And where’d she gotten this slutty outfit?

Lynn’s eyes opened as though I had shocked her awake.

Her expression was much like the one she’d had the night she’d “pretended” to be into dancing at the club. As though I had asked her about something she hadn’t revealed to me.

The back of my neck tingled.

She turned sharply to me and gave me a plastic smile. Her voice was lilting, also plastic, as she sang to me: “Oh, jeez. I don’t even know. The club was pretty dead, the girls were sneaking drinks... you know. It just happened.”

I blinked at her. “That doesn’t make any sense.”

She sighed, like I was an idiot, which always gave me a deliciously painful shiver from my chest to my cock. “They aren’t supposed to drink while they’re working anymore. Even if it’s like three in the morning and there’s no one there. So Tim came down and he was getting angry, they said they were trying to help me get up the nerve to dance.”

I looked at her. She didn’t seem to be lying, but the story didn’t hold a ton of water.

“But you weren’t drinking,” I said.

She rolled her eyes. “It was just an excuse,” she said. “To do it. And... I mean, I *had had* a few drinks.”

I frowned.

She sighed again. “Oh, please. Like you wouldn’t be drinking a few, if you worked there.”

She had a point, but I still didn’t like it.

“Anyway,” I said. “So what happened after that?” I wasn’t as interested in her drinking as I was in her dancing.

She shrugged. “I don’t know. Tim was like, ‘I would like to see you dance,’ and I was like, ‘no, I only wait tables,’ and everyone started egging

me on, and there was no one else there... so... I just did it.”

Her eye twitched.

I sensed she was lying about something. She had looked down while she was telling me this story, and it just didn't seem like her. For one thing, Lynn wasn't a peer-pressure type. In fact, the more people egged her on, the more I'd have put money on her refusing to do something even if she *wanted to*. And she would have had to have had more than a few drinks to do something out of the ordinary, because, while Lynn wasn't a drunk by any means, she could hold her booze really well.

“You danced *in* the club?” I said flatly. I knew my tone sounded like I didn't believe her, but I figured I could always say I just found it incredible that she did it.

She looked me in the eye.

“I mean... I danced in a like, smaller room they have in the back, for VIPs and stuff. I was too chicken to do it in the club, on stage. Plus Kandy would've been pissed that I took her set.”

“I thought you said there was no one there.”

For a moment her face was frozen in surprise. Just a moment. Like a deer in the headlights.

Or at least, that's what *I* saw.

She recovered quickly. So quickly, in fact, that I wasn't even sure I had seen the look of terror on her face.

“I was just saying, it was *dead*, but not like *no one* was in the club, silly.”

“So you went to a VIP room.”

“Yeah.”

There was a long pause while I stared at her.

“Who was there?”

She pushed herself up on one elbow. “I thought you were into this?” she said accusingly.

I *was* into it.

And I wasn't.

I turned back to face the ceiling. “Sure, but I was thinking you'd be... dancing in the club. With all the same rules and everything. Not giving some private dance for your boss in a back room.”

She laughed lightly. “There were like five girls there, too, giving me some coaching. And his bodyguards or whoever those guys are.”



I turned back to look at her. “And you didn’t find that *more* intimidating?”

She shrugged. “I don’t know. I just got a wild hair up my ass, I guess.”

She dropped her eyes to the tangled sheet across my pelvis, which was slowly rising above my pubic bone, as my cock betrayed some of my less-conscious thoughts about the matter. Her hand drifted down to the tent in the sheets, and she rubbed her palm over my crown through the fabric.

She bit my ear gently. “I don’t see you complaining much,” she said.

She tugged on the sheet.

“In fact, it seems like you like the idea more than you’re letting on. Me dancing in a little red room filled with mirrors, Timor sitting on a chair, watching me...”

I was on top of her in a heartbeat. I don’t know how she’d learned to push these buttons so quickly, especially when I hadn’t even known that I had them just six months ago.

As I sank into her pussy, she grinned at me, and I pictured Timor on a folding chair, elbows on knees, legs spread, eyes on her lean body as she spun around and around for him on a pole.

I pictured her doing the splits, sliding with her back down the pole until her red panties were stretched thin over her gash.

I wondered if she had flashed it for him.

And then I had a thought that made me ice-cold, right before it burst through my dick and made me come:

Lynn’s pussy was freshly waxed.

What the hell was with that? What were the chances that she would do that, and then be pressured into dancing, out of the blue, the very next day?

Suspicious and doubts flooded my mind, but it was not a question I got a chance to ask. Lynn came, rolled over, and fell asleep.

## CHAPTER 6

She was already in the shower when I woke up.

“Room in here for two?” I said, opening the shower door.

My eyes dropped immediately to her shaved snatch, because that was the first place my mind had gone when I had woken up.

Soap was sliding down her shiny body, lavender filling my nostrils, the spray of the shower misting my face. Lynn turned, and a big glob of white foam drained erotically along her inner thigh. She wiped water from her face and smiled. “Sure. Sorry if I woke you up, I couldn’t sleep.”

I slipped my hand down to her bare pussy, feeling the silkiness of her skin, made rubbery by the soap and water.

She didn’t turn away, but instead backed herself toward me and let me indulge in the feel of her pussy, the heat and slickness between her lips. Her skin was smooth as silk.

“When’d you have time to get this done?” I murmured in her ear.

It wasn’t as if this was something entirely new. She had started doing it a few years back for swimsuit season, and she had gotten one when she started at Liquid Kitty. At that time, it had seemed like a logical thing to do, even for a waitress, and she had told me about it.

She usually told me about it, because she hated getting it done.

“Yesterday?” she said, unsure. “Wait, no... or the day before.”

I gauged her tone, my fingers moving over the soft petals of her outer labia. I could feel her hard clit just beneath the opening, twitching slightly.

“Man,” she said, stepping away from me to reach for a washcloth, which she had a tendency to hang annoyingly on the shower door. They would get caught in the door when I tried to close it, and it drove me crazy.

This one was caught, and she tugged on it, squinting her eyes. I reached for the door and opened it so she could get it out. “I must have had a lot more than I thought I did,” she said.

“Lynn,” I said admonishingly.

It was hell to get around in this city without a license, and it would make it very hard for her to get to work – at Liquid Kitty or anywhere else.

Although, I thought: it wouldn’t be terrible to have to drive her everywhere. At least I would know what she was really up to.

“I know, I know, what you’re going to say,” she said from behind the washcloth. “But you’re going to sound silly, because I got a ride.”

“Oh you did, did you? From who? Your boss?”

I reached for her pussy again, but she was turning away from me to get under the water. “You’re hogging all the water,” she told me.

I murmured at her neck: “You didn’t tell me who you got a ride with.”

My cock was getting hard against her bottom, I knew she could feel it.

“Oh,” she said, in a dramatically over-the-top sexual moan. “From Tim, I got a ride from him, if you know what I mean, all the way home in the back of his limo, oh!”

She was joking, but my cock twitched against her ass and she turned around, her eyes dropping to look at my dick, a smile of incredulity on her face.

“It was one of his drivers or something,” she said wryly. “He does it for all of the girls if they get drunk.”

I stood away from her. “I thought you said he said no drinking.”

“He did. But, you know, I don’t know. Sometimes he comes down if it’s slow and then the girls have drinks with him.”

Of course. The big-shot alpha male descending from up high to his harem of sluts, and telling them when they could drink, and when they could not.

“Sounds pretty...” I searched for the word.

“Domineering?” Lynn offered. “You think? The guy is so full of himself, I swear.” She sounded annoyed with Tim now, and I scored a personal victory.

I also felt a peculiar pang of disappointment.

“So what are you doing dancing for him, then?” I asked.

Lynn shrugged. “Like I said. It just happened.”

She studied my face, her eyes lighting up as she discovered something.

“God, *who* did I even get that costume from?” she mused.

I wrinkled my nose.

Lynn laughed. “It was in a package,” she said, smiling. “I’m not that gross.”

My cock throbbed again. It was filthy, thinking of my wife sharing a pair of panties with, say, Kandy Stripe, or that scary black girl. But it was

also hot.

“Anyway, sorry if I got a little carried away. I’m not about to do *that* again.”

“What?”

She turned to me and looked at me incredulously. “*Dance*,” she said.

“Oh,” I said. I pulled her close to me. “I thought you said you liked it, you were going to do it Wednesdays and Thursdays on stage, Tim said you could, you were going to make all this money.”

Lynn’s mouth quivered as she repressed laughter. “I said all that?” she asked.

She reached to the side and slammed the shower off. “Man. I must have been more loaded than I thought.” She laughed genuinely. Then she looked down at my cock. “Wow. You really got off on the idea of having a stripper for a wife, huh?”

I was dumbstruck.

“Tell you what,” she breathed close to my lips. “I’ll give you all the lap dances you want.”

She put her arms on my shoulders, and brought her face close to mine. I kissed her, and my cock pulsed again, against her silky pussy and her inner thigh.

“Just not now.” She opened the shower door and pulled a towel off the rack in one easy motion. “I think I’ve had enough for a few hours,” she said. “Sorry.”

“Aw,” I complained. “You can’t leave me like this.”

She tapped the door shut with the back of her foot. “By-yyye.”

We settled in for breakfast on Sunday morning – this was a few days later – at our favorite restaurant, Rosario’s Kitchen. She liked the huevos rancheros. I had scrambled eggs, bacon, and home fries, as usual, and she scowled, as usual, as I poured maple syrup all over everything.

“It’s an East Coast thing,” I told her, as usual.

She bit into a corn chip, which I found unnerving at breakfast.

“Gross,” she said.

“So...” I began. “Tell me the truth. What’s the real deal with the new boss?”

I’d wanted to bring this question up Friday, and Saturday, because both nights Lynn had come home horny and ready to play games,

pretending she had stripped all night, telling me Tim had asked her for a private dance, all while we had great sex. I wasn't complaining about it, *per se*, but I was beginning to get confused about what was real and what wasn't.

"Are you making joke with me right now?" she asked, using her Lidiya accent.

I wiped my mouth. "Can you... can we cut it out for just a minute?" I said.

Lynn looked like she was about to say something smart, and then she changed her mind. "What?" she said. "Oh, okay, you're serious."

She rested her fork on the side of her plate. "What do you want to know?" she asked. And then she added, quickly, reaching for my hand: "You know I'm not serious about any of this stuff."

It was like a nice warm blanket. But I wasn't satisfied.

I cleared my throat. "So... you're not going to start dancing?"

She grinned. "Not in a million years."

"But you did dance for Timor?"

She shook her head. "I guess I did," she said disbelievingly. "But it had to have been pretty awful. I was drunk." She held up her hands. "Won't happen again."

I narrowed my eyes at her. "So you're seriously just joking about all of this stuff?"

I felt her foot between my legs. She wiggled her toes over my balls.

I grasped her bare foot and smiled, but pushed her gently away. "I'm *serious*, Lynn," I said.

She smiled again. "I'm just doing all this because you *seem* to like it," she said.

Her foot disappeared from my grasp. "I can stop."

I rubbed my forehead with my thumbnail. "I'm not saying *that*," I told her. "I just... I want to know what's real and what isn't."

"Okay," she said. "Shoot."

I sighed. "Well... one: you're not dancing?"

"Established."

"And two, you danced for Timor and you don't want to do it again?"

"Correcto."

"And... what's your deal with him? Like really?"

She cocked her head to the side. There was a pause, while my insides boiled. "I think he's hot," she said. "But he's an asshole."

"So...?"

"No deal. I just... he's bossy, and Russian, and weird, and... I just want to pay off my loans. So... I tease him a little. But not like, in any serious way."

I smiled at her.

"And he's cleaning up the club?"

She cleared her throat then, and reached for her water. "Yeah, so, since we're on the topic, this is something I needed to talk to you about anyway... he's, uh... I think you have to stop coming in. He's telling all the girls, no more significant others."

I raised my eyebrows. "What? Can he even do that?"

Lynn looked at me. "It's not some hard rule, or anything. He just mentioned it. He prefers that you guys don't come in."

I don't know why this irked me so much. It had a sort of pimp-ish feel about it. I was getting hot on the back of my neck, about to say something, when Lynn shook her head slightly and said: "Well... actually, I don't know. Maybe that's only for the dancers. But either way, it's like, sort of unprofessional, you know?"

I laughed. "Unprofessional?"

Lynn turned sharply toward me. Her eyes were wild. "What's that supposed to mean?" she snapped.

"Just, it's funny, you getting worried about how professional you're being at a strip club -"

Lynn cut me off. She was ticked.

"Lynn," I said, reaching across the table for her arm.

She fished a nearly transparent, long cream-colored sweater out of her purse. She pulled it over her body in jerky movements. "Just for the record," she said icily, "that *unprofessional* job is bringing in almost as much money as yours. Sometimes more."

She stood up and pushed her hair out of the way, walking toward the door.

"Lynn," I said, scrambling to get out of the booth. "Lynn, stop."

She turned around to face me, her features set sharply on her face. She was still by the booth, and I reached for her wrist, to try and keep her from leaving.

“I just meant,” I said, trying to calm her down. “It’s not like a job in your field, that’s all, so it’s funny that you are worried -”

“I almost have my student loans paid off, did you know that? And that’s because I take that job seriously.”

“I wasn’t saying you didn’t, I just -”

“Good. So shut up. And fuck off.”

She stormed down the hallway to the bathroom. Which at least wasn’t the exit, because there is nothing more embarrassing than driving slowly behind a pissed-off woman and pleading with her to get in the car.

Lynn was a real firecracker, in case you haven’t picked up on that by now, so I knew better than to try and talk her out of her mood when she got back. We’d had that kind of fight before (said every man married to a woman, ever), so I wasn’t really worried about the fight itself.

It just seemed strange that Lynn got so riled up about a waitressing job. Had I missed something? Every indication she’d given me was that it was a temporary thing, that she was doing it for fun and money and planned to ditch it as soon as she got a “real job,” which as far as I could tell, she was still looking for.

She said nothing when she came back, but at least she didn’t stomp off. I decided to let her cool off. She was silent all the way home, and then she disappeared while I was in the bathroom, where I often end up after Rosario’s kitchen.

There was a note on the counter.

*Had to go to gym. Sorry about fight. Love you, L.*

## CHAPTER 7

I don't know how most guys feel about it, but I'm not usually inclined to bring up a topic that pissed my wife off that much, so I kept my thoughts about the conversation from that evening to myself. And things went on much like before, except now the slight suspicions I had nurtured for the fun of it were becoming well-fertilized, large vines of tangled emotions and dark, intrusive thoughts: convictions that Lynn was having secret affairs. If I let myself really get going, I could believe she was fifteen minutes late because she had been turning tricks in the infamous back room at Liquid Kitty.

Inside, I was torn: half of me wanted to plead with Lynn to quit that job. It was too wild, too seedy, too dangerous, too disruptive to our lives.

The other half of me, and maybe this was more like a 50.01% because it seemed to win out, wanted to see where this would all go. It was the part that stopped me from telling Lynn to quit. The part of me that secretly hoped to catch her coming through the door with a pearl of cum nestled in the corner of her mouth.

Strictly speaking, there was no reason to suspect Lynn of doing anything but waiting on tables at a strip club, and flirting to get more tips – all of which she had told me about, let me watch her doing, and which it was hard to deny that I liked.

I liked the new boss, and the subtle changes in Lynn, a lot less. There was something dark, but also delicious, about this guy telling my wife that her husband wasn't welcome at the club. There was something about him – even though he was no more than a fabled presence to me at that point – that irked me. Something about the way Lynn talked about him that bugged me.

Then there was the dancing. Was she actually doing it? Why had she teased me about it like that?

I started going through her purse, counting her money, looking at the bills and trying to determine if they seemed like they'd been stuffed inside someone's panties. But she came home with suspiciously crisp twenties, and no more than she had made as a waitress.



That should have been enough to get rid of my suspicions, but for some reason it wasn't. If she seemed more tired than usual, I attributed it to dancing. If she was more horny than usual, I attributed it to dancing.

So of course, I eventually found myself driving from a dentist appointment back to work the long way, calling in to say I wasn't coming back to work, driving past Liquid Kitty in the stark light of the afternoon, and then parking.

And going in.

Lynn saw me as soon as I walked through the door, and for a moment she looked confused.

Her confusion quickly shot through her eyebrows, into high-arched, Valkyrie fury, and she snatched her tray table and headed straight for me, nostrils flaring.

I have to make a confession: I find it really hot when my wife gets this mad. I could feel the heat building inside of me, my stomach knotting, my heart beating faster. Add the glittery, trashy girls to the equation and I was pretty amped up.

But by the time she crossed the room, she seemed to change her mind about getting mad. It was actually a little schizophrenic the way she changed as she approached the table.

By the time she got there, she had a sweet smile on.

"Can I get you a drink, big guy?" she said, her hip jutted to one side, the tray resting on the bone, suspended by her long, toned arm. She was using her Lidiya accent, though it seemed a little half-hearted.

"Uh," I said idiotically, because the way she had looked a moment before, I had expected her to come over, spit at me that I had to leave, and storm off. "Uh... sure, what do you recommend?"

Lynn's eyes narrowed slightly, but that was the only indication that she was wary of me, or even knew me. She gave a slight jerk of her chin, and then smiled.

She leaned over my table, resting her hand on the edge of it, pushing her breasts together with her arm. She brought a pen to her mouth, letting her perfect whites close down suggestively on the end of it. "Well," she said. "Everything here is *very good*, but I'd have a White Russian if I were you."

Her voice was low and sultry, and she let her heavily shadowed eyes close, half-sleepily. Her breasts looked twice as large, plumped up by the dress and the way she was squeezed her arm toward her body.

And her lips, closing around her pen. So full, so wet in the lights, so red.

“Why’s that?” I managed to say.

She tapped the pen on her teeth and smiled again. She seemed to have been overtaken by another woman. “I like White Russians,” she purred, “because they’re creamy, and sweet, and burn just a little going down.” She let me think on that for a moment.

“Just. Like. me.”

I swallowed. “I’ll have one of those, then,” I said.

She smiled at me.

“And what are you doing here?” she asked, still looking at her pad. The smile was gone, as well as the accent, under cover of her order-writing, which she spent a lot more time doing than she needed to.

“I don’t know,” I said, helplessly. “Maybe I wanted to watch you at work. Maybe I just wanted to say hi. You are my wife, after all.”

Then she sent a chill through me by looking over her shoulder, as though she were worried about something. When she turned back to me, she tapped her pen nervously on the order pad. “Listen,” she said, looking a little nervous. “I told you. Tim’s not too big on significant others being here. It was cool with Jessie, but these are the new rules.”

“I can’t come in here and spend money?” I asked incredulously. “It’s not like I’m not paying.”

Lynn, who only moments before had looked unflappable and cool as ice, looked flustered now. She gave another glance over her shoulder. “He doesn’t like it,” she said. “It’s his business.”

I shrugged. “He doesn’t know who I am,” I countered.

Lynn’s face seemed to grow noticeably paler, which is really a feat if you’re slathered in make-up in the dark light of a strip club. Her lips parted, and her eyes swam quickly beneath her sea of black eyelashes. Her head began to make yet another turn, but she stopped herself.

“Okay,” she said. “Stay for a while if that’s what you want. I don’t want to fight about it here. But just... don’t make a scene, or do anything that like, I don’t know, would tip your hand. I don’t want to lose my job.”

“You’d lose your job?” I asked, again incredulously. There *had* to be some kind of law against that.

She rubbed her forehead with a fingernail. “Why are you making this hard? I don’t know. I think maybe. Look, Tim really doesn’t like any drama.”

Now, I was really annoyed. It was one thing to have some guy coming in and running a club, trying to get my wife to dance at a club when she really didn’t want to, but quite another to have her acting like some brow-beaten prostitute who had an unruly pimp, which was vaguely what this whole scene was reminding me of.

“Lynn, what the hell-?”

“Rick,” she hissed. “I do not need this. Either stay quiet, or get out, or... or I’m going to bounce you. I’m serious.”

She spun around and went to the bar.

As she moved away from me, and I sat there fuming, I saw *him*. He sort of oozed onto the dance floor from behind a closed door I had never noticed, one tucked away in a far corner of the club with a terrible view of the stages. The door was painted the same color as the wall, black, and he emerged like the devil from the darkness beyond.

There was no mistaking the man, a dark-haired, steely-blue eyed young guy with decidedly Slavic features and an alpha-wolf stare that moved slowly around the room, surveying all that was unmistakably his. His stare went round like a lighthouse light, and then paused on me, sending a knife of undiluted fear through my chest for no good reason except that he had that mafioso veneer. The gaze went in reverse, back to Lynn, and then paused, his eyes narrowing.

Calculating.

I felt like someone was digging fingernails into my heart. The eyes started moving again, barely pausing on me, taking in the rest of the club. He straightened his jacket, said something to the henchmen who had come out of the hidden door behind him. They were rough-looking, steely-eyed Slavs as well, but they were clearly subservient to the infamous Tim.

He surveyed his domain one last time, then turned on his heel and walked back to the stairs that led to the upstairs offices.

I turned my gaze to the stage. The upstairs offices, I knew, had one-way glass looking out on the club, and if Tim the Russian went up there, he would see me and everything I was doing. And quite suddenly, what had

been lighthearted fun at Liquid Kitty – even with all of its emotionally dangerous moments – now felt extremely dangerous and dark.

You had to see him. He was the kind of no-nonsense guy who carried a gun on every limb, under an expensive tailored suit that only a very rich man could afford. His face was steely and uncompromising, a little bit of manly black stubble on his hardened jaw.

Most frightening of all, he had this look in spite of being very young.

Lynn was coming back. My stomach was flopping in my abdomen. I didn't want to act like a pussy, but I kept my eyes on the stage as I spoke to her. "Lynn, that guy back there in the blue suit that just went upstairs, that's your boss?"

She started to turn, and I hissed, "Don't *look*,"

"Black hair?" she said. "It's him, why?"

Lynn's voice was accent-free, and coiled up tight as my asshole felt.

I tapped my finger on the table. "He looks like a *real* mafia guy," I said.

Lynn pressed her lips together.

Then she said, "You watch too many movies. So do I. He's actually a nice guy, he's just... no nonsense. He wants a professional club, without all the stupid crap that was going on here before."

"What stupid crap?" I said.

She rolled her eyes. I was starting to think I *was* maybe watching too many movies.

"Just... stupid crap. You know? Drama. Boyfriends coming in and starting fights with guys, girls crying because of schedule changes, kids in the back, stuff like that."

I stared at her.

"I don't think you should be working here anymore," I said, my eyes on the stage. Maybe I had watched too many movies, but Tim the Russian was kind of freaking me out, whether he was a mafia man or a savvy business guy.

I looked up at her.

Lynn stared back at me. I couldn't get a good read on the expression on her face. She closed her eyes and opened them, slowly, an expression of annoyance. "It's fine," she hissed. "Look, I'll talk to you about it when I get home. Just... please. Drink your drink and maybe get out of here."

I did my best to look taken aback. "Or *what*?"

I was getting sort of aggressive now.

Lynn rolled her eyes. “Or I’ll lose my job. And you know what? I want to pay off my loans, okay? So just....” She gave a sigh of exasperation. “Please. Just, let’s talk about it later.”

I started to fish some money out of my jacket.

“Oh, God,” she said sourly. “It’s on me, you dummy.”

She spun and walked away.

I stared after her, and then remembered the upstairs windows. I had to force myself not to look up at the mirrored glass, behind which I imagined Tim’s narrowed Slavic, potentially mafia, eyes staring at me. I burned a hole into the stage, and the unusually tall and thin dancer who was sliding into the splits against the pole.

After a few seconds, the set ended, and there was no reason to look at the stage, but I kept my eyes there anyway, burning up on the inside. I wanted to make a scene, but I knew Lynn would never forgive me. I couldn’t even put my finger on what I was so mad about: everything she’d said made perfect sense. You could see how girls would get catty and boyfriends would be a problem at a place like this.

After a minute or two, I saw someone approaching Lynn in my peripheral vision. I turned my head just enough to take in the scene: one of the guys who had been standing by Tim was standing close to Lynn, saying something to her.

I looked over at her. She was standing with arms out to the bar, not especially perturbed by whatever he was saying.

The guy left, and she swung back and forth at the bar with a smile on her face. She was chatting with the bartender.

She turned her head and looked right at me. “Go home,” she mouthed.

She moved some things around on the bar, turned away, fluffed her wig, and walked calmly toward the stairs. I stared at the stage, seeing nothing as Kandy Stripe returned. Nothing but the vision of Lynn’s white-blond hair as it bobbed up and down on each step, up and up, until it was gone, followed by her ass, her legs, her black boots.

My phone vibrated in my jacket pocket.

I took it out to look at it.

[Lynn]: *GO HOME!!!! talk later*

I slipped the phone into my jacket and stared at the stage, sipping my White Russian as slowly as humanly possible. My chest was tight and my stomach was flipping, but it was with a new and different, and quite unpleasant feeling.

A Liquid Kitty uniform appeared in front of me: legs, black plastic boots, straps across the chest. The face below a red wig swam in front of me.

“You want another one, hun?” the girl drawled. Her features came into focus: petite nose, blue eyes. A combination of features that somehow screamed white trash. Her body was hot as hell, though, and her head was framed not by a wig but a magnificent halo of stunningly gorgeous mahogany hair that pretty much made up for her lackluster features.

I ordered another drink – just vodka, straight up, in case anyone was watching.

I’d go home, I had decided.

But not right at that moment.

I still had my fucking pride.

\*

Staying at Liquid Kitty, to petulantly watch Kandy Stripe in her pink and white stockings, had not given me quite the rush I had been looking for. When I saw black boots clomping down the stairs in the corner of my eye, I skedaddled before Lynn could see that I was still there.

I had the entire night to stew once I did get home. I stewed, and stewed and stewed. I got drunk, blindingly so, and then had time to sober up, which wasn’t fun but was advisable because I was so blottoed I wasn’t even making any sense to myself around 12:00.

I took out my phone several times and stared at Lynn’s message, replaying what I had seen in the club over and over and over again. It had such a sinister quality to it, I wasn’t actually enjoying myself all that much, not even in the perverse way I usually did.

*Tim.*

What the fuck kind of Russian let himself be called Tim? Certainly not a guy who looked like that.

Or, maybe... a guy who looked like that, emanating such raw power, just called himself whatever the fuck he wanted. Bunny. Francis.

Whatthefuckever.

I fell asleep briefly, but woke up with a raging headache at 4:00.

I then stared at the clock as it ticked away, right past 4:30.

At 4:37 I started to write a text to Lynn. I thought better of it for two reasons: she was probably driving home at this moment, and if she wasn't, and she was sucking Tim's cock at this moment, then I didn't want to look like...

What?

A fool? A pussy? Like I felt the way I actually had, sitting in the club, getting that guy's icy stare thrown at me?

My cock was pulsing, but a whole different thing was making it do that. I had a similar problem when I climbed a ladder. Erotic terror? I wouldn't even know what to call it.

The scratch of the key in the door sent a wave of relief jolting through me. I was sitting in the living room with a glass of water, trying to sober up, assuming (as people trying to sober themselves up do) that I was doing a pretty good job. I straightened up and wiped a drop of spittle from the corner of my mouth.

Then I tried to harden my features.

Lynn was in the kitchen for a while. I heard the soft shuffle of mail, the opening and closing of the fridge. I could see through the door, at an angle, to the counter. It was only then that I realized I was sitting in the dark, like a burglar, but it was too late to do anything about it.

A soft blue glow replaced the bright streak of light from the fridge. I could hear the light tapping of Lynn's fingers on her phone. A low buzz as replies to texts came in. The light moved, the shadows grew long and distorted, and then I saw her face, floating above the darkness and her phone.

She leaned on the counter, staring into the phone in her hand.

My eyes took a while to get used to the darkness, to see the contrasts of the light on her face enough to make out her features.

A smile turned up the corner of her mouth. She rested her head on her chin and typed. Then she smiled again, and the light went out.

She had a glass of something in her hand and brought it to her lips in the darkness.

The phone on the counter lit up again, and she looked down at it before reaching to pick it up.

I heard her laugh quietly.  
She set it down, shaking her head, without writing a reply.

She pulled her hair from a ponytail. She was back to her long brown hair, and she ran her fingers through it absentmindedly, a smile on her lips still, staring at the wall in front of her.

Suddenly, she snatched the phone, and typed a response to whoever she was writing to, smiled at her cleverness, and sent it. She set the phone down again.

I was thinking about how to tell her I was there without scaring her. I was trying to think of the things I had wanted to ask her, what it was I had meant to talk to her about before she got home, but all of that had flown out of my head as I watched her with her phone.

The phone lit up again, the low rumble of the alert grainy on the marble counter-top. She snatched it up, and read it, her lips slightly parted, a smile slightly forming. She shook her head, and she whispered something as she typed, still shaking her head.

She didn't set the phone down while she waited for the reply, which came immediately and seemed to shock her a little.

I leaned on my knees to watch her.

She held the phone away from her, and for a second she looked like an old person who couldn't read without sticking the phone a few miles away from their face.

I couldn't make out her expression.

She set the phone down, and looked at the wall for what seemed like an eternity. Then, suddenly she laughed, loud enough that I heard her. She turned abruptly and disappeared into the dark kitchen.

I heard the back door slide open, and Lynn began to say something outside, clicking and cooing.

The cold air snaked through the house. She had obviously stepped outside, her voice growing more distant.

Time went on, and Lynn didn't return immediately.

I rose from where I was, and crept into the kitchen.

I admit to imagining scenarios in which Lynn had snuck outside to embrace her Slavic lover in the backyard, as obviously stupid as that might be. Rest assured, I was as confused by that scenario as I was by whatever it was my wife was actually doing in the backyard, and my ordinarily creative mind was having a hard time figuring it out.



The night was very cold, unusually so. I could just make out Lynn's dark shape in the small fenced yard, close to the fence – was she *climbing* on it? She had her black thigh-high boots on, and the dark black satin hoodie. Her thighs were dangling from her uniform.

She hadn't changed.

And what on earth was she doing? I could vaguely hear her voice from outside.

I considered turning on the light, catching her at whatever it was, but it was so deliciously nonsensical, I really wanted to just watch it.

The woman who lived behind us was about eighty, so my wife certainly wasn't running over there for an affair.

Lynn was bending down now, and then there was a flash in the yard. It illuminated her, leaning over toward the ground, her white thigh in sharp contrast against her black boots, her short dress hiked up to almost her bottom, the hoodie obscuring the shape of her torso, her brown hair hanging almost to one bent knee.

What the fuck?

I heard her laugh again, and then she stood up and the blue glow of her phone illuminated her, just barely, as she evidently sent the photo she had just taken.

I watched her figure as she headed back to the house. She cursed when she almost fell, twisting on something in the backyard, no wonder with those crazy boots. I stood just inside the door, watching her.

She was looking at the ground, so she didn't see me until she reached the concrete porch and looked up.

She shrieked, really loudly, which is Lynn's response to anything that surprises her. She then let out a stream of filthy cusswords, which is her next response. This is for spiders, mice, things tumbling out of the junk closet, and ill-conceived surprise birthday parties you've invited her grandma to.

"Jesus fucking shitchrist, you fucking *asshole!*" she hollered, which is pretty much the same thing she said at her party. She threw her hand up to her chest and breathed heavily, then stomped into the kitchen. "Why in the raving, hellchrist *fuck* are you sneaking up on me like that, you fucking crazy psycho?"

This is also very similar to what she said at her party, except in between "hellchrist fuck" and "fucking crazy psycho" she said something

like “making me think I’m at a fucking intervention.”

Lynn gets pretty wild with the f-bomb when she’s scared.

“What the hell are you doing in the yard at...” I flipped my watch over and shook it to get it to light up, “Five-ten in the morning?”

I tried to stop there, but I was full of suspicions, so I continued: “And why are you home so late?”

Lynn slammed the door shut and locked it. “You’re going to wake the whole fucking neighborhood up.”

I boiled over with something I wouldn’t call rage, or jealousy, but it was some black mix of the two.

She looked at me. Then she pushed her hand through her hair. “I’m *late*,” she said, “if you can even call it that, because the place was trashed tonight. And I’m outside because I was -”

And here she paused. Not long, hardly even long enough for me to notice. But it was just long enough to betray that she was looking for an explanation, modifying what she said next, calculating.

“I was trying to get a picture of Mrs. Heeley’s cat. You know, the black one?”

Her eyes were moving. She was a few steps ahead of her words, thinking.

“Oh,” I said. “Oh, *okay*.”

I threw my hands up in the air in exasperation.

She folded her arms across her chest. “It was for a *joke*,” she said.

I looked at her. *I’m waiting*, my face said.

It was at this moment that I realized that Lynn was fairly drunk. She wobbled a little on her heels. She hiccupped and leaned over to undo her zipper. “God,” she said, stepping down and out of one boot. She leaned on the counter to unzip the other one, and almost fell.

“Did you drive home?” I snapped.

She glared at me. “That’s the other thing,” she said. “I had to take a cab.”

The cat was forgotten for a moment. “I thought you said you weren’t going to start getting into that party scene at work?”

Lynn stepped out of her other boot. “Oh, Jesus, Rick. Don’t start with me, okay? I worked two shifts, I didn’t make any money, Tim was offering everyone free drinks, and I got to talking and having a good time, okay? What, you never did that after work? Ever?”

She walked, less-unsteadily, to the island and snatched up the glass of wine she had been drinking.

I didn't like it; I didn't like any of it. But considering that Liquid Kitty closed at four, she wasn't *really* home all that late.

Instead of saying something conciliatory, though, I found myself saying:

"I thought Tim didn't like any of that 'funny business' at his club."

Lynn lowered her glass and gave me a sharp-edged look. Then she set the wine glass down loudly, so much so that I thought it had broken.

"You know what?" she snapped. "I'm going to bed. You..." she waved in my direction. "You just... ugh. We'll talk about it tomorrow. I'm too drunk. Goodnight." She trudged toward the doorway. "I need a ride to get my car," she slurred, waving backward in my direction. "Gestapo-man."

## CHAPTER 8

I was so stunned, and confused, by Lynn's behavior, that I just stood there for about ten minutes, trying to make sense of it, and trying to calm down.

By the time I had recovered my composure, and stormed to the bedroom, Lynn was already in bed. Her dress was crumpled on the floor, and she was lying with the covers pulled over from my side of the bed as a blanket, wearing only her panties.

My eyes dropped to her phone, which was suspended over the floor in her hand. It would slip from her fingers any minute.

And I wanted that phone.

"Lynn," I said loudly, because she was not ordinarily a quick nor a sound sleeper. It was so obvious, though, that she was genuinely asleep, that I walked over to her, stood looking down at the phone in her hand for only a moment, and then took it from her hand.

She didn't stir.

I started to rifle through her phone right then and there, to see what was up with this mysterious cat picture, and anything else I could find, when I realized that if she woke up I would look like a real asshole.

I left, walking quickly to the office and shutting the door behind me.

My heart was racing, and I wasn't even sure why. Lynn's story was not crazy, not implausible, and yet I had this excited, nervous, devastating, arousing feeling inside of me that *wanted* to find something wrong with the story, something sinister about what she had been doing tonight.

I was hoping, as my fingers swept through her phone, *hoping* to catch her having an affair or doing something terrible, like turning tricks.

None of it added up, though, and I knew this in the back of my mind. Lynn really did work at Liquid Kitty, and it really did close at four, and she really had gotten home at five, so -

My heart skipped a beat. Violently.

I had gone to the most obvious place: her conversations on messenger. There, at the top of the list, the most recent conversation, was the name "TV," and the first few words of a message:

*I see she is very shy. Maybe she likes caviar?*

My eyes narrowed. My gut went cold.

*Tim.*

Tim what? I wondered. Probably some insane Russian name.

I pressed on the conversation.

The most recent message was from “TV:”

[TV]: *any man would be flattered to receive such a picture*

The message following that one was from Lynn. There *was* a picture. It was, as Lynn claimed, a snap of Mrs. Heeley's black cat, green eyes flashing angrily, blurry, half of the cat out of the shot.

My eyes moved up the screen, and as they did, a slow-moving cold moved through my torso.

And the following slowly unraveled, backward in time, a flurry of words, innuendo, lines of flirtatious content. Up, up, backward in time, and the words just kept coming.

The text hit a wall. The first message from TV was from today, at 2:37 am.

[TV]: *It's me*

[TV]: *you have something white on your tail*

[TV]: *are you still downstairs?*

[Me]: *I have to get home*

[TV]: *come up there's someone I want you to meet*

[Me]: *my Uber driver?*

[TV]: *I have caviar*

[Me]: *American girls are not lured by that.*

[TV]: *Not even pussy cats?*

[Me]: *overusing that*

[TV]: *OK wait I will send a car for you*

[Me]: *next time, I just jumped in my uber*

[TV]: *my car is more luxury*

[Me]: *this is a really nice car tbh*

[TV]: *tbh?*

[Me]: *to be honest. Don't you have someone to meet?*

[TV]: *that was lie to get you upstairs pussy cat*

[Me]: *what about the caviar*

[TV]: *not lie. All rich russian have caviar*

[Me]: *where do you keep it?*

[TV]: *secret*

[Me]: *it's your pocket isn't it?*

[TV]: *I'm laughing out loud pussy cat*

[Me]: *you don't seem like the type.*

[Me]: *See you tomorrow boss*

[TV]: *did you get home okay pussy cat*

[Me]: *you're pushing it*

[TV]: *I don't know what that means*

[Me]: *you have to stop saying pussy so much*

[TV]: *I like to talk about cats. I love cats*

[TV]: *To tell truth, I did not understand name of club until tonight*

[Me]: *I admit to laughing out loud*

[TV]: *it is not such a big step. You laugh a lot. I like it. So you are home*

[Me]: *goodnight T*

[TV]: *can I get proof?*

[Me]: *of what*

[TV]: *that my pussy cat is home safe*

[Me]: *oh my god. Some b-grade movie just called, they want their lines back*

[TV]: *I do not understand*

[TV]: *I just want a picture of your pussy*

[TV]: *I am so sorry. This was mistake of grammar.*

[Me]: *right.*

[Me]: *but you would like a picture of my pussy, wouldn't you?*

[TV]: *any man would be flattered to receive such a picture*

The last message from Lynn was the photo of the cat.

I smiled in spite of myself, in spite of the flirtatious banter that had unspooled in front of my eyes.

I read, and re-read, the messages, the conversation, trying to imagine how it had begun.

There was no doubt that TV, who I also had little doubt was the mysterious Tim, was hitting on my wife. Any way I read the messages, it seemed certain he was trying to seduce my wife.

After all, he was a man.

I remembered his alpha-male stare, his young, good-looking face, and the insinuation of muscles, tattoos, and scars beneath his well-tailored suit, and I felt sick.

Would it be so hard for a man like that to seduce my wife?

And while anyone could read into my wife's messages that she had tried to shut her boss down in a humorous way, the most realistic reading of her texts was that she wasn't *exactly* shutting him down.

In fact, she almost seemed to be luring him in, if you took it a certain way.

Which of course I did.

If I had been texting with a woman who looked like Lynn, I would have only become more intrigued by her, if she had sent me those texts, rather than throwing herself at my feet.

The question was: were those Lynn's intentions? Did she mean to be clever and alluring, playing hard-to-get to make herself more appealing to a man like Tim, or was she up to something else? Was she trying to keep a man who was obviously after her at arm's length without offending his obviously inflated ego, so that she could keep her job and pay off her loans?

I stared at the texts until my eyes itched, interpreting them one way and then the other.

Which one did I want it to be? The woman fending off a dangerous boss, just to keep working and make a little more money?

Or the wife secretly luring a bad boy in, lying to her husband, plotting an affair with a Russian mobster?

When I snapped out of it, it was bright outside and hours had passed.

I tiptoed back to the bedroom, my heart pounding. Lynn rarely drank so much that she passed out immediately like that, and when she did, she slept for about three hours and then had what she termed "alkie-wakie." I had to get the phone back to her before she woke up.

Halfway to the bedroom, I took my own phone out. With my hand shaking, I took a picture of her text messages to “TV.”

The feeling of doing that was very similar to the feeling of retrieving dirty magazines from under my brother’s bed while he was out of the house, and reading them in my closet.

I wasn’t sure if that was a genuine thrill, or a guilty pleasure, or what.

I placed the phone on the floor beneath her hand, and she slept on. Hopefully, nothing would appear amiss.

And then I drove myself to the Qwicki-mart, because after ten years of not smoking, I suddenly needed a cigarette.



## CHAPTER 9

After reading my wife's texts with Tim, I waded off into the deep end. I can't remember exactly how I got from spying on her texts, which I could have just talked to her about, to breaking into her bank accounts and student loan servicing. I don't know how I got from there being a plausible explanation for what she was doing with Tim and her texts, to being convinced that she was having a full-fledged affair.

It's like this: you can see a set of facts, and if you're actually outside of those facts, and you have no stake in them, you might be able to see them objectively. You might be able to see that there are simple explanations for everything, and also sinister and conspiratorial ones.

But if you are inside those facts, and it's your wife, and you both want her to be having an affair, and don't, it becomes very difficult to see anything clearly anymore.

The thing that really put me over the edge was the fact that Lynn's student loan debt had decreased *drastically*. I couldn't see the payments, but I could see the end balance. And if my recollection of her debt when she finished school was correct, she had paid the debt down by almost \$20,000 in not even four months.

Perhaps someone could assume that this was possible, if she hadn't spent any money on anything else. But that would have required her to make the maximum amount of tips every single night, and then not spend one single dollar on anything else. Not her car payment, gas, a martini with the girls, new clothes, a gym membership, *nothing*. And I knew for a fact that she hadn't asked me for a dime since she had started working at Liquid Kitty, so she had to be spending some money on herself.

And Lynn wasn't exactly frugal.

So the money didn't add up, not by a long shot.

Unless... Lynn *was* dancing.

Or doing something else.

So you can see why I hired a private investigator, right?

Sid Mulroney was just the kind of guy you expected to be a PI. With a name like that, what else could he have been in life, other than a boxer or something?

His left cheek was rough and patchy, which made him look tough, but in reality came from a bad bout of acne when he was a kid. He was balding, so he had shaved his head, and he bore more than a passing resemblance to Bruce Willis on his good side.

Sid had been a cop, which also gave him street cred, until you found out that he had been essentially a desk jockey, after having a single grand mal seizure that had never repeated itself. He liked being in the field, so he became a PI, which turned out to be infinitely more mundane than it sounded.

Mostly, he did divorces and got things thrown his way from the insurance industry for things like workman's comp and car accidents. It was all pretty boring, if you asked him.

He gave me this history himself, in a dry and flat voice, from behind the desk in his office, which would have looked more at home in the corporate headquarters of... I don't know – Cisco Systems or something. He didn't look like a PI.

Sid's office, however, was reassuringly situated in strip mall, tucked into a weedy lot just beyond an overpass and halfway into an industrial area I'd never even passed through. The other tenants were a Personal Injury lawyer whose commercials blared on daytime TV, a sub shop, a pawn shop, and several closed storefronts with junk in the windows. One such shop read "Photography" on the sign, and had boxes of auto parts in the window.

I'd gotten Sid's name from a guy at work who had hired him about his own ex-wife over something to do with a custody battle.

He told me all about himself, which was a pretty sad story, Death-of-a-Salesman-style, and so I felt instantly at ease being frank about why I was there.

"My wife says she's waitressing at a strip club, and I think she's dancing or maybe something else. She's made a lot of money in the past four months."

Sid was unaffected by this statement. "How much?"

"Maybe thirty thousand," I said.

Sid didn't blink. "What club?"

“Uh...” I said. This guy didn’t have anything else to say about that figure? “I mean, is it common for a girl to make \$30K in four months waiting tables at a strip club?”

“No,” he said, instantaneously and without inviting any further comment.

I liked the guy, all right, but what I didn’t like was the uncomfortable feeling of having departed my own life, only to be dropped in an episode of “Better Call Saul.”

“It’s Liquid Kitty,” I said.

Sid made a note of this – and nothing else – on a piece of paper. Then he took out a lengthy form and began explaining our agreement.

“So you want to know, is your wife dancing at Liquid Kitty or just waiting tables?”

I nodded.

“That’s all you want to know?”

I rubbed my thumbs together. “I mean...” I cleared my throat. “Yeah, well... unless there’s some other explanation for it. I guess I would, I would want to know about that, too.”

Sid gave me a hard look, though I have to say, it wasn’t nearly as gangster as it might be sounding from this description. He had an unusually high-pitched, and soft-toned voice, with a mamsy-pamsy accent from someplace down South that came across more Barney Fife than anything else. “I have to explain to you at this point that I just observe, then I write down what I see. I don’t analyze. I don’t speculate. That’s your business.”

He started filling in the forms. I wondered how many guys like me had come to him.

“Anything you’re not telling me?” Sid asked, after licking his fingers to pull apart the pages and give them a once-over. He tapped his pen on the table.

I shook my head.

What can you say to a question like that? There was plenty of stuff I wasn’t telling Sid The Private Investigator.

My wife was hornier than usual.

I kind of wanted to catch her fucking guys for money.

I jerked off to that idea in the shower.

I wasn’t asking her directly about this because I was a pervert who got off on it a little.

I felt like I wasn't living my own life right now.

Etc.

Sid sighed, filled out the forms, had me sign them, the way people who sell cars roll through a contract. He sorted the papers into a nice pile, got out a manila file folder, wrote "Liquid Kitty" at the top, and set it in an inbox.

"I'll do my preliminaries and get back to you by the end of the week."

I walked out into the parking lot, and the sun had come out to light the whole place up with a blazing hot whiteness that made every weed and crack stand out.

I looked back at the office. The tilted, bent blinds were drawn, and I was afraid to walk back in there, anyway.

What was I *doing*? I remember thinking to myself.

But in the end, I just got in my car, and went home. I was going to see how it played out.

## CHAPTER 10

Sid handed me his report, which was about three pages long.

“I want to reiterate,” Sid told me. “I can only report on what I see. Go over it, tell me if you have any questions.” Then he leaned on the counter. “I gotta tell you, though. That place has the feel of something really shady. To that end, I’m not going to agree to do any more surveillance at Liquid Kitty.”

My eyes were moving over the words on the report, and the letters swam in an incomprehensible soup in front of my eyes. I didn’t really even process what Sid had said.

I looked up at him. “Wait... no more surveillance?”

He shook his head. “Not there.”

“What?”

He folded his arms. “Look. I get a bad feeling about that place. Those guys look like organized crime. I’m not gonna get caught taking pictures around this kind of club. So you want some surveillance on your wife at home, anywhere else, sure thing. But I’m not doing Liquid Kitty again.”

“But... so you think they’re, what -”

“I don’t speculate. That’s not my job. But I keep outta things if I have a bad feeling about them. And I have a real bad feeling about this.”

“Like... what? Should I call the cops?”

Sid shook his head.

“Look. Mr. Vistke. I have to tell all my clients the same thing. I can’t do anything but watch the subject, write down what she does, and write that on paper. I can’t tell you what to do. I can’t speculate. So don’t ask me to do that. That’s in our agreement.”

The high-pitched Barney Fife voice was stern now, and it was a little easier to see Sid as a cop at that moment.

The whole scenario was so new to me, and he was creeping me out with all this talk about how sketchy Liquid Kitty was, and I was so preoccupied with finding out what Lynn had been up to, that I just left, in a daze.

I stumbled out of his office and into my car, drove to the next strip mall down in a daze, and parked my car in the middle of the parking lot, facing a busy but horrific-looking Chinese restaurant marooned in the center of the cracked blacktop.

Then I went through his report.

\*

Date: October 18, 2018

To: Rick Vistke

From: Sid Mulroney

Subject Name: Lynn Vistke

File Number: 18-914505

File Type: Domestic Services

File Assigned: September 24, 2018

16:17 Upon arrival at LK, subject's vehicle, a blue Taurus plate #TXC 632, was observed in parking lot adjacent to the LK building, at 5127 Brighton Avenue.

Investigator entered LK and sat at a two-top near the bar with a view of center stage. Investigator observed approximately ten customers scattered through the area. Only the center stage was open. Performer was black and name was never announced. A bartender and one waitress, small, naturally blonde, and not meeting subject's description, was waiting tables. One bouncer was standing by the main door. No other staff were present on the main floor.

At 17:25 subject exited door at the SW corner of the main floor with a man and another woman. The man was approximately six foot five, dark hair, blue eyes, well-dressed. The woman was in her twenties, dark-haired, and appeared to be a stripper at the club as she was dressed in a revealing costume and thigh-high boots. Subject was wearing waitress uniform for LK and hair was down, no wig. The threesome

was talking, the women were smiling, and they proceeded immediately to the stairs on the S wall of the main floor and ascended.

At 19:30 subject descended stairs wearing blonde wig. More patrons had arrived by this time. Investigator observed subject waiting tables for approximately ten minutes and left building under the pretense of smoking a cigarette and to move to a table in the subject's area.

At 20:12 subject made contact with investigator. Subject was flirtatious, speaking with a Russian accent, but made no physical contact with investigator. She brought a drink as requested and attended to other tables. Subject took a second drink order at 20:30

From 20:30 to 21:57 subject waited tables in full view of the investigator. Subject was flirtatious with patrons but investigator did not observe inappropriate or lingering physical contact, nor did subject appear to be doing anything but taking drink orders. The club was busy and subject appeared to be working hard to deliver drink orders. Subject was dressed in waitress costume and did not dance.

At 21:57 the same man, meeting description of owner TV, descended and spoke to the bartender. The man then entered the hallway marked "restrooms." The bartender spoke to the subject at 22:01. Subject delivered a few drinks and spoke to the small, blonde waitress at 22:04. Subject then went to the hallway marked "restrooms."

At 22:06 the subject exited the hallway marked "restrooms"

From 22:06 to 22:15 subject waited on tables. Owner TV did not exit the hallway. At 22:15 subject returned to restroom hallway.

Subject and man exited hallway together at 22:26.

Man returned to upstairs area.

Subject waited tables in full view from 22:26-00:17. Contact was made with investigator to take drink order at 22:30, 22:50, and 23:17. Investigator struck up a conversation with a dancer and moved to the blonde waitress's section in order to avoid suspicion at 23:30 after paying tab to subject. Subject appeared sober, content, and busy.

At 00:17 a different, as yet unseen man, descended stairs and spoke to subject at the bar.

Subject ascended stairs at 00:20.

Subject descended stairs at 01:27.

Subject waited tables from 01:27-02:47. At 03:00, subject spoke to man from upstairs and followed him to upstairs area.

Patrons were cleared from area at 03:27 and subject was not on main floor at that time.

Investigator moved car to parking lot where subject's car was observed upon arrival at LK. Car did not appear to have been moved since observed prior to entering LK.

Subject exited building alone at 04:17.

A white male, sandy-hair and slight build, walked quickly toward subject from LK entrance at 04:18. Subject and male paused at border of parking areas between LK and adjacent lot and spoke for approximately 5 minutes. Subject smoked a cigarette with the male, and then returned to the entrance to LK. Subject entered LK with male, and exited at 04:37, followed by Owner TV.

Investigator observed TV speaking to subject as subject walked to car. Conversation appeared flirtatious. Subject was smiling, TV did not appear angry or confrontational. Subject waved at TV without looking back and entered car smiling. TV stood in LK parking lot until subject exited adjacent lot onto Brighton Ave.



TV made phone call from parking lot, making it impossible for investigator to follow subject without arousing suspicion.

TV entered LK at 04:44.

Surveillance terminated.

\*

Private investigations sound like they're not going to be all that bad, money-wise, but expenses really kick you in the balls, especially if you send an investigator into a strip club. In order to protect his cover, Sid had needed to buy a lot of drinks and tip a lot of waitresses. He also charged me for gas and a litany of other items. In the end, the bill was hefty, and that alone should have put me off the whole thing.

But I could already imagine myself dishing out more money to another PI, to get more reports and grainy photographs of my wife.

Reading the report was almost like watching porn: it had the same, dirty appeal, got me almost as hot, and I couldn't stop going back to it. I couldn't stop looking at the photos of her. They weren't even showing her *doing* anything, and they were hot. I thought about them while I jerked off.

Imagine if I had a photo of her doing something bad. A photo that answered all of my questions, confirmed all of my suspicions...

But what did I know, in the end? What did I even *suspect*? My wife didn't seem to be stripping at Liquid Kitty after all. But she *was* disappearing into back rooms and going upstairs for hours at a time, with Tim the Russian Gangster.

Or following him into the restroom for ten minutes at a time.

I read and re-read the report, unable to see anything but betrayal in the observations. There was nothing else to imagine Lynn doing for an hour upstairs, or ten minutes in the bathroom, besides screwing Tim.

Right? What else could a man imagine? After those flirtatious texts, after seeing the man and his heady, masculine, alpha, *manliness*.

And yet.

I kept going back to the report again and again to find the details that favored a different analysis.

Sid hadn't observed her kissing Tim, or even touching him.

That was something.

And why would they fuck in a filthy strip club bathroom when they had the whole upstairs, which I imagined as an expanse of black leather couches and mirrors and humidors?

All I knew for sure now was that she was waiting tables, just as she'd said, and not stripping.

At least not on the center stage.

But this other thing, this "sketchiness" that Sid had talked about – that was something else entirely.

And I had no way of talking to my wife about that, because talking to her about getting out of Liquid Kitty because it seemed "sketchy" would necessarily involve me telling her I'd hired a PI. And *that* was something I didn't care to explain.

Especially when I had no real evidence that I shouldn't have trusted my wife in the first place.

I lay awake thinking about all of this, in circles, no solution presenting itself. I imagined myself getting some balls and just asking her, straight up, what was going on, or getting some balls and admitting to hiring a PI. Or getting some balls to do anything.

Deep down inside, though, I knew that there was a certain allure to just letting all of this play out. And that in the end, that was probably what I was going to do.

When she came home, I pretended to be asleep. I checked the time: 05:12. She pushed the door open gently, checking to see if I was awake.

I made myself lie still, my heart suddenly racing.

She left, pulling the door quietly shut behind her.

I entered the office at ten the next morning, where Lynn had slept.

She was wearing a dress shirt of mine that I recognized from a box of clothes I had begrudgingly stored in the office. It was old, sort of ratty, and she was planning to donate it to charity. Her Liquid Kitty boots were crumpled on the floor, along with the scrap of a dress. She was using a sleeping bag from the same closet as a blanket.

She opened her eyes and smiled at me, then stretched languidly. "Hey," she said. "I didn't want to wake you up. What time is it?"

"Ten," I said flatly. "I didn't want to wake you either, just wondered where you were."

She put her head on her hand, propping them up on her elbow. "You just getting up?"

"Yeah," I lied.

I had actually been up all night, since she had come home, my heart pounding, re-reading the report from Sid. I had gone out to her car and searched it. I found a pack of cigarettes, but nothing else of interest. I had considered creeping into the office and taking her purse from next to her on the floor, but then thought better of it.

"How was work?" I asked, trying to sound casual.

She gave me a weird smile. "I dunno. About the same. Why?"

"How'd you do?"

She sat up, looking down at the floor, distracted by something else entirely. She was looking for something. She picked up her purse and rifled through it, not without a little bit of panic. "How'd I do?" she parroted. "Wha..."

She seemed to find what she was looking for. She relaxed and looked up at me, and I could see that she was actually processing the question now. She squinted, suspicious. "Like, money-wise?" she asked.

"Yeah," I said.

Her mouth closed like a fish swallowing water, and she gave a little head shake. She had no *idea*, her face was saying. Why would I even *ask* that?

"Uh... I guess like three or something."

"On a Saturday," I said.

She narrowed her eyes again. "I didn't count," she said coldly. "But let me do that now."

She dug into her purse and pulled out her Liquid Kitty satchel. She extracted a wad of cash and started counting the crisp bills with pursed lips.

"I was just curious," I said. "I didn't mean you have to count it -"

"Twenty, forty, sixty, eighty, four, twenty forty, eighty, *five*," she counted, and lifted her eyes to punctuate each hundred count. "...sixty and one, two, three, four. There. Five hundred sixty four dollars."

She threw it on the desk. "You can count it yourself if you want."

"Honey, I'm not -"

"No? Then what are you?" She stood up. "I need to take a shower."

I wasn't really sure what had made her so mad, but I was sure that I did not possess the finesse to be a PI. Sid's warning to me, to not do my

own investigating, rang in my ears.

“Sweetie, look,” I said. “I don’t know what you’re so mad about, I didn’t mean to piss you off with that question, I just... wanted to know if you had a good night.” I held her arms. “I feel a little bit disconnected, is all. I’m sorry I went about it wrong.”

This kind of thing always worked.

But today Lynn raised her eyebrows incredulously. “Right,” she said. “Well, now you’re up to date. I’m going to take a shower.”

I wondered why she needed to do that so hastily, and my imagination started running away with the idea as she pushed past me and walked brusquely down the hall.

I stayed in the office, and waited until I heard the door close. My eyes fell on her purse, which was on the couch tipped over. I looked down the hall, the way you look around before you say something non-PC, and I was about to take a step toward the couch, when I heard the door open and Lynn’s footsteps come stomping down the hall with purpose.

She pushed past me and into the room, taking her purse from off the couch.

I looked at her strangely.

“I need something from in here,” she said.

And then she stormed out again.

I looked at the money, and then fingered the crisp bills. Then I went to the kitchen and stared out the window while the coffee percolated.

I wasn’t crazy, was I, to think that my wife was acting suspiciously *now*? Why would she want to come and get her purse, except if she thought I was going to go digging around in it? And why would she think I’d do that, if she didn’t have anything to hide?

I did take a minute to pause and argue with myself at that point – that I had, in fact, gotten into her phone and sicc’ed a PI on her.

I brewed some coffee, making an especially frothy latte for her. I would propose going out to breakfast to smooth things over.

Lynn dug into her huevos rancheros violently. “Oh God,” she said. “I’m so hungry.” She looked at me. “I’d even eat those gross eggs,” she said. Her mouth was almost full. It was unusual, to say the least, but I saw an opening.

“So... do you get breaks there? I’ve been meaning to ask you, because I always forget. When do you eat, I mean?”

I took a sip of my water and looked at the wall opposite us, just to really underline how casually I was asking this question.

“You mean, at work? Yeah, it’s usually just when it’s slow, you eat something, the buffet if it’s a weekday. Or somebody brings stuff. I just get going and I never eat, is what happens.”

I appraised Lynn’s comments, and the very genuine way she was wolfing her food down. She didn’t *seem* to be lying.

I had yet another pang of guilt, and a wave of doubt wash over me. What if everything my wife was doing was 100% legit, and all there was to this whole story was that I was crazy, and she was a waitress at a strip club making a ton of cash and paying off her student loans?

What if?

*It still doesn’t explain the hour upstairs.*

*It still doesn’t explain why she took her purse when she went to take a shower.*

*It still doesn’t explain a lot of things.*

“When do you think you’re going to pay your loans off?” I said, and Lynn jerked her eyes up to look at me.

“It just seems like this job is really unhealthy. Unhealthy sleep, unhealthy eating...”

Lynn pursed her lips and started cutting her huevos rancheros into little pieces. She cleared her throat. “It’s.. yeah it’s super unhealthy,” she said, to my surprise.

Then:

“Look, I feel pretty guilty about something,” she said, in a low voice. My stomach lurched.

She kept cutting her food.

Then she looked up at me. “Don’t get mad, okay?”

I shrugged. What was there to be mad about, if she felt guilty about fucking her boss?

She switched her fork and knife. “I kind of started smoking again,” she said. “Not that much, just like, after the club, everyone else is smoking, so I just sort of did it. Yeah. Unhealthy, the whole thing.” She took a bit of her food, and chewed, her mind ticking away privately. She wasn’t really

talking to me anymore, but to herself. “I think I should be able to get out of there in like... I don’t know. A couple of months, max.”

I gulped.

“You’ve paid that much of your loans off?”

She shrugged. “Not that much, you know, but...I’m getting pretty tired of it. Being up all night. I just want to save up enough to have a cushion while I look for jobs. I think.”

I stared at her.

She looked up at me. “That answer your question?”

Not really.

I nodded.

We ate most of the rest of breakfast in silence. I was silent because I was so surprised by what she had said, and I didn’t know if I could trust it, or if it was just some way of throwing me off the trail of her affair, or what? She seemed silent because she was thinking, deeply, about something that troubled her.

Her expression was one of a woman who is miles away, and her brow was furrowed slightly, making her look much older than she was.

And now, I was much more suspicious than ever before.

A dark, foreboding feeling was creeping over me. One I could not put my finger on at all, and which I liked even less because of that.

## CHAPTER 11

Monday.

Monday and Tuesday were Lynn's days off.

And now, Monday and Tuesday were days of deep suspicion for me. I had always assumed that Lynn just slept and did laundry, ran errands, and went to the gym. That's what she'd always told me she did, and I had never had any reason to suspect otherwise.

But after the surveillance report from the club, I decided two things: one, I needed to find out what my wife was *really* doing, and two, I couldn't afford to pay another PI to do the surveilling.

So I did what any man would do. I claimed to have a dentist appointment and took off Monday afternoon to surveil my wife myself, against Sid's advice, and against all practical reasoning.

I went to work until eleven, because I figured there was no way Lynn would get out of bed and get going any earlier than that, even for an affair. I came back to the neighborhood, and sure enough, her car was still there. I parked on a side street, drank so much coffee I felt like I needed to piss the whole time, and watched my house like a hawk.

For hours.

Three hours, to be exact, and there was absolutely no movement from my wife, until, at 3pm, she came out of the house in a pair of gray yoga pants and an unflattering parka, her hair up in a bun and no makeup on.

I followed her; she went to the gym.

By then, it was about four. I called her at four-fifteen. My back ached from sitting in the car so long, and I was feeling like an ass. She answered the phone, almost breathless, and I could see a form that looked like hers, through the gym's large glass windows that looked out into the parking lot.

"Hey," I said, not even sure what my plan was. I wasn't even sure what I was *doing*; I'd missed a whole day of work for this and it was turning up nothing. The only discovery I'd made was that stakeouts sucked. That, and that I was a crazy person.

I thought quickly. "Yeah, I... think I'm going to be pretty late tonight."

She breathed into the phone. “Oh yeah? Oh... okay. Well... like, how late?”

I stared at her bobbing form through the window. I was parked at an angle, amid mini-vans and family cars in the center of the parking lot. A woman with kids shrieked at them.

“Uh... why?”

She didn’t seem to have heard the shriek. She panted into the phone. “Just wondering,” she countered. “Do you want me to make your dinner, or what?”

She sounded annoyed.

I was annoyed with myself. I actually *would* have to go back to work, and make up for some of the shit I’d missed today in the pointless wild goose chase. Tonight, I vowed to myself, I’d just ask her about all of this.

“No dinner,” I said, wondering what I was plotting in my subconscious.

She panted some more. “Oh... okay, well. I’m at the gym, so, I’m gonna finish this workout. I guess... I’ll see you later?”

“Okay, sweetie,” I said.

“Bye.”

I watched her figure through the glass. The intention was not to spy on her anymore at that point. I think I was going to look at her whimsically, and then drive away, and plan how I would just talk to her about everything tonight. This was all so silly, I was thinking.

But as I watched her, the elliptical slowed. She climbed off of it, her phone to her ear. I stared as she looked out of the window, as though she were looking for someone.

My heart rate picked up.

Sure, I had a part of my mind trying to be rational. I didn’t *know* what she was doing. She could be calling a friend. Meeting a friend. She could have decided that she wanted to do something herself with her evening.

But the darker side of me saw only that she had called someone as soon as she had found out that I was going to be late. And that, to me, in my current state, was all the evidence I needed to prove that she was having an affair.

So I stayed in the car.

She spoke on the phone briefly, standing by the window and looking up and down the parking lot along the strip mall.



She hung up, stared out the window for a bit – it was too far away for me to see her expression. She got back on the elliptical, and began to exercise wildly. This went on for five minutes or so, and I was just thinking of leaving again, when the elliptical slowed, and she brought the phone to her ear again. She stepped off of the machine, looking out the window.

The conversation was short.

And then my wife, confirming all of my worst suspicions, turned abruptly and disappeared back into the gym.

She emerged about five minutes later.

She was still wearing her workout clothes, and I noted that she hadn't done much with her appearance. She was rushing, skipping through the parked cars with a serious and worried expression on her face.

I saw what I wanted to see; that she was rushing to meet a man, that the man was Tim. But even as I was feeling the wrenching of my gut, I could see all the things that didn't make sense: she looked worried, she was wearing horrible clothes, she was in a hurry... why?

I dismissed the incongruity and followed her as she left the parking lot.

I expected her to head north on Cecilia Avenue, taking her downtown. The direction of Liquid Kitty, the direction of where I thought someone like Tim Vasilyovich would live. But she turned south instead, and then mystified me even further by driving down Cecilia, as it disintegrated into old suburban housing tracts where poorer and poorer people lived. There was nothing here for my wife; no reason to be on this side of town. I couldn't even remember the last time I'd driven through. She had no friends here, there was nothing to visit or do here, and I would hope that Tim the Russian was a better businessman than to live in this oft-forgotten quadrant of town.

She pulled into Lake Heights Mall, a relic from the eighties that barely held on with a Sears in its old May D&F space, and a Kmart and a Ross Dress for Less working as the glue to hold together the oddball collection of tweeny and shoddy stores.

I squinted as I followed her into the parking lot. It was mostly empty; the cars that occupied the spaces were clustered up close. Everything looked run-down and abandoned and the whole thing had an air of danger about it somehow.

What the fuck was she doing?

I didn't want to get too close to her vehicle so I parked between two cars at the far end of one of the vast lots. I drove a very nondescript gray sedan, but I was like a sitting duck out there in the parking lot.

She drove to a parking space in the center of the lot, neither close nor far away, where there were no other cars, and then she turned off her vehicle but didn't get out.

The wait was long. My kidneys were screaming at me now, and my mind was completely blank for the twenty or so minutes we waited. I toyed with the idea of calling her, just to see if she answered or what she had to say for herself.

And then, just as I started to rifle through the car for something to pee in, just as I started thinking again, she got out of her car. I craned my neck to watch her as she walked toward the entrance of Sears. She walked with purpose, as though she had meant to be shopping there all along.

She didn't look back.

I crawled out of the car, wondering how I could follow her into the mall, no longer thinking about the absurdity of any of this, not even thinking so much about her having an affair as genuinely, deeply curious as to what could possibly have brought her all the way out here.

I stood behind a red minivan and looked through the glass, thinking that as soon as she touched the door, I would run across the parking lot to catch up with her.

And just like that, a black, expensive-looking sedan pulled up to the curb. She turned around and stepped into it – the door was open for her – and the sedan sped off, around the corner, and was gone.

The whole thing took me so much by surprise that I stood there, my mouth hanging open, and then turned back toward my car, keys in hand, and made a face at it, as if I expected my car to tell me what to do.

I jumped into the car, started it, and drove through the parking lots in the direction of the sedan. My head was spinning, because all of the possible explanations I had worked up did not seem to fit with what I had just witnessed.

The sedan was gone. I made a full circle around the mall, and saw nothing, so I went around again, knowing I wouldn't find anything. What did I think, she would get into a sedan and park at the mall?

I dialed her number, my eyes getting red and angry, hot tears of frustration threatening to spill over. I didn't expect her to answer, and she

didn't.

I decided, hopelessly, to go back to her car and sit on it. My kidneys began to scream at me, so I parked across two lanes and entered at the main entrance. The mall was mostly empty, the clerks looked at me like I was crazy as I stormed to the restroom.

I searched every corridor as though I thought I'd either see my wife or find some explanation of what I'd just seen.

I called her again, and her phone went straight to voicemail.

I typed a text to her while I was walking, and I almost took a header into a knee-high fountain. I deleted it, and for a million dollars I could not tell you what I wrote.

It smelled like Orange Julius everywhere, though there wasn't one anywhere I could see.

When I drove around to where her car had been parked, I came to a screeching halt in the middle of the aisle.

Her car was gone.

\*

I drove to the office. It was rush hour, and I was on the opposite side of the city, so the first half of my trip, I was in the counter-directional lanes, speeding along, heading in when everyone else was heading out. I hit the sluggish traffic to the northwest side of town where Tolmax offices were tucked away in the foothills, and time dragged along like my car, in a sea of red lights, with no escape.

I replayed what I had seen over and over again, a knot in my stomach. What had been scintillating fun only days before now felt dark and dangerous, but not only that, seemed impossible to explain.

I lost interest in attempting to get any work done, but I drove all the way to the Tolmax exit to turn around and head back home. By then, the traffic was thinning, it was seven o'clock, and I could arrive home at the time I'd told Lynn I would arrive.

She called me just after I merged with the southbound traffic.

"Did you call me?" she asked. "Earlier?"

Her voice sounded strange to me. Almost hostile. Or was it frantic, beneath an attempt to be calm? I couldn't read it.

"I...uh, yeah, I called you," I said uncertainly. "But I forget why."

“You coming home now?”

I frowned. She sounded, actually, sort of bitchy. Like she was about to chew me out for something. Like she wanted me to get there so she could get something over with.

My stomach felt cold. Was she finally going to confess to her affair? Did I even want that?

Was she even having an affair?

“Rick?” she said. “Are you there?”

I snapped back into the moment. “Yeah, sorry – traffic. Yeah, yes, I’m almost home. I’ll be there in like twenty.”

She sighed. If I hadn’t known better, her sigh sounded like relief.

“Okay,” she said. “See you.”

And then she added:

“You want me to make dinner for you?”

I stared at the road ahead of me. “No,” I said, my voice cold. “No, that’s okay.”

“Okay.”

“Okay, bye.”

\*

Lynn was deep, deep in thought when I got home. She poured me a glass of wine and suggested that we watch some Netflix together. She had the vacant eyes of a person who cannot escape their thoughts, and was staring through the screen, not seeing anything.

I suppose she might have reported the same thing about me, had someone asked her. But I was absorbed by *her*: what was she thinking about? What had she done that afternoon? Was she simmering in guilt, or was she basking in the glory of some torrid affair?

Or was it something else entirely? Whatever it was, it seemed to be consuming her.

“How’d your day go?” I decided to ask.

She didn’t even get annoyed that I had interrupted a TV program, which I was notorious for doing, especially when she put on a slow-moving drama like this one, a police procedural from the UK that I couldn’t understand at all.

She played with her lip, evidently not hearing me for a few moments, and then she jumped as though she had been stung by a bee. “Huh? What? My day. Yeah... oh, boring.... Gym.... Grocery store... not much.”

Grocery store, huh?

“What’re you so lost in thought about?” I asked.

She shrugged, and hugged herself after giving a brief stretch of her arms and a short yawn. “Oh, God, I’m sorry,” she said. “I think it’s just this job. I really need to get out of it, I feel stoned all day.”

She stood up and swept up my glass. “You want another one?” she asked.

I shook my head.

She yawned again. “I’m having a Rum and Coke,” she suggested.

Then she turned and walked into the kitchen.

I followed her, after pausing the TV, and watched her make a drink with Diet Coke and a hefty amount of rum. I peered into the fridge for signs of groceries, but I wouldn’t have known if they were new or old, to be honest. We hadn’t eaten at home much since she had started working at Liquid Kitty.

“That’s quite a drink,” I said, eyeing her Rum and Coke.

She crunched an ice cube, staring right through me, and said, vaguely, “yeah.”

It was obvious she hadn’t heard me. She stood there for a minute, so I snapped my fingers in front of her, and she blinked slowly, coming back to reality.

“Sorry,” she said. “I’m...”

“You’re miles away. What are you so deep in thought about?”

She became annoyed. “God, nothing. I’m just thinking. I’m sort of drunk. I’m tired.” She took a swig of her drink and turned to head back to the living room. “God. Cut me a break.”

I stared at her, and then followed her into the living room. We re-settled on the couch. I couldn’t concentrate on anything, and I was looking for the right way to start a conversation with her, to find out what was on her mind, maybe tip her in the direction of confessing.

She slammed the glass on the table before I could get going. “I’m sorry,” she said, reaching out to press pause and turning toward me. She was wearing the same gray yoga pants, the same running shirt. She pulled on the sleeves. “I had a weird day. I had...”

She cut herself off at that point, and seemed like she got a little choked up.

I could feel the cool bile of jealousy snaking through me. Then, like a shot of adrenaline, I was suddenly on fire, confrontational, not able to contain myself any more.

“Are you having an affair?” I blurted.

Lynn’s face went white. The pallor, the suddenness with which it grasped her, turned me to ice. I was right, I remember thinking. I had held onto the hope that I wasn’t, the belief that I was imagining everything I had seen with my own eyes.

And yet there she was, as pale as a ghost, caught.

*Caught.*

It gave me a thrill as much as it crumbled my entire world. My blood was fast-moving, my heart racing, my senses acute, a tunnel forming around me. The next words out of her lips would be that she was sorry, and she would tell me all about how she had bent over and let that muscled Russian boy fuck her on his billiard table, over and over again.

Lynn’s lips parted. She was still white.

She shook her head quickly, though. It reminded me of the vicious tug of a dog on a chew toy, rapid and fierce. “God no,” she said. Tears overflowed from her eyes, which is something Lynn didn’t do much of. She wasn’t theatrical. “It’s not that. God.”

She wiped her eyes with both hands, and gave a weak laugh. I stared at her, rage mounting inside of me, my mouth dry and my ears ringing. The fucking bitch, lying to me like this to my face.

I opened my mouth to speak. I was planning to outright accuse her, spit all the evidence at her, see how she would try to weasel out of it when she was faced with me seeing her, spying on her, reading her texts.

“I got myself into something,” she said, in a low voice, cutting me off before I could talk. “And I think I need to get out of it. But I don’t know how.”

The rage boiling inside of me gave a great big shudder, and then popped, like a bubble.

I screwed up my face. “What?” I asked, in disbelief.

She looked at her hands. “Oh God,” she said. Her voice was shaking. “So listen, I’m not supposed to tell you anything about this, okay? At all. But I just can’t... I’m getting too stressed out.”

I pressed my lips together. My head was spinning. Drugs? The things I'd seen this afternoon started to take on an even more sinister light, and I began wishing that she would just tell me she was having an affair after all.

"What did you do?" I said. All I could think of was Tim, his cock inside of her.

She looked up at me quickly and then back at her hands. She took a deep breath and exhaled sharply. "Okay. So... you know how I've been, you know, making a lot of money at Liquid Kitty. Right?"

"Okay," I said, my chest cold.

"Well, so this guy comes up to me one day at the gym, and he gets to talking to me..." her voice trailed off. My body went numb. I tried to move my lips, to put the brakes on my wild imagination.

"It turns out – and you can't say anything about this, okay, you swear? Because it's... it's like, it's so dangerous, and I just have to quit, I have to quit Liquid Kitty tomorrow and I have to... but you just can't say *anything*."

"Lynn," I said quietly. *Get back on track.*

"So he's a cop. The guy. And he works for the Organized Crime Unit, like, undercover. And he tells me all this stuff about... you know, Tim. And I was like, oh, whoa, okay, thanks buddy, I was sorta suspicious about that guy but now I think I have to find another job for sure, and that's what..." she looked up at me, her eyes welling up with tears, "that's what I *should* have done. But this guy is like, ok, I wanted to talk to you about something else, and I was like, forget it, whatever it is, you know?"

Lynn was talking in puzzle-pieces, but I knew her well enough to follow what she was saying.

"When did this happen?" I said, to get her back on track.

She looked at me. "Like. Sheesh, I don't know. Whenever Tim took over the club. Right before that."

"And so, what did you do?"

She looked at her hands again. "I went in to quit. I mean, I don't want to be working for some guy the Organized Crime Unit is trying to get info on, right? But..."

She looked at the ceiling.

I was already putting the pieces together, already seeing the picture, so I didn't even need to ask her about what had happened. The money, the

paid-off loans, the weird cars and meeting places... it all clicked together suddenly.

She was a snitch. Or something like that.

"Holy shit," I said.

She sniffed. "Look, it's all just like, tax evasion stuff, you know? And like, I don't even have to do anything dangerous -"

"What the fuck are you *talking* about?" I burst out, as the picture came into focus. "What the hell were you *thinking*? Why didn't you *say* anything to me?"

She wiped a tear from her eye. "Look, I wasn't going to do it. At all. I... first of all, I kind of like Tim, you know? And then, it was also too dangerous. But then Troy was like -"

"Troy?" And what did she mean, she kind of "liked" Tim?

"My case officer," she said plainly.

"Oh, Jesus Christ," I said. Now my blood was really at a boil, though for a completely different reason.

She put a hand out on my knee. "Look, I know how it sounds. I know how it sounds... *now*. It's, it wasn't like that at first. It was just super easy, all I had to do was tell those guys when Tim was there, what time he arrived, what time he left, and who showed up at that place. That's all. It wasn't hard, I have an agreement I never testify, and they paid me like \$500 a week for that. So I figured, okay, cool, pay off the student loan, I mean... it didn't seem that bad."

I was speechless.

She looked up at me.

"So what happened?" I finally managed to say.

She shrugged. "I don't know. It's... Tim is hitting on me, right? And Troy is trying to get me to, I don't know, take advantage of that."

My heart skipped a beat. "Like have an affair," I said icily.

She shrugged.

"With a mafia guy."

She shrugged. "I don't know. It's... he never said -"

"What the *fuck*? And why would you do all this for \$500 a week when you make that much in a night? And what is the fucking, what are the *rules* about putting *civilians in* with mobsters and -"

"Look, I know," she said hotly. She held up a hand. "Like I said, you can't freak out about this. I'm not supposed to tell you. It wasn't a big deal



at first and then it started to be, so now I just need... I just need a way out.”

I rubbed my head viciously and pulled at my hair. “Quit!” I yelled. “You just *quit*. This is crazy!”

She bit on her lower lip and nodded. Then she sucked in her breath before saying, calmly: “I know. I know that’s what I need to do.”

There was a heavy sense of “but” in the air.

It would only be later that I would realize that what Lynn sounded like in that moment was a cokehead saying she needed to quit, a smoker telling you she knows how bad cigarettes are, or an alcoholic confessing after going on a bender. The kind of resigned and empty admission given by addicts.

But I would only realize that later.

“I can’t believe there is any *doubt* in your mind that’s what you need to do!” I said. “God. Lynn, what the hell were you thinking?”

I suddenly became exasperated. “You shouldn’t have even been working there to begin with. I never should have even let you work there.”

Lynn sat up straight, suddenly peeved. “Excuse *me*?” she snapped. “*Let me work there?*”

I rolled my eyes. “Seriously, Lynn, do not start some feminist bullshit here,” I said.

“*Let me work there?*” She stood up, furious. My heart sank in a completely different kind of way. *God*, I hated this kind of conversation.

“Let me explain something -”

“Don’t start!” I snapped, standing up as well.

“Oh no. You don’t get to be like, getting off on it, bringing your friends to salivate all over me, sitting there with a hard-on because you fucking love it, and then say some stupid thing like that!” Lynn hollered. She pushed past me to head toward the kitchen.

I took a deep breath, trying to calm down and collect my thoughts, but they were like a paper blizzard, and I couldn’t even grasp one of them. Confidential informant, police, gangsters, strippers, feminism, danger, drugs, mafia, dancing, money... I couldn’t even hold one for a second. What the fuck was going on?

I heard a drawer slam and the flick of a lighter.

I stomped into the kitchen. “Are you *smoking*? In our -”

“I told you I was smoking!” Lynn snapped.

“- our *house*?”

Lynn looked at me, and her lips trembled. She looked at the cigarette and then seemed to almost laugh inside. She walked over to the window by the sink and opened it, blowing smoke out and ashing in the sink.

“Oh that’s better,” I said.

Lynn shook her head. “I’m sorry,” she said. “You’re totally right to be angry. I never meant for any of this to happen. I’m... I’m quitting tomorrow, I just wanted to quit and not tell you about any of it, but...”

“I just don’t understand what you were thinking,” I said numbly.

Her eyes flashed at me.

I held up my hands. “Look, okay, what you said is true, it... I was getting off on it, I admit it. But that was the waitressing, and the role-play about stripping. Not the... the other stuff.”

She raised her eyebrows.

Okay, fair enough. Now that I’d had a little time to think on it, and now that she was casually leaning on the counter, smoking sexily in the dim light from the deck, I *did* find it all kind of hot.

She blew smoke in a steady stream out the window.

I did hate smoking, though.

I felt things slipping out of control again.

“The thing is,” Lynn said. “The reason I did it, this guy Troy said he could get me into something in forensics.”

I squinted. “As what?”

“A coroner,” she said icily. “As a fracking forensic linguist, what do you think?”

She slicked ash into the sink.

So, this might be a good time to interject that Lynn’s degree in linguistics had always seemed pretty kooky to me. And not very likely to be lucrative. Also, I had never even understood what she *did*, and about the only thing I *did* know about linguists after all those years was that you should never, ever ask them how many languages they spoke or about Eskimos and snow.

That’s a freebie for you. Also, they do not think much of the cunning-linguist joke.

When she had tacked on “forensic” to “linguist” I had utterly lost the thread. After that, I knew she had told me she’d probably be working in pathology, because she had clinic hours and all this stuff, and a double specialization.

It all amounted to this: I really had never quite understood what the hell she was doing.

So I said:

“Oh.”

“It’s hard to get in in that field,” she said. “Which is why I gave up on it. But if I could just get *in*, then, you know, I’d have it made, and that’s what I always wanted to do.”

She took a drag of her cigarette, and studied the end of it before exhaling, not even aiming for the window.

“I’m just telling you why I did it,” she said at last. “Because you asked.”

None of this really sat right with me.

“Lynn,” I said. “This guy is some kind of gangster. You should really, really *not* be working there. It’s... it’s crazy. It’s gotten way out of hand.”

I was not only thinking of the strip club, and the way it had soured from fun to dangerous, but of myself. I was thinking of how I had actually become the sort of man who hired a private detective to investigate his wife. The whole thing was crazy.

Looking at Lynn, ashing a cigarette in the sink, looking thoughtfully out the window, I realized that the thing I felt was most out of control was *her*.

“Lynn,” I said sternly, when she didn’t say anything back. “I mean it. I want you to quit. Tomorrow.”

Lynn finished her cigarette without answering me, and the air between us grew thick and tense. She blew the smoke out in a steady stream, and then put the cigarette out. “What if I don’t want to do that?” she asked.

There were a few full seconds that she let this hang in the air, and it sounded like a real challenge. While the time passed, my heart accelerated, and I felt like I was in free fall.

It didn’t last long, even it felt like an eternity. Lynn laughed, looking at me through her fake eyelashes. The smokey makeup gave her a devious appearance, and for a second I felt like she wasn’t even the same person. “I’m kidding,” she said lightly. “Of course you’re right.”

She slinked over to me and rested her arms on my shoulders.

My cock was so hard I thought I would burst. I couldn’t get my head around what had just happened, why I found it so erotic when she said *what*

*if I don't want to do that?* Her red lips, the scent of cigarettes and rum, her lips still cool from the drink, her warm body against my chest...all of it swirled together and cast a spell over me.

She slid her hands down my body, and we made our way wordlessly to the bedroom. Underneath my skin, I could feel the tingle of knowing that she might be working me, using her version of Lidiya on her husband, pretending to be tender, pretending to be my faithful wife.

That tingle, for whatever reason, was almost as delicious as what I decided to believe.

So like all the men at Liquid Kitty, who perhaps suspected that Lidiya was not really a stunning Russian waitress who loved to run her fingers through their hair, I let myself be taken in by the fantasy.

It was only later that I would wallow in the dark idea that my wife was taking *me* for a ride, as much as she might be taking everyone else.

## CHAPTER 12

I didn't, for a moment, think about my own deceit, nor did it occur to me to come clean to Lynn about the PI. It didn't occur to me at all to ask myself (or her) *why* she had so suddenly decided that everything was over her head, that she needed to quit.

And so maybe I deserved what happened next.

Lynn went in on Wednesday determined to give her two weeks' notice, but Tim was mysteriously missing Wednesday and Thursday.

I had a stomachache.

"What does that mean?" I had asked Lynn, trying and failing to hide the frantic wobble in my voice.

"Nothing. He has other shit to do. He'll be there Friday," Lynn had said calmly.

I had a lot of work to make up for, after my day spying on my wife. I drove bleary-eyed to work, hating the whole situation, but convinced that Lynn would quit her job, and life would go back to normal. Sure, it had been delicious fun, but like all delicious fun, it would come with a hangover. But now, the air was thick with real, mafia-style danger. I knew the right thing to do was to back right out of it.

If Lynn quit, and gave two weeks' notice, it seemed like there would be very little chance of her getting into any trouble with Tim and his organized crime... whatever they were. I for one wouldn't feel safe until we were well away from it, and she had changed her number, and we had disappeared back into the anonymity of the suburbs, with a nice little story to tell someday when we got older and this was all behind us.

I didn't hear from Lynn all day Friday.

At one in the afternoon, because I wasn't sure exactly when her shift started, I sent her a text.

[Me]: *Good luck*

I resisted following up with her on it, because in my mind I was vacillating between thoughts of this all ending nicely and being no big deal,

and Tim being... I didn't know, some KGB bad-ass from a spy movie, and torturing my wife in the basement of Liquid Kitty.

There was no basement in Liquid Kitty. But still.

She didn't write; she didn't call.

I sat in the living room, then the office, then the car, then the kitchen, my stomach twisting into knots. Time kept ticking away, no word from my wife, and I started to think the worst. I didn't even know how to call this Troy character if, say, my wife disappeared. I held the phone in my hand, thinking more than once of calling the police.

But what would I say?

At two in the morning, the phone rang. I was so amped up that the ring jolted through me like an electric shock. I started sweating immediately. As I stared at the phone, vibrating so hard it was spinning on the counter, vertigo overtook me for a moment and I played out a thousand terrible scenarios in between the rings: the police were calling because Lynn had been murdered, Lynn was calling to gasp out her dying breath on the phone, the phone was going to explode in my ear.

*Ring.*

The number was not recognized.

*Ring.*

"Hello?" I said, my voice shaky.

Or maybe it was just the phone in my hand that was shaking.

"What did you do?"

It was Lynn. She was hissing.

"Where are you?" I asked, panic rising in my voice.

"I'm on my break." Lynn's voice was icy. "Did *you* hire someone to watch me? A PI or something?"

I went cold as ice and froze in place, my mouth open. Try as I might, I couldn't make any air move over my vocal chords.

"You *idiot*," Lynn said, taking my silence as confirmation. "You idiot."

"Lynn," I said.

But she cut me off. "You know what? Whatever happens now, it's your own fault."

I started talking, but Lynn had probably hung up by then. The dead silence of a no line, the sound of my own voice hitting a plastic wall to

nowhere inside the microphone of my cell, slowly ate away at my words until I just stopped talking.

I stared at the number. I called it, and it just rang and rang, never picking up, never putting me through to an answering machine.

I texted Lynn:

[Me]: *please call me back*

But I didn't hear from her for another three hours.

I sat in the living room, my skin getting sweaty, looking through police numbers on the computer, oscillating between panic and fear, Lynn's last words chewing a hole through me. Why hadn't I told her about the PI? How had she found out about it?

And why, why hadn't I realized that the PI was a very, very dangerous thing to have put on a guy the police were paying someone to inform on?

Sid. That fucker should have known better, too.

I played this game all night, and five o'clock came and went.

I texted Lynn.

[Me]: *Text me back or I'll have to call someone.*

There was no reply for five minutes, so I texted again.

[Me]: *Lynn I'm serious. I'm worried about you. Text or call. Or I have to get a hold of the cops.*

Nothing.

Angrily, I called her. The phone rang and rang, and then it finally made the clicking sound of a connection. I thought for sure it was going to be her voicemail. Instead, I heard the low laughter of a party in the background. Music, glassware clinking together. Women's lilting voices, Russian.

"Jesus, all right already. I'm here, I'll be home in a little bit."

Lynn.

"Lynn, what the hell is going on?"

But the cheerful, drunken noise on the other end of the line was gone.

\*

The car arrived at six am. It was late fall, so the streets were still dark and the headlights swung over the front of our townhome and blinded me in the living room for a moment, just as the phone buzzed in my hand.

[Lynn]: *mute your phone*

I stared, bleary-eyed and without comprehension at the phone, which startled me when it began to vibrate and ring in my hand. I blinked, and swept the icon to “answer.” Stupidly, because I was tired and unable to think, I held it to my ear and croaked: “Hello?” before I put two and two together.

A man was talking, not into the phone, his voice muffled.

“So. Lynn, Lidiya. This is it. Where you live, with your husband.”

The voice had a Russian accent, was low and authoritative. It had a dangerous edge to it that made it clear, even though it was muffled and far away: Tim was the voice speaking.

It took me a second to match what he was saying to the reality that must be playing out, just outside the house.

I rose, stunned, feeling like a puppet being moved by outside forces, and I approached the living room window, which looked down to the street.

“This is a curious house, for a girl who works at a strip club,” Tim continued.

I looked out the window. The car was an expensive-looking black SUV, the windows tinted, very gangster, parked on the other side of the street. I saw Tim in the window, just his leather jacket, his arm propped up on the side panel. The lights went out.

Lynn was silent. I wondered if she was as scared stiff as I was. There was a sinister quality to Tim’s voice, and though I tried to tell myself I had just watched too many movies, I couldn’t shake the feeling of impending disaster as he talked to her.

When Lynn spoke, her voice was smooth as glass. She had no “Lidiya” accent. She laughed lightly. “What, you don’t have a lot of suburban soccer moms working at your club?”

I saw Tim lean on the window, his hand to his head. “Are you soccer mom?”



Lynn laughed, and I could almost hear her rolling her eyes. “No.”

There was a deadly quiet on the phone, and Tim was motionless in the window. The next sound that came through was a rustling. Tim’s body moved in the window of the car. Not a lot; his leather jacket shifted in the light, matte black trading places with dark valleys, his hand dropping slightly as he turned his body a little to the interior of the car.

I heard breath, expelled from someone’s mouth as though that person were exercising.

More rustling, a thud, and then, distinctly, the wet and sticky sound of lips meeting, parting, meeting again.

Lynn’s voice was a low purr when I heard it: “Ummm,” she said. “This is not a good idea.”

I fell to the ground as though someone were shooting at me when Tim turned suddenly in the car, looking behind him out the window. “Why because of your husband there? Come on don’t tell me you have been teasing me all this time.”

I looked at the floor, too frightened to lift my head to the ledge. I pictured Tim staring at the house, right into the window. I willed my wife to say something, anything, but through the phone the only sound I could hear was the rustle of two people moving, touching each other.

I lifted my head, sinking back on my heels so that I was hidden in the darkness. Tim had moved into the interior of the car, toward my wife, and now I could see only the black of his jacket, moving in the light.

My heart stopped when I saw a feminine hand on the back of his head, the glint of our wedding ring shining in the streetlight. Between the muffled audio and what I could see in front of me, there was little doubt what was happening in the car.

“We’re right in front of my house,” Lynn said, her voice breathless.

Tim did not answer. There was an eerie silence, the female hand slipped down his back, I could see the movement of his left arm, crossed over into the passenger’s seat. “I am very discreet about my business,” I heard Tim say, after a while.

A sound escaped Lynn’s lips, and then she whispered something, and a mewl ate up the last of her words.

“I think,” Tim drawled, “you are not soccer mom at all. I think you’re the kind of girl who likes thrill.”

I very distinctly heard Lynn mewl again, and she sounded disappointed, before she whispered: “don’t stop.”

From there, things happened very quickly. The car, as big as it was, rocked slightly, and in the windows I saw a flash of Lynn’s thigh, the profile of Tim’s face, Lynn’s brown hair whipping against the glass.

It took a moment to sink in as I watched her settle on Tim’s lap, her mouth open in ecstasy, her chest rising and falling with gulps of air: my wife was riding his cock. Right there. On our street. In full view of anyone who cared to look out their window.

“That’s it, pussy cat, that feel so good, that’s what you wanted all this time,” Tim coaxed her. The phone began to slip from my hand as the scene swarmed in front of me. Lynn’s hand went up to the window and pressed against it, steam was slowly fogging them away from my view. But their voices: the panting, the heavy breaths, the little squeaks coming from my wife, were still sharp in my ear.

I dropped the phone and watched as the vehicle rocked, slowly at first, then faster, and then I heard them both moan and grunt as they came, either through the phone or all the way from across the street.

Stunned, I watched the window, their blurry forms meeting up again, kissing.

I swept the floor for the phone, not wanting to take my eyes off of it.

“I knew you were bad little girl,” Tim was saying.

Lynn’s voice cracked through the phone, a knife in my heart, as she gave a laugh. “Okay. I have to go in now, or he’ll get suspicious.”

There was another silence of words between them, and sounds that indicated they were touching, somehow being intimate. A wet kiss again.

“I’m going to talk to him,” Tim said.

My heart stopped. I tried to imagine Lynn’s expression, forgetting for a moment that Lynn herself had already “told me” about all of this, that Lynn had called *me*.

Lynn laughed again. Another silvery laugh that struck through my heart. “And say *what?*” she said lightheartedly.

The lights on the vehicle went out suddenly, and a sound on the phone died away. Tim had turned off the car, perhaps the heat had been on and had ceased as well. There was a long pause again, and Tim looked straight out the windshield.

“I am going to tell him that he cannot send his private investigator to my club. And then, I will tell him that he can come and see for himself what is happening. I will shake his hand.”

There was another pause. I wondered what Lynn was thinking, what her face looked like just then. I didn't know what game she was playing, or why she was doing this to me, or if I loved it or hated it. Was she shocked? Pretending to be shocked? Or was she thrilled to be driving another cold ice pick through my heart?

“You are not,” she finally said, incredulously.

“I am. I'm going to shake his hand with your pussy all over it, and then I am going to invite him to club. And while he is there, I am going to fuck you.”

There was another terrible pause, and Tim leaned toward the passenger seat. There was another wet kiss, and then more shuffling, which I could identify without seeing as Tim slipping his fingers into my wife's panties to feel for himself what he already knew to be true: she was hot for it, and her pussy was ruby-red and swollen, sticky with his cum, and ready to go again.

“And you know what I know, *kiska*? I know that you are just the kind of girl who will like that sort of thing.”

A long two minutes of airtime followed, Lynn's breath ragged and low, then panting and fast, and finally a forceful exhalation of air. I thought I could hear the sloppy wetness of her pussy as Tim worked her up to another climax.

He faced the front of the car. He was smiling, looking out the windshield. He brought his fingers to his face and smelled my wife's pussy.

Then, without another word, he opened the door.

“Wait,” Lynn said, but her voice was distant. She also seemed to be laughing.

I stepped back into the shadows as Tim stood in front of the car, shaking out his jacket. He zipped his pants, standing there in full view on the street.

Behind him, the passenger door opened and closed and my wife teetered out of the car in her thigh-high boots. She was adjusting her short skirt, pulling it down to mid-thigh.

Tim didn't wait for her. He stepped across the street, his steely eyes glinting.

I receded into the house. The lights in the back were on; the living room was dark. My gaze fell on the lock to the front door, and I was relieved it was turned.

I could just not answer.

I had a sudden realization that the phone was still in my hand. I shakily turned it off, and dropped it like it was a hot coal. My heart was pounding. I couldn't get the image of Lynn rocking against Tim's body in the driver's seat, slowly fading in the thickening steam on the window, out of my head.

Footsteps, hollow on the concrete, rang up the stairs. There were five short, authoritative pounds on the door, and then the doorbell chimed. It struck me that I had never even heard our doorbell. I hear the clacking of Lynn's shoes after these sounds, as she scurried up the stairs, saying something in a sing-song voice.

"He's probably asleep," I heard her purr.

Another three knocks made me jump.

They laughed together.

I heard the scraping of Lynn's keys as she attempted to put them in the door.

And then I got tunnel vision. I stepped forward, walking toward the door, unaware of how I was moving my legs.

The key turned and the door opened just as I flipped the light switch.

"Oh!" Tim practically shouted. He smiled at me. "Mr. Vistke."

I squinted at him. Lynn stepped into the foyer and brushed past me, putting her hand on my arm and squeezing it, before heading straight to the kitchen.

Tim stood on the porch expectantly. I knew I was supposed to ask him in, but I was frozen, staring at him. There was a smudge of red lipstick on the corner of his mouth.

He extended his hand, a grin on his face. "I am Tim Vasilyovich, I am owner of Liquid Kitty."

I put my hand out. Tim grabbed it firmly, a shake that was meant to establish dominance, turning mine slightly down and squeezing hard. There was still a moistness on his fingertips: my wife's juices.

He turned, pointing to the car. "I just giving Lynn a ride to her home."

He looked back at me, releasing his grip.

He looked expectant.

“You want to come in, Tim? Want a drink or something?” Lynn said behind me.

I looked back at her. She had already made herself a drink and was holding it, smiling in a devilish way I had never seen her smile before. She winked at me.

Or did she?

Tim’s voice was a severe baritone behind me, suddenly serious. “No, no, *kiska*, I don’t mean to disturb you this evening.” He was looking at me now.

He stepped up onto the foyer floor, and was very, very close to my face. It was awkward, but I fought the urge to step back. “I just want to clear something up with you, Mr. Vistke. Lately at my club, one of my bouncers has observed a man hiding in a car, watching the girls. He has a camera, this man.”

I kept my face as placid as I could, and repeated to myself that the best plan was to say nothing.

Tim’s eyes almost twinkled as he watched me. His head tipped ever-so-slightly to the side. “You understand this could be a very dangerous man, which is why I insisted on driving your wife home tonight. Now, my bouncer seems to think this man is a private investigator...” he paused, watching my face, smoothing his shirt. “But I don’t think you would hire such a man, would you, Mr. Vistke?”

My mouth was open. I shook my head, looking back at Lynn, who was leaning against a table, one long leg crossed in front of the other, smiling as she sipped her drink. She said nothing.

“The thing about my business, Mr. Vistke,” Tim said in a low voice, “is that... sometimes the police get it into their heads to give me trouble. They think there must be drugs, prostitution, lots of mafia, at my club. You and I know of course this is not the case, but sometimes the police make a big bargain – no, this is wrong – they make big deal out of these things.”

When he said “big deal,” Tim leaned forward and guffawed, almost cartoonishly, but his eyes were hard and cold.

“So, I want to request, man to man, that if you have hired such an investigator, for whatever reason, that you ask him to discontinue his surveillance of my club.”

I stared at him.

He smiled, and stepped onto the porch. Turning, he hovered on his heel, and swung back with a smile on his face. He had a hand up, a finger pointed in the cinematic gesture for “I forgot just one thing.”

“I wanted to extend the offer to you, as well, come by the club. I have a rule that boyfriends are not allowed, but you seem like a reasonable man and I see no reason you should not see for yourself that everything at the club is...” he clicked his tongue. “Straight as arrow.”

I was unable to speak.

“I will see you tomorrow then. Special VIP section.”

I started to shake my head, and my mouth made sounds that must have been the beginning of the sentence, “Oh, I don’t think -”

“I insist,” Tim said, the same false smile and demonic glint in his eyes.

And then, still smiling his queer little smile, he put his hands in his pockets and trotted down the steps.

When I turned, closing the door as I did, Lynn was still leaning provocatively against the table.

My stomach was ice-cold, the painful chill of it bleeding through me in waves.

“What did you do?” I whispered.

As horrified as I was, I had to admit that I was also incredibly turned on. Lynn looked utterly trashy in her Liquid Kitty uniform, and details were coming to me, making my erection even more forceful. Her lipstick was smeared, her hair was stuck to her neck, a sheen of sweat still covered her body. I could still feel the dampness on Tim’s fingers as he shook my hand.

I knew beneath that skirt, her panties were twisted and soaked in her own juices and Tim’s cum. Her bee-stung lips looked unusually fat and plucked, as though he had chewed on them while she rode his cock.

“Did you hear all that?” she asked, almost casually, though I could see a gleam in her eyes. I was beginning to see an aspect of Lynn’s personality I had never seen before. It was like Tim had said: she was the kind of girl to chase a thrill, and while I knew she was about to give me some excuse for what she had done, the truth was that he hadn’t read her poorly at all.

I swallowed. “Lynn...” I breathed. Part of me was angry, even though I knew as much as Lynn did that this was something I had wanted.

She wiggled her hips, hooking her fingers under her dress and sliding her panties down her thighs. She shimmied side to side, smiling mischievously at me.

“You didn’t leave me much of a choice,” she said, and her voice betrayed that beneath her smile, she was also a little angry. Or maybe, confrontational was a better word.

She shook the panties past her thigh-high boots, working them down the plastic and to her calves. From there they slipped, heavy with cum, landing on the floor with a soft thump.

There was a simmering, angry heat between us as we stared each other down. I was so turned on, I could scarcely breathe. My chest was tight and all the blood in my body seemed to be throbbing in my cock.

I dropped my eyes to her thigh, where a pearly drop of cum was sliding down her flesh, headed for the black stocking. As though reading my thoughts, she dropped her hand to the milky bead and scooped it up with her ring finger. Then she brought her finger to her mouth, and sucked on it, all the way to the gold wedding band.

She stepped out of her panties.

“I thought...” I said. “I thought you were going to quit.” My voice was plastic, my mind working on a million other thoughts than the one I was talking about.

“I was. And then here comes Tim, he wants to talk to me.” She sat on the table behind her, dangling her legs for a moment before she crossed one over the other. She lifted her leg high enough that I could see her wet, swollen pussy, creamy cum oozing from between her lips, just before she rested one thigh on the other. She leaned on the table and gave a shake of her head. “And *he* says, ‘do you know why a man would be watching you and taking pictures of this club?’”

I was walking toward her then, certain I could smell Tim’s acrid cum from where I was. An incredible change took place on her face at that moment: her lips parted and her eyes went dark with excitement as her pupils consumed the blue iris. She looked like she had just done a line of coke.

“So imagine,” she said softly. “What I was thinking: Troy had gotten caught, and now Tim knew I was an informant.”

Her face looked scared, but beneath the expressions of fear, I could see that she was delighting in this story. I could also see something I had

never had the chance to observe before: she was an adrenaline junkie. She *liked* this game. A lot.

“So for a minute, my heart is racing,” she continued. I was close enough now to put my hand on her crossed leg, pushing it to the side, spreading her open. The scent of her pussy and the foreign smell of another man’s cum, hot and humid, wafted up from between her legs. I could see her pulse throbbing in her neck, in the hollow of her throat.

“But then I think: who would have done such a thing? Not Troy. But who wasn’t surprised at all about the things I told him? And I realized it was you.”

My hand was on her left thigh now. It was moist and sticky. My palm shuddered as it moved along her leg. When my fingers found her pussy it was hot and soaked, and I slipped into the silky folds like she was a stick of melting butter.

“So this is what I tell him. You’re crazy, and jealous, and it was probably you. And it’s such a good explanation, and I come up with it so fast, that I can see he’s just not quite convinced.”

She lifted a hand and used it to unbutton my fly. I felt her fingers on the zipper, pulling it down smoothly. The meat of her hand was resting on my cock, which was straining to be freed from my boxers. Without looking down, she helped me out.

Her thumb rolled over the crown of my dick and she smiled as she felt the precum boiling out. She brought her thumb to her mouth and licked it again.

“So I think,” she continued, after swirling her tongue over her thumb. I was staring at her, transfixed: she looked nothing like my wife and she was acting nothing like my wife. For a moment I had an errant thought that I had somehow walked into another house, or was dreaming. “How can I convince this guy that I’m not a cop? Because I can see that’s what he’s maybe thinking.”

I curled my fingers inside of her and she closed her eyes a little, as happy as a cat. “So you fucked him,” I said.

She closed her fingers around my cock and raised her eyebrows, as if to say: “Like that really bothered you.”

I pulled my hand from inside of her and grasped her hips, pulling her toward me and sinking my cock into her sloshing pussy as I did. There was



a filthy squelch, a final sonic reminder of her infidelity. She rolled her body down to the table, vertebra by vertebra, until she was lying on it.

“How did you like shaking his hand, knowing that he had it in my pussy just a minute ago?” she asked me.

I thrust deep inside of her, and leaned over her body on the table to grab her by the hair so I could drive myself deeper into her cheating cunt.

The table, however, wasn’t designed for those antics, so it tipped, and her body went sliding down the angle. She wrapped her legs around me and grabbed my shoulder, and I lifted her just in time. The table slammed back onto the floor and I slammed her into the wall to the left.

Now my face was close to her lips, and I could just barely smell my own cum and her juices on her breath. “Does he have a big cock?” I asked her.

She squeezed her legs against my lower back and pulled me deeper inside of her rather than answer. She grinned, and that was as good as her telling me it was gigantic.

We fucked against the wall, but I ran out of energy to hold her up there, so we collapsed on the floor. She bit into my shoulder as I slammed into her pussy. I felt her clench around my cock and then arch up toward me, and I let go, filling her cunt with my cum, adding it to all the liquid that already marked her infidelity.

I lay on top of her for a long time, and then rolled off to stare at the ceiling. My shirt was soaked, my pants tangled around my knees and ankles, and all the bad thoughts that had been crowded out by our feral fucking were welling up in my mind. I put my hand to my forehead.

I was still out of breath. Lynn was still in her crazy boots, though they had been pushed down to just below her knee by what we had done. Her dress was pushed up around her hips, and her left breast was ready to fall out of the top. My eyes wandered to the pink skin of her waxed pussy, glistening and swollen.

My chest suddenly got tight.

“You brought him to our *house*, Lynn,” I said.

She was looking at the ceiling. “I know. I didn’t know what else to do. He offered me a ride home, you know, in that spooky way. So... I mean, what was I going to do?”

“Not take it. Not show him where you live!”

She rolled her head toward me. "That would have made him suspicious. He was already suspicious."

My stomach hurt. "I don't like this, Lynn," I said.

She pushed herself up on her elbows. "Really. Because you could have fooled me."

I didn't say anything, so she turned back to look at me. Her hair was silky, sweaty, falling in a glorious, messy cascade. "Look. Troy has always told me, don't sleep with him, just lead him on, because he gets tired of girls really quickly. So... now he'll get tired of me, and then in like, three weeks, I quit, and it all fits together, and I'm out."

She brushed her hands together.

I put my hand over my eyes and squeezed my nose. "Agh, Lynn," I said.

She hit me playfully with the back of her hand. "'Agh, Lynn,' what? You're the one who got a private detective like some idiot."

"What did you want me to do? You were working at a strip club, shaving your pussy, stripping, not stripping, staying out late...."

She wasn't saying anything, so I uncovered my eyes and looked at her.

"Talk to me?" she said.

I sat up, and pulled my pants from my ankles. Change rattled and fell on the floor. "Yeah. Kind of like you did, when you decided to spy on a mobster."

I didn't see her do it, but I could feel her roll her eyes. "He's not a *mobster*," she said.

"Oh, sorry, organized crime...guy, boss, whatever."

"He's not a boss."

I turned and looked at her with disbelief.

"What?" she asked. "He isn't. And anyway I'm not *spying*. I'm just doing my job and then I sometimes tell someone about what happened there that day."

"Lynn," I said.

"Look. You've made your point, okay? I'm going to quit, and it'll all be fine, and anyway, you got something you wanted in the bargain."

She put a hand on my cock, which was no help at all in trying to take any of this seriously. It throbbed to life under her fingertips.

"You get off on this," I said, in disbelief.

She ran her fingers through her hair, opening her mouth to deny it.

Then she shrugged. "I guess I do. Okay. So what?" She looked over at me. "It's fun."

I shook my head. "It's dangerous. This is all so... fucking dangerous."

She leaned in close to my ear and breathed onto my neck. "Would it be any fun if it wasn't?"

"Uh, maybe," I said, exasperated. "Did you hear him, about coming into the club?"

She bit into my earlobe with two teeth, gently. "You know he's going to fuck me while you're there," she purred.

My cock was at full mast under her hand in an instant. I could feel her lips spread into a smile next to my ear. "What do you think I should do with him?"

"Lynn," I said. My voice was shaky, I was forgetting every thought I was having as her lips moved over my skin and her fingers played over my sensitive, throbbing cock. "This is not a game."

A puff of air against my neck let me know that she was laughing under her breath.

"Of course it is," she said. Her tongue was traveling up my neck, along the ridge of my ear. As I sat there, stunned, she swung her leg over my body and climbed on top of my lap. Her hands worked her tight dress up her body, her breasts pouring from the strappy confines like cream, then bouncing into a gelatin cone topped by a pink cherry.

"It *is* a game, and we have no choice but to play it," she said. Her hips shifted on my pelvis, her soaked pussy sloping all over my cock and my thighs. "So you might as well have fun."

This last sentence was in Lidiya's voice. A thought fluttered briefly through my head, red-hot with the sting of betrayal: she didn't use her Lidiya voice with Tim. All this playacting, and she seemed fine being real in front of him.

The burn made its way through my body, but Lynn was sliding down to my legs, her bare ass up in the air, giving me a nice view of the rounded hills of her bottom. Her hair brushed over my legs, and then her mouth closed on my cock. She sucked on the crown, her tongue playing with the ridge and the glans, before she released me with a pop and looked up at my eyes.

Her lips were against my shaft, her head turning, her eyes on mine, as she breathed against my dick:

“Should I suck his cock?”

I didn’t find the words to answer her, but my dick bobbed as she caught it in her mouth. I gripped the back of her head, and pulled on her hair as she wrapped her lips around my cock and slid down to the base.

When she released me, she gripped me in her hand and squeezed me, like she was going to milk my cock. I stared at her as she readjusted herself, rising up on her knees and positioning her pussy just above my dick. She moved me against her clit, her body jumping when she stroked herself. The juices inside of her slowly poured down my shaft, squelching as she riled herself up again, masturbating with my dick.

“I might have to do some really, really dirty things,” she said. “If I want to convince him that I’m not a cop.”

She had her answer, it throbbed in her hand. She gave me a knowing grin, and slowly sank onto my cock. She was so wet she glided onto me with no friction, but the filthy things she was making me imagine were driving me so wild it didn’t matter.

Her weight pressed on my balls. Trickles of cum and juices rolled down, between my legs, into my asscrack. Her breasts bounced as she hopped on my cock, then rolled, her eyes getting heavy, her mouth parted.

She made herself come, and I was just about to go over the edge when she pulled herself off my cock and sat on my thighs. “I hear Tim really likes to come all over girls’ tits,” she said.

I went almost blind as I started to come. Her hand swiftly milked my cock, and thick ropes of creamy white landed across her chest, clinging to her nipples, her perfectly shaped mounds of flesh, her navel.

She relaxed her weight onto my thighs and smiled down at me, her fingers playing with my chest hair. The cum dripped slowly down her body.

She sat like that, a filthy and statuesque, whoreish-looking strip club waitress who was going to do filthy things with her boss, for a long time. Then she rose, standing over me in those fuck-me boots, with my cum dripping down her thighs, mingled with Tim’s, and her pussy throbbing and sucking like the mouth of a fish.

*No choice but to play.*

## CHAPTER 13

I did a lot of thinking all day long, especially on the drive to Liquid Kitty, which I dragged out a lot longer than I needed to by driving onto the interstate and circling around the city instead of heading straight to the club.

Mostly I thought about Lynn, and her slow-motion transformation from Lynn, my wife, to Lidiya, the...what? Strip club waitress? Wannabe stripper? Cuckoldress? I went back in time to conversations we'd had, to exchanges in which she'd looked wild and aroused, or nervous and caught, seemingly out of context.

I was slowly coming to the conclusion that my wife was a much different person than I had ever thought. I had always nurtured the image of her in my mind as a quiet, bookwormy type, who just happened to be hyper-competitive about a few weird things. But now that I thought about it, now that I really gave it some serious consideration in the current context, I could see something much clearer than ever before – a possibility, and a frightening one:

What if Lynn was not some quiet academic type? What if she was an adrenaline junkie? What if the way she was acting now was not the real anomaly? What if her pursuit of linguistics, our marriage, our nice quiet life in a townhome in the near-suburbs... what if all of *those* things were her fake personality?

What if she had actually discovered her true nature, and now she was going to be a different person forever?

The Lynn who worked at Liquid Kitty as an informant – who had the instincts to fuck her mafia boss to alleviate his suspicions about her, who calmly told her husband that she was indulging in his fantasies by doing so – was *hot*. No doubt about it.

But was that a woman who I could live with, as my wife?

A cold shiver went up my spine, again and again, as I thought of the ease with which Lynn had played her hand in all of this. She hadn't been afraid to wait tables at a club, to indulge in make-believe with a wig and a Russian accent, to take on the work of a confidential police informant, to dance for a mafia boss, to manipulate a dangerous person.

To manipulate me.  
So it was clear what Lynn could live with.  
Now just one question remained:  
What could I live with?

When I arrived at Liquid Kitty, the place was just on the verge of becoming busy. The girls were weaving languidly through the patrons. Kandy was in her pink and white costume, alluring as ever. The girl who looked like Beyoncé was dragging astounded eyes along with her like a magnet, all of them drawn to the rounded perfection of her ass. She had on yellow-green neon thigh-high stockings and a matching suit with strips of exposed flesh. With her narrow waist and generous backside, she had a wasp-like appearance. Something about the yellow color promised to glow in the dark against her ebony skin.

As for me, I had the sort of jitters you get when your hands are just on the *verge* of shaking. After all that thinking in the car, I was as lost as I was before.

I walked toward the bar, hands in my pockets to look cooler than I felt.

I saw them both at the same time. Lynn was taking a drink order way at the back of the club, where a cluster of suit-clad men were sitting. They looked Russian and didn't seem interested in the girls. She looked quickly in my direction, but kept at what she was doing without missing a beat. Her proximity to whatever was happening there, among obvious gangsters, made my blood run cold.

Tim was not with that group. He emerged toward the bar from the opposite corner at the back, walking toward me as though he had expected me at that very moment, all along.

I made myself look him in the eye as he charged toward me, a light smile on his lips. I appraised him differently now: these were the fingers that had felt around inside my wife's cunt; these were the lips that had sucked on her mouth, and under his shiny, expensive suit was the cock that had plunged into her pussy.

And he was going to do it again.

He extended two hands to me, and so I stuck out one. He enclosed my hand in his two-handed grip and pressed hard. It might have been a warm gesture under other circumstances. He was smiling broadly at me. While I

couldn't help but read something sinister into his smile, if I hadn't known better, I would have said he was a very warm and friendly man.

"Rick Vistke. So you came. Please, do not sit here, I have reserved for you a very special seating. I wish to clear up any sort of..." he looked skyward, genuinely, "you have to forgive my English, I cannot think of the word, maybe confusion, that we may have had."

He still had my hand in one of his, even as he was gesturing toward the VIP section by the stage nearest the stairs. Using his grip, he pulled us a little closer together. His voice became darker, and his eyes seemed to blacken beneath their light blue color, like deep water full of sharks. "I understand how we may have arrived at this confusion. I also do not like other people touching my stuff."

He said this to me in a conspiratorial tone that I had no idea how to read, and frankly, he was scaring me shitless. I pressed my lips together in an expression that I used for exactly this type of situation: when I had no fucking clue what else to do.

"Thanks," I said, lamely, giving his hand a little shake to free myself and head in the direction of his outstretched arm.

"What kind of drink will you have?" Tim said, putting his shaking hand on my back as I walked past him. It was a hard slap, just a little too forceful for a purely friendly back-slap.

"Uh -" I started to say, but he was already patting me some more and interrupting. "No, you will have my best vodka, this is a brand from my hometown in Kanevskaya, you cannot find it anywhere. Sit, sit, I will have your lovely wife bring it to you."

We were at the VIP section now, a gaudy red velvet half-moon booth with a glass table in the center, up against one stage and angled for a view of the entire club as well. A red velvet-covered chain hung across the entrance to the small stage it was set on, and Tim waved me through it, still grinning his shark-like grin.

I sank into the booth and started to scoot in toward the center. I decided better of that plan, vaguely thinking about escape – in case of what, I don't know.

The Lidiya-version of my wife looked particularly stunning that evening as she sauntered past my booth, a tray suspended with one toned arm, her pussy-cat tail swishing, every roll of her body a panther-like move

of perfection. I couldn't help the pang of arousal that burst in my chest and traveled straight to my cock.

She had taken to wearing particularly gaudy and trashy makeup for work, I noticed, as she leaned on the bar to talk to Tim. I burned from the inside out as the two of them edged closer to each other, and Tim's fingers brushed over her smooth arm where it was folded on the bar.

My wife smiled for him, tucking a strand of her blonde wig behind her ear. She leaned in toward his voice, not far enough to touch him, but enough to hear his secret. Her thick, fake black eyelashes swept over her cheeks and her eyes glinted like jewels from between them, stealing a glance at me.

Or sending it my way, like an ice pick.

Her cherry-red mouth floated in the dim lighting, plump and grinning, conspiring with Tim to find a place where she could seal her lips around his cock.

Tim left the bar abruptly, summoned to the entrance by a bouncer.

Lynn collected a crystal carafe of vodka and a matching shot glass – not the standard ware for Liquid Kitty's patrons, and walked gracefully back toward me.

She set the vodka down, and poured me a shot as I stared at her.

She was quiet, her eyes on her work, her lips quivering with a secretive smile. She adjusted a cocktail napkin and set the shot glass on it. "This is perfect," she said quietly, looking down as though she were talking to herself. "He's so preoccupied with getting me to screw him right under your nose that he's not paying *any* attention to what I'm overhearing."

She leaned close to me, her fingers suddenly in my hair, a quick kiss wet on my cheek – nothing sultry, the stuff of married couples. "Those guys back there? They're all big hitters," she whispered.

She raked her fingers down my neck. "So. That's on the house. Just sit back, and enjoy the show."

I slammed the vodka. Lynn's eyes went wide, and she reached for the carafe. "Easy, tiger, that's supposedly sipping vodka."

I exhaled to let the gasoline flavor escape my throat. "Jesus," I said.

Lynn let one eyelid drop, sleepily, in a sexy wink, and then she spun around to return to the bar.

The lights dimmed suddenly and the Beyoncé look-alike's music came on, so my eyes were drawn to the center stage, where her neon outfit



floated in the air as she spun around, a pair of slender legs up to the mid-thigh, half a sphere, and two round globes stretching and spinning in the dark. We all salivated, thinking of the dark brown places between her suit, and when we would get to see them.

When the lights came on, she treated us to a lot of bends and shimmies, before shaking herself loose of the neon outfit, her dark purple nipples long and swollen like her lips.

As she finished her set, I finished another shot of vodka, and then looked around for my wife.

She was nowhere to be found.

I pushed myself into the cushions of the booth, tightening up into a coil, tapping my fingers on the crystal shot glass. I stared at the stage, not even seeing the beautiful girls who came, one after another, to tease and gyrate and peel away their clothes. I saw nothing, because all I could think about was my peripheral vision, my stolen glances from side to side, a way to look behind me or to the right and see where Lynn, or Tim, or the thuggish table of guys, had gone to.

At last, I built up the courage to look over at the table: no Lynn, no Tim, and only a couple of guys remained. They were beefy, unintelligent looking brutes, who I took for bodyguards. They, too, had their eyes on the strippers and yet seemed to be seeing nothing.

I re-settled into my booth.

What was I supposed to do here? Where was my wife right now? Almost surely she was with Tim somewhere – probably upstairs? Doing what? Sitting on his lap, playing with his hair? Rolling her ass slowly over his erection? Or was she on her knees, giving blowjobs to the Russian mobsters while they drank this same shitty vodka?

Exactly as I was thinking about this, and had quite an erection going, Beyoncé herself emerged from the dark, neon stockings glowing against her black skin. She had her hair up in a ponytail and was smiling brightly at me: the fake, cheerful stripper smile. “Hey there,” she purred like a cat. “It’s Rick, right?”

She was terrifyingly pretty, her accent a little trashy and black, and she had that frightening demeanor that a lot of black women have, like if she yelled at you you’d probably start crying. She slid right into the booth next to me, bumping me over a little to make room for her terrific ass. Her

hips were narrow, her legs went on forever, and they were against mine under the table.

I noticed her skin was shiny. She smelled like coconut and cigarettes.

“Tim sent me over here to see if you’d like a lap dance,” she said, her voice pouring into me like Tim’s vodka. “We have a private room I could take you to.”

She had placed her fingers – long, slim, perfect, with blood-red manicured nails – on my chest, and they electrified the already buzzing tension inside of me.

Did I want a lap dance from this girl? Did I want her perfect ass in my face, nothing but a thin string of yellow fabric nestled between her chocolate globes?

“Uh...” I said. My heart was racing.

I still had no idea where Lynn was.

“It’s on the house, baby,” she purred. “Don’t make me feel bad.”

She was smiling, because I could see that in her mind, there was not even the faintest concern that I would say no to this offer. The fingers on my chest were already sliding down, and I looked at them nervously, wondering if they were headed toward my cock, when she detoured and grabbed my hand. “Come on with me, sugar. There aren’t as many rules back there.”

Before I knew what was happening, I was being led by her to the back door Sid had reported Lynn and Tim emerging from, the door that blended into the wall, unmarked, only entered by a select few.

She pushed it open, and the loud music of the club dampened as we entered a surprisingly elegant hallway. The dark painted walls of Liquid Kitty were not filthy, but they were pretty standard strip club fare.

Back here, there was rich wood paneling, and we seemed to have stepped into an elegant gentleman's club instead of the back alley of a strip club.

“I don’t even know your name,” I said, almost moronically, and she turned back to smile at me, but there was the hint of an eye-roll as she did. Like it mattered, she seemed to be saying. But her lips were still blossoming into smile after smile. “Sweet,” she drawled, and the word came out of her mouth covered in nectar. She put a hand on a wood door, thick and elegant with carved squares, and knocked with the other. She scanned the ceiling for something, then turned the handle.

“It was, Sweet Sugar,” she said, as she sauntered into the room. “But then, all sugar is sweet, right?”

I shuddered slightly.

This was a larger room than I had expected, with a long, mirrored catwalk in the center. Three poles divided it into sections, and against the wall, behind it, was a bench of red velvet. The classiness of the hallway evaporated into mirrors and red velvet, lights and poles. The sound of the club was still pumping through the speakers.

She flipped a switch on the wall, and nothing happened in the interior of the room.

“Have a seat, sugar,” she said, turning around.

She was walking toward me, and now that we were alone, she seemed even more wasp-like. My chest felt tight, and I was starting to lose the feeling in my legs, so I stumbled backward and sank into the couch.

Sweet stepped onto the catwalk with the practiced ease of a truly professional dancer. The song outside was winding down, so she weaved sexily through the poles on the catwalk, smiling at me, her teeth white, her eyes glowing with mischief and allure.

She stopped at the pole in front of me, and took a wide step before turning to face me. She leaned against the pole, one arm stretching above her. Her legs were so long, her skin so shiny and smooth, her proportions so Amazonian, that for a moment it was easy to believe she was made of plastic.

The new song began outside, and Sweet’s legs began to fold outward as she slid down the pole to a long, sexy intro of moaning female vocals. Her eyes were on mine, which were fluttering uncontrollably between her sultry stare, her pillow lips, and the center of her legs, where the yellow fabric of her dress was stretching thin, narrowing, opening, until I was sure I was going to see what it was hiding.

She popped up suddenly with an uptick in the music, and suddenly she was spinning around the pole, holding it and undulating her hips toward it. She hooked a leg around it and whipped around, then stopped to bend over and give me a profile of the firmness of her bottom.

She did this a few more times before she began to unwrap herself. I had no idea how she unhooked her costume, or how it worked as she spun and spun, the long, connected yellow strip rolling off of her with each turn.

Her breasts were freed on the third turn, and sprang loose, enormous and bountiful. Dark, purple black aureole, the size of small pancakes, were adorned by a cherry-sized nipple. The ebony mounds that suspended them were solid as marble, and barely moved as she spun again, the yellow strip rolling, rolling off her body until nothing remained but the tiny yellow panties and the knee-high yellow stockings.

And then, just as suddenly as she had begun dancing, she was off the stage and right in front of me, turning, spinning, gorgeous and dark. She leaned forward and shook her ass right in front of my face: the rock-hard mocha flesh barely jiggled even as she shook her hips violently. The yellow thong between her sculpted black hills was deep in the valley between them and almost invisible.

She climbed on top of me, and I instinctively threw my hands to the side to indicate that I was not touching her, which made her smile. "This room has different rules, sugar, I thought I told you that."

Her voice seemed even lower, even more seductive than before. My chest squeezed even tighter and I croaked, "It's not... it isn't that, I, um..."

I, um, couldn't finish my sentence. What were the rules here? My palms were itching to touch the smooth black skin in front of me, and my mouth was actually watering for a taste of the plump, dark cherry nipple in front of my lips. Her whole body was like a ripe, swollen fruit, still firm, bound to be so juicy inside that it would dribble from chin with a single bite...

She was smiling again, and I felt the weight of her body as she sank onto my lap. Her mischievous fingers were on my chest, on my thigh, circling inward, closer with each second to my cock.

I was so stunned by what she was doing that I simply stared at her, transfixed, as her fingers brushed over my cock.

"I, um..." I managed to whisper.

Sweet leaned back, holding onto my shoulders for support. Her breasts pointed at the ceiling, and her hips shifted to grind against mine. She squeezed me with her thighs for support and released my shoulders to play with her breasts, her fingers pinching her engorged nipples, pushing her flesh together, making circles on the velvet-smooth skin of her aureole.

My cock was so hard there was no attempting to deny it, so I just stared and let myself enjoy the moment. There didn't seem to be much of a

way of extricating myself, anyhow. Sweet's thighs were clenched so hard against my thighs I couldn't move.

She danced to the music like this, and I was in a fevered dream the whole time. She bit her hair, sucked on her fingers, pushed her breasts into my face, rolled against my hard cock like she was riding me for real.

And then she popped off my lap, onto the stage, and did the splits across the catwalk, her pussy dead in front of me, long thighs on either side. The yellow panties were glowing; the light had gotten dimmer.

Her fingers were suddenly on her thighs, and I raised my eyebrows in both appreciation of the athletic feat she was performing, and wariness at what she had planned next.

"Song's almost over, sugar," she said. Her fingers were inching toward the center of her thighs, and then one finger was hooked beneath the fabric, tugging it outward, away from her pussy. Not far enough for me to see what was under there, but far enough to drag my eyes to what she was doing and trap them there.

"Want to see what's underneath?" she asked me.

I said nothing, and she played with the panties for a few more moments, running a finger along the inside, then the outside, then the inside. I must have been watching like a cat with a toy, eyes riveted on her movements.

And then she pulled the panties to the right, and give me a peek at her bright pink, juicy pussy, the lips dark and purple, the folds as fat and swollen as her lips.

"Want a taste?" she asked, using her other hand to draw a droplet of her nectar up to her own mouth. "It's on the house."

The music, as chance would have it, changed at that moment, with an abrupt enough break that I blinked, and managed to snap out of the trance.

"I... do..." I said slowly, "very much. But that is... I'm..." I lifted my eyes to meet hers. "I'm married."

Sweet lifted her arms and grasped the pole, a wicked grin on her face. She moved her shoulders in what would have been a shrug, still smiling. "And Lidiya is your wife?" she asked.

The smile she gave me was not malicious, not even a smirk. But it was knowing. "What do you think she's up to right now, sugar?"

She had a point, and I would have possibly reconsidered her offer, but for Sweet it was too late. She lifted herself up the pole in an even more

extraordinarily athletic feat, by pulling her legs together and using her arms to elevate herself back to standing.

“Wow,” I said.

The music changed. Sweet gave me a smile of appreciation and swiped her costume – basically a long yellow strip of fabric – from the floor.

“Sweet,” I said, standing up as she wrapped herself in the fabric. “What, um...”

“Nothing,” she said, looking up as she put the final wrap around her chest. “Tim’s paying for this one.”

She hopped off the stage and looked me up and down. “So too bad for you, because there was a lot sweeter Sweet coming.” She was playful, grinning. It made no difference to her, which relieved me a little bit, because I didn’t want to offend her, as silly as that sounds.

“Uh... no, not that, well, I mean, thanks for that. But...” She was looking at me with a diminishing patience now.

“Honey, I got a set in like fifteen and I need to smoke.”

I exhaled. “Do you think this is, uh... like, is Tim a dangerous person to work for?”

She looked at me for a moment with an absolutely dumbfounded expression on her face. Then she gave a light laugh, and her mouth broke into the kind of smile natives give to tourists when they’re about to do something very stupid.

“Heeeeeeeeeeeeeehhhh,” she said, turning, and walking to the door. And that was all she said to me before she walked out.

My head was ringing as I pretty much stumbled out of the hallway. As luck would have it, my eyes went straight to Tim, who was seated in the VIP booth, drinking some vodka, a smirk on his face. My cock was throbbing from Sweet’s dance, the memory of her dark purple pussy materializing over and over again in my thoughts.

But seeing Tim, knowing that he had probably been off with my wife that entire time, made me pulse painfully to an even more engorged state.

“Come. Rick. How did you like your lap dance?” Tim was grinning, beckoning me to sit down next to him.

I sank into the booth again. He leaned toward me. “I check with your wife before, so don’t worry,” he said, his eyes glimmering cruelly.

*I'll bet you did, buddy.*

The vodka in the carafe had diminished a bit, and Tim had several shot glasses on the table now. I noticed that one of them was smudged with red lipstick.

It could have been any lipstick, any lipstick at all, but my instincts told me it was Lynn's.

And suddenly, there she was.

She leaned her tray on her hip and smiled at me. "So," she said, picking up the vodka carafe and pouring me a shot. "How'd you like your lap dance?"

She had a necklace on, glinting around her neck. A collar of diamonds, surely not real, but expensive-looking and even a little pretty. Surely I would have seen those before.

"Were you wearing that necklace before?" I asked.

Lynn brought her hand to the collar.

Tim leaned forward again, having just leaned back to rest his arms on the back of the booth. "This is part of new uniform," he said. His accent seemed to have gotten thicker.

Lynn gave him a relieved look, one I wasn't certain was genuine or play-acting. Tim was grinning, thinking he was very clever.

My cock ached.

At that moment, one of the beefy Russians from the mafia table leaned over the back of our booth and said something in Tim's ear.

Tim slapped me on the back again, and started to get out of the booth. His eyes were on Lynn. "*Kiska*," he said, "why don't you give your husband a kiss and I will go deal with this." He moved his head in my direction, but did not take his eyes off Lynn. "Rick. Be right back. Don't keep my best waitress too busy."

And he was gone.

Lynn slid into the booth next to me, taking Tim's seat.

She slipped her hand right between my legs and felt the contours of my hard cock as she leaned forward to kiss me on the mouth.

No doubt about it: her lipstick was fresh, her breath was minty and burned slightly with vodka, but beneath those flavors was the unmistakable musk of cum. She ran her tongue along my teeth, played with my lips for a bit, and then chewed softly on my lower lip before letting me go.

Her fingers were resting on my shaft. “While you were getting an eyeful of Sweet Sugar,” she said, “I had my lips on Tim’s cock.”

She smiled when my cock pulsed under her fingers. Then she started to rub my shaft. “He’s having so much fun, making me do dangerous things, thinking you don’t know, that he’s letting his guard down all over the place.”

I saw the gleam in Lynn’s eye: this was not just a sexual allure for her, it was also a thrill of danger. I wondered what percentages of each mixed in her blood.

“Lynn,” I breathed, “This is a dangerous game.”

“I know,” she said. Her fingers were working my zipper down, then they were delving into my pants, hot against my cock. She started to stroke me, under the table, there in front of everyone. I looked around, but no one was paying any attention to the scene we were making. It was dark, crowded, and girls were stripping on all three stages.

Lynn’s hand moved along my shaft, and she rested her head in her hand, speaking close to my ear. “You know what he wants me to do next?” she asked me.

I was shaking already, almost over the edge. I had absolutely no idea what she was going to say. I was almost bursting apart at the seams in her hand.

“It’s something I’ve never done before,” she said. Each of these words snaked through me and ignited the climax that was boiling at the base of my cock. I struggled to keep myself from flailing around as cum spilled into Lynn’s hand and my orgasm racked me violently as she said, in a low voice: “Well, I’ve already sort of done part of it.”

I was unable to speak.

Lynn slipped her hand out from under the table, picking up a cocktail napkin with her free hand, and wiping most of my cum from her skin. Then she used one finger to slide a glob of it from her palm, and held it up for me to see before she enveloped it between her lips and sucked it off her fingertip.

“Mm,” she said.

I was shaking, still speechless, and I had gripped the table in a death grip. She uncurled the fingers of my left hand one by one, and guided my hand between her legs. I felt her thigh, dry and smooth, and then the silky fabric of her panties, and then -



Just as my fingertips grazed something unknown, foreign, the sensation of which didn't even have time to reach my brain, she pushed my hand away and scooted out.

I saw stars at the edges of my vision, and I snapped my head around to watch where she went. Her reason for abandoning me so suddenly was crossing the room toward the bar: Tim.

At the end of the booth, she slid her tray back against her hip and looked at me, her eyes sultry. "Maybe later," she said, and away she went.

Tim smirked over her shoulder at me as she approached him. He didn't touch her as he turned and walked toward the bar with her, but I could see that he was enjoying the fact that he *had* touched her, and then some.

What was this "new thing?" My fingertips burned where they had touched Lynn's panties. What had I felt there? Perhaps I was imagining things. My mind jumped in head first, imagining the most depraved scenes from all the porn I'd ever watched, as I stared emptily at the stage and tried to look like an ordinary man who was there to watch the ladies.

Not a man who was there to watch another man fuck his wife.

\*

I got pretty blitzed over the next hour, as Lynn strutted around, waiting tables. The truth about her job, whatever else you could say, is that she really hustled.

Watching her, I also saw that Lynn was naturally talented for being an informant. Where had she gotten this from? Movies? TV shows? Was she just naturally deceptive and ingenious?

While she smiled and positioned herself with all her best assets right in the face of her Russian customers, her lips moved and she said something that pulled them right in. Then she would steal a glance at something on the table, or study a face. I could see that she was doing far more than just bringing them drinks.

As for Tim, you could see things in one way: he was hitting on her, she was playfully putting him off when her husband was around, he was getting off on making her do dangerously naughty things while I was right there.

Or, you could see it another way: she was luring him, like a fish on a hook, to make those suggestions.

“Hi,” she said, popping onto my thigh after speaking to Tim, sometime after one, when I was really bleary-eyed, aroused again, and wondering how to extricate myself and my wife, while also wondering how I could get into the office to see what the two of them got up to in private.

Lynn gave Tim a look, and I pretended to be clueless about it. She smiled. “Tim just told me,” she said, in a low voice next to my ear. “Well, he dared me, really...” Her fingers played with my hair, and as she did that, she slipped her legs on either side of my thigh. Not completely straddling me, but just enough that I felt what was between her legs.

It was hard, knobby. A small thing, the sort of thing I recognized instantly from all the porn I’d watched, but which had no place in *my* life. Or in my wife.

I was dizzy for a moment.

She moved her bottom to grind the jeweled plug against my thigh. “To come over here and sit on your lap. And if I do it, he says he has a very special treat for me.”

My eyes were on her diamond collar. The only other thing I was aware of was her butt plug. “What is that necklace?” I said, like a robot.

She flashed a look of fear, and stood up. Her fingers fluttered over the collar. Then she smiled – and let me tell you, this act came across as a little maniacal, until I realized that it was a show for Tim, and not for me. “I have to act like I’m shocked,” she said. “Or it isn’t any fun for him. This is covering where he bit me. I’ll show you later.”

She poured me another vodka, and kissed me on the lips. “There’s another one on my thigh. It’s going to be very tricky fucking you tonight without you seeing all these things.”

She walked away, and I faced the stage, but in the corner of my eye I saw Tim leaning on the bar, bringing his hands together in a slow clap.

I stared at the stage for the next parcel of time, but I have no idea how long that was. Half an hour? An hour? My wife was waiting tables, walking around casually with a plug in her ass, and her boss was lurking around, planning to fuck her right under my nose. Thinking I didn’t know what he was up to.

Was I titillated or humiliated? Aroused or furious?

I didn't know.

I drank a lot of vodka.

Tim plopped down next to me and rested an arm over the booth, like we were old friends. Sweet was doing a number on stage again, her yellow stockings exchanged for a fantastical peacock outfit. Tim didn't say anything, which was intimidating enough that when he did finally turn to me, pour me another shot from the rapidly-depleting bottle, and say something, I just went along with it.

He sucked in loudly before he spoke. "You look very drunk, Rick. I have taken the liberty of ordering you car. I have driver, Nikolai, he is very good and he will take you home to your house."

I looked at Tim. At this point, I realized my vision was doubled.

Lynn passed by the table, and looked over at us. "Yes," she purred, and she looked like a cat through my drunken haze. "You need to go home, darling."

She shook her hips, and her bottom, as she sauntered away.

Nikolai was a sandy-haired, thuggish kid of about twenty-five, who did not speak English. I suppose he drove me home, because when he turned around and looked at me expressionlessly, that's where I was.

I remember holding up a bill, and him shaking his head slowly.

"Thanks," I said, idiotically.

And then I stumbled up the stairs, and it wasn't until I closed the door that I felt the full impact of what was actually happening. That Lynn was still there, without me.

So I collapsed in a chair, and stared into the darkness, waiting for my wife.

## CHAPTER 14

I didn't notice my phone buzzing until it was too late: when I fished it out and held it to my ear the call was gone.

I realized how drunk I was as I stared at the screen. "Lynn" looked like "Lyme." Twice.

I pressed the icon and held the phone to my ear.

"Oh," she said breathlessly, a hysterical gasp barely submerged in her voice. She was panting, as though she were jogging. "I thought you wouldn't answer...I'm so, glad, you...called back."

There was little doubt that she was engaged in something sexual at that moment. The only question was *what* that something sexual was. I tried to read every sound that reached my ears as she gasped and spoke to me. Was she bouncing on Tim's lap like she had in the car just a few days ago? Or was she bent over on a pool table and taking his cock hard, her face sliding across the felt?

"I, um, just wanted to make sure everything was... okay..." she gasped. She cleared her throat. "That you... don't... weren't... mad about... had a good..." her voice was getting quieter and quieter with each word she uttered, and I could hear the strangled excitement in her throat, getting even tighter.

"Don't ssssst-", she whined, and I had an idea that wasn't for me, even though she quickly followed up with: "-tay up for me."

There was a rustling on the end of the line. I still hadn't said anything. From the earpiece I heard something distinctly wet, though I couldn't have said what it was for a million dollars. Lips? Her sloshing pussy? Cum splattering on her face?

"Honey?" I said.

"I'm still here," she slurred.

"Okay, I'll just go to bed then," I said shakily, "and see you tomorrow?"

This was a gambit, a hope that this phone call had been another dare of Tim's, and that my job was to pretend that I was still as clueless as ever. I *wanted* to scream: *I won't go to bed at all, you harlot, until you come home and I fuck you senseless.*

“Okay,” she said, gasping. “I love th-you.”

I wondered, as I let the phone slip from my hand, if she had been looking right into Tim’s eyes when she said that.

Lynn got home at about 5:30. I stood next to the window, as I had the evening she had fucked Tim in the car, but she arrived in a black sedan and stepped out of the back seat.

She was still wearing her Liquid Kitty uniform, the satin, knee-length hoodie-coat loosely pulled over it. The tail and ears had been discarded, but the fishnet stockings and high boots were still on. She was still wearing the blonde wig, which had the appearance of being seriously ruffled and then hastily patted into place.

She looked up at the window, as though she knew I was there watching her, and then climbed the steps to the entrance.

The car drove off, so I opened the door.

Lynn had her keys in her hand, so she dropped them into her purse and gave me a wry smile.

I reached through the door and grabbed both unzipped sides of the hoodie, pulling her into the house and then pushing her against the wall so I could shut the door. I was too wound up to wait for any seduction scene: I mashed my lips against hers and explored her mouth. The same mouth that had been on Tim’s cock, sucked his cum from his bulbous head, and maybe done even more since then.

I tasted her tongue and her lips, and we played with each other’s tongues and then drank each other in deeply for a long, filthy kiss. The taste of sex, of no particular origin – pussy, semen, sweat, filth – was on her mouth, but there was no way of telling what she had done with it purely from the taste. How far would my wife go in her adventure? I wondered briefly.

I released her lips and leaned back to appraise her appearance. Her lipstick had long ago worn off, her lips had the bruised and puffy appearance of having been used quite a bit for something. The blonde wig framed her face, slightly askew, and I reached up to touch the hair just to the side of her right cheek. It was matted together with dried cum, which I felt with my fingers, the filthy delight of it traveling down my arm to my groin. Then I pulled the wig from her head, and her long brown ponytail snaked out and onto her shoulder.

The fake eyelashes were gone, the mascara smeared only slightly under her eyes. Dark brown powder still smothered her eyelids, giving them a slutty allure.

I worked my fingers down to the collar Tim had given her, and I fingered the back of it for a clasp. She brought her arms up to unfasten it, and I pulled at the front. The cubic zirconia beads rattled as they collapsed around my hand, and the dark red, purpling stain of a bite from Tim stared at me from the side of her neck.

“He’s a biter,” she said casually.

I fingered the bruise and then kissed her there, and was titillated to feel her inhale deeply, excited by the touch.

“Tell me what you did after I left,” I breathed. My hand moved down her back, down to her ass, seeking the jeweled plug Tim had been so brazen to put inside of her right there in front of me. But it was gone, and Lynn squirmed away from my touch. “Be gentle,” she breathed on my mouth. “I’m very, very sore there.”

Her words hit me like a wall of bricks. Stars shot wildly from the sides of my eyes in the dark, and I was lifted to a whole new plain of arousal, and pain.

“You let him fuck you in the ass?” I said, pushing against the wall to lean away and get a better view of her.

“It just sort of happened,” she said. “After I let him put that plug in, it wasn’t as though I could really say no.” She drew a finger down my chest, biting her lower lip. When she reached my groin, and the shape of my hard cock beneath my pants, she sucked on her lip and smiled. “I really needed to *convince* him,” she said softly. “What’s a girl to do?”

I stared at my wife, or this person who was in my wife’s body, unable to believe that she had let her mafia boss Tim take her in every single hole that night.

But I found myself, rather than feeling pitiful, getting a little rush, thinking ahead to the chance that I might get to see this for myself. Flashbacks of the night of the car filled my head.

She was shimmying out of her hoodie now, the satin fabric slipping over her shoulders. I pushed my hands down to her thighs, feeling the insides of her legs for the dried telltales of cum, for the slippery, sloppy drips of all the filth in her used cunt.

But her legs were damp, as though sweat had gathered on them, and the further I pushed up between them, the more sticky they became, until I reached her mound. There were no panties between my fingers and the wet slop of her pussy.

“I had to throw those out,” she said. “They were ripped to shreds.”

She had been working on my zipper this whole time, and now that it was open, she pushed my pants down, sliding down the wall to pull them with her. It was vaguely reminiscent of Sweet’s slide down the pole, and my wife had her legs splayed in much the same way when she reached the floor.

She grasped my cock in her left hand, and looked up at me through her smoky, trashy eye makeup with an open mouth just below my cock. I grabbed her head when her tongue made contact with the underside of my shaft: if she took me into her mouth now, I was going to last exactly one second. And I had other things I wanted to do.

“Wait,” I said, which wasn’t necessarily what I meant, but she seemed to get the message.

She squeezed my dick again. “I might be too sore for anything else,” she said, her tongue searching for my cock as I pushed gently back on her head to keep her away.

My cock strained against her grip, which made her smile. I pulled her gently by the hair, trying to get her to stand up, but she shook her head, her eyes filled with that same mischief as before.

I sank down to the floor, giving up on making it anywhere else. But once I was there, it was a fairly simple thing to push her over to her back.

She laughed, liking the game.

“How many times did you have sex with him?” I demanded, pushing her dress up to her hips, pulling it down to her waist, so that she was naked except for the crumpled material of her uniform at the waist. Her pussy was pink on the outside from friction, looking like ruptured fruit. Her juices and whatever else was in there – one? Two? More? Loads of cum – gushed as I stroked her smooth mound.

“When?” she asked, grinning. “Tonight?”

My cock pulsed, and my face melted into a look of shock, which I could see ripple through my wife like electricity. It was frightening how much she got off on that particular kind of thrill. She smiled. “I’m only joking,” she whispered. She pulled me close and bit into my ear, gently. “I

sucked him off, and then he fucked me upstairs after he sent you home. Twice.”

She pushed my hand against her pussy, directing my fingers into her gushing hole. “Once here,” she murmured, raising her body to enclose my fingers in her flesh, “and once...”

She let her sentence trail off, and let me guide my own hand down, over her taint, to the eyelet of her asshole. I was shaking, afraid to look down, feeling with my fingers: it was wet, sticky, and felt distended, but not monstrously so.

When I made a circle around her ring, she squirmed beneath my touch. I explored deeper, working my finger inside of her, and she mewled softly. “So sore,” she purred, teasing me, daring me to do more.

She lifted her left leg, stretching out the fishnet and black boots, grasping her calf with her hand and pulling her leg up high in a flexible, stripper-like move that left her ankle above her head. As she did this, her body rolled around my finger, wet and silky, squeezing tighter.

I looked down, and she worked her other leg up and over my shoulder as I did, so that I could have a better view of my finger in her ass. The pink of her hole was puffy, used like her pussy, and clasped around my finger like her poofy lips.

I pushed in deeper, liking how slick she was inside, enjoying the way she mewled and twisted on the floor, undoubtedly sore but craving more. “Did you like it when he fucked you in the ass?” I asked her.

Her pussy was throbbing, gushing the load of his cum and her own excitement, dripping down to my hand. Her eyes closed and she made a noise that couldn’t be interpreted as anything but a yes.

I rolled her over by grasping the leg on my shoulder and pushing it to the right. She went willingly onto her front, her legs bent up under her, her ass in the air. I somehow managed to keep my finger embedded in her ass the whole time.

She kicked her feet forward and grabbed the heels of her shoes, a move I had only seen before in porn. My cock almost exploded right then and there.

The view I had now – her bare ass, round and displayed for me, my finger in her reddened hole, her dripping pussy pulsing beneath it, was framed by her lean thighs and the fishnet stockings, the plastic hooker boots, the high heels next to her bottom.



I used my finger as a hook to lift her up a little, and then had to do very little but point to sink my cock inside of her pussy. She felt loose, impossibly wet, and hotter than ever before. As I fucked her, she moaned and squirmed. “Oh,” she gasped. “I’m so sore, oh, that feels good though.”

My cock pulsed, and I could feel it through the flesh between her ass and her pussy. I replaced my finger with my thumb, and palmed one buttock so I could finger-fuck her ass while I thrust into her pussy. With every fuck I threw into her, her dirty cunt squelched and I could feel Tim’s cum splashing over my balls, down her thighs, and splattering onto the floor.

I held on as long as I could, but the second I felt her pussy pulsing on my cock, I went over the edge and hammered my cum into her as she slid forward, too caught up in her own orgasm to hold herself in position. We collapsed, and I finished off inside of her, lying on top of her, her legs flailing at my side.

We dozed off on the floor – the cold, hardwood floor of the entryway – but pretty soon we both stirred and we made our way to the bedroom. Lynn stripped off all of her clothes – no tease, just a perfunctory removal of the boots and stockings, the stretched remains of her dress. I shook myself out of my clothes, and by the time I climbed in next to her, she was almost asleep.

I pulled her ponytail loose, and ran my fingers through her hair. “I love you, Lynn,” I whispered.

She smiled, and lifted a hand to feel for my head, edging closer to me to spoon. But she never said anything back: she was so exhausted her hand floated down, like a falling plane, and crumpled up around her head.

I moved it to her side, and snuggled next to her.

My emotions were soaring high and plummeting low, my mind back to spinning, but I was also so tired and drunk by that point that my eyelids grew heavy and my thoughts turned to soup. I fell asleep and didn’t wake up until eleven the next morning.

Lynn was in the shower: the sound of water woke me up. I rolled onto my back, and the evening before came crashing into my mind, waking up my cock, stirring up all kinds of feelings in my chest.

I waited for her to come out. For some reason I didn’t feel like going to her. I watched her as she came into the room, rubbing her brown hair dry, her face scrubbed clean, her body wrapped in a towel.

She caught me staring at her and gave me a smile. “I couldn’t sleep anymore,” she said. “This schedule has me so messed up.”

I kept staring at her.

“What?” she asked, pushing on my foot with a knee.

“Come here,” I said, beckoning her with my hand.

She came toward me, reluctance in her step. “I’m not up for any more sex at the moment,” she warned me.

She sat down on the bed, and rolled on my side and put my arms around her waist. She ran her fingers through my hair, looking down at me.

Everything about her now – her smell, like soap and her shampoo, her pink cheeks and her fresh face, her long, wet brown hair that she was rubbing with a towel – was like the old Lynn, the bookworm, the brown-haired, pretty linguist.

“What?” she said, nudging me again. Then her face grew serious. “You’re okay, right? With... everything.”

She scooted back against my hips, giving me a signal that she could feel my throbbing cock against the small of her back. Whatever I said, I wouldn’t be able to deny that I was at a minimum intensely aroused by “everything.”

“What’s wrong, honey?” she said, her fingers in my hair. “Something’s obviously bugging you.”

I looked up at her. There was a long pause.

Sure, I could have told her that something *was* bugging me. That her personality change was disturbing, that I would have to get used to the fact that she was an adrenaline junkie. That I felt out of control in this whole game, like she was the one marching ahead and being daring, and that it felt like a role reversal in a lot of ways.

“No, honey. It was so hot,” I said instead. “I’m just...” I rubbed my hair.

Her face was expectant.

“I’m just hungry,” I said.

Her face brightened. “So glad you said that,” she said. “I’m starving.”

She stood up, and walked to the closet. On her way, her foot got tangled in her dress from Liquid Kitty.

She picked it up and inspected it. It was essentially mangled. “Thank God I won’t need *this* much anymore,” she said.

She went to the closet, her back to me.

“What’s your plan, then?” I said casually.

Lynn didn’t even turn around. She shrugged. “Troy says Tim usually gets tired of girls right away. So I figure, this’ll fizzle, I can give my two weeks in a week or so, and it will just look like I’m another disgruntled girl who quit because he wasn’t nice enough to me after we fucked. Right?”

She wasn't even looking at me.

I was astounded, though I was starting to get used to this new Lynn. She sounded like she barely cared, and her nonchalance about Tim gave me a perversely warm feeling.

He was just a mark to her, and I could see that now.

It might be hard, learning to live with this adrenaline-seeking, fast-paced, game-playing Lynn. Lynn who liked danger, Lynn who thrived on risk-taking. Lynn, who was steering the ship while I held on for dear life. I could see that I would either have to learn to live with that, or let go: there was no turning back to being the Lynn she was before.

I looked at her back, the muscles moving beneath it as she hooked a black bra behind her. Strands of wet hair clinging to her shoulders. The shape of her thighs as she shifted from foot to foot.

I loved her. So I guess I was just going to hang on for the ride.

As if she could hear my thoughts, she looked over at me, and smiled.

END

## **MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER**

### ***Romantic Hotwife Books By Arnica:***

#### **Hannah Gets Hot**

When Hannah has a chance encounter with a younger man on a plane, Twitter goes crazy for their "budding romance." Her husband Mike sees an opportunity to seize on his long-hidden fantasies. While Hannah is attracted to the hot, young guy from the plane, she's far too loyal to her husband to

have an affair... at first. This is a slow-burning story of wife-sharing for the first time, with a scorching finale.

### ***Working On Her Game***

Will has landed a lucrative position at a law firm in New Mexico, but the transition to the slow-moving, scorching Southwest has been a strain on his marriage. His wife has surprised him by taking up a new sport to fill her time. But it isn't long before the couple discover that Scarlett's new instructor can give her a lot more than just tennis lessons. Her dark, handsome tennis coach might have just the thing their marriage needs...

***Don't forget to check out *Game For More*, the sequel to *Working On Her Game****

### ***A Taste For Teasing***

Oren knows he's a lucky man with a hot wife: Monica is blond, stunning, and has a killer body. She was even a cheerleader in the NBA in her university days – and there are even more interesting jobs in her resume than that. But Monica is also a practical, down-to-earth, and happily married woman.

Things take a turn one year when they're vacationing with friends. Oren discovers that he has a taste for thinking about his wife with another man. And Monica has a taste for... well, something. Monica is becoming a hotwife before his eyes: but Oren can't be sure of *who* she's teasing. Is his fantasy coming true, or is it turning sour? Was there more to Monica's past than she ever let on? Is a hotwife really what he wants?

### ***Ela's Performance***

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their

own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

### *The Houseguest*

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

### *A Conventional Hotwife*

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

### *The Hotwife Summer*

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

### ***Body of Research***

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

### ***The Hobby Job***

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a “hobby job.” Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's “hobby job” make a hobby of their marriage?

### ***The Hotwife Tattoo***

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to his wife – maybe even himself?

# ***Interracial hotwife books by Arnica:***

## ***Interracial Hotwife Bundle***

Includes *The Tenant*, *Not Black and White*, and *Grand Slam* for \$5.99

## ***Claudia Changes Tack***

Mike is on his friends' luxury sailboat with his stunning blond wife Claudia, hoping for nothing more than to convince Claudia that sailing is enjoyable. It turns out that his friends are swingers, in the Caribbean for more than just the sailing. And it turns out that Claudia has a streak of voyeurism in her. The couple embark on a mild adventure of exploration and sexual reawakening on the warm, beautiful beaches of the Caribbean, and it seems like the ideal vacation.

## ***Grand Slam: An Interracial Hotwife Adventure***

Charles keeps a secret desire about his wife Zoe. Her sizzling beauty is typically hidden under scrubs and a hair bun, so his fantasy may never happen. But a wrong turn on a weekend getaway turns out to be the opening pitch of a very naughty game, and Zoe seems determined to knock it out of the park.

## ***The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel***

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with

the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

### *Not Black And White*

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken.

But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

### *Unlocking Noel: A Reluctant Hotwife Novel*

Pretty, bookish Noel is not exactly an adventurer in or out of the bedroom, and Spencer has come to accept that. But things take an unexpected turn one year at an annual ski vacation. When they return the following year, Spencer gets to work on unlocking Noel and her (literally) dark desires.



A romantic hotwife novel with a deliciously corruptible and reluctant heroine.

### *Lisa Plays Her Part*

Lisa and Luke married young because of an unexpected pregnancy, and Lisa never had much experience with other men as a result. But when a dark, handsome, wealthy man she almost slept with (and always wondered about) resurfaces in her life, Lisa is confronted with agonizing desires... and choices. Now that their nest is empty and they don't have the same reasons to stay together, will Lisa and Luke reconnect, or will Lisa choose to make this the final act of their marriage?

### *Megyn For The Win*

In Megyn's view, nothing could be sillier than entering a charity contest to win a "date" with the sexy black celebrity Max Riley, not even to raise money for underprivileged youth. (Un)fortunately for her, her friend entered her in the contest anyway.

When she wins, her husband Peter sees a chance to dip into a fantasy of his. But when this brush with fate turns into a very real, permanent job offer for Megyn – one that puts her in close and frequent contact with the famed black actor – the couple has a lot more to think about than just a winning a "date."

A romantic, interracial hotwife story with a win at the end!

## *Hotwife **Suspense** By Arnica Butler*

### *Nila's Long Con*

It began with a chance encounter with a man from his wife's past. Rich knew Tennile had some skeletons – of a sexual nature – in her closet, but he never dreamed they were going to come back to haunt them both. Before he can blink, the two of them are embroiled in high-stakes intrigue, with Tennile's reputation and career, their marriage, and a lot of money on the

line. There seems to be no way out but to play the game, and Tennile's past might be game-winning asset. In the style of *A Well-Laid Trap*, this is a thrilling hotwife ride that will keep you hooked until the end.

### *A Well-Laid Trap*

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...

## *Fun Summer Swinger Titles:*

### *Clothing Optional*

Sy Price and his wife find themselves in an unexpected situation when their Belize vacation resort turns out to be "Clothing Optional." They're even more surprised to find out that "Clothing Optional" is code for quite a bit more. They decide to make the best of things and enjoy their vacation. But there are a lot more surprises in store for Sy when Jackie decides to fully embrace the hotel amenities...

### *A Summer Vacation*

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along. Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

### *Try To Have Some Fun*

Helena and Steve's wealthy, sexy, swinger friends have returned to town. Helena has a child- and work-free stretch of summer ahead of her. There's nothing stopping her from spending her days relaxing by their spectacular pool. No reason not to borrow a tiny bikini, or to maybe sunbathe topless. Or skinny-dip at one of their wild parties. One thing, though, will probably lead to another...

## *Explore darker themes by Arnica Butler:*

### *Well-Constructed Affairs*

As a hot female construction engineer, John's wife Adria draws a lot of attention at the job site. Which isn't all bad. But when Adria opens the door for him to tell her about his sexual fantasies, he doesn't realize she has opened the door on her own – very dark – fantasy as well. A fantasy she hasn't shared with anyone until now. The couple are off on an exploration of their desires...but is their marriage well-constructed enough to withstand the forces of their fantasies?

### *Nikita Gets In Too Deep*

When Cole and his wife Nik arrive at their usual vacation spot in dull Cape Breton, they're taken by surprise by the most unlikely of next-door neighbors: ultra-sexy Paige and wealthy, commanding Mitch. And these new neighbors are full of surprises. Cole and Nik embark on new adventures in their marriage, trying new things and pushing boundaries they'd never even discussed. It's invigorating, but Cole can't help but wonder if his transformed wife hasn't gotten herself in too deep...

### *A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife*

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change

everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

### ***A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos***

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “*reliability*” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.